Backing into the Future:

A Professional Journey

An Autobiographical Guide to the Carlos E. Cortés Papers
in the University of California, Riverside,
Special Collections

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Chapters Pages

1: Opportunity Knocks 2
2: The Road to Riverside 10
3: The 1960's: Becoming a Historian 17
4: The 1970's: Lurching into K-12 Education 25
5: The 1980's: The All-Purpose Multiculturalist 48
6: The 1990's: Everybody's Adjunct 82
7: The 2000's: Curtain Going Up 108
8: The 2010's: Winding Down 134
9: The 2020's: Zombie Time 148
Postscript: My Collection 185

Chapter 1:

Opportunity Knocks

Brazilian President Getúlio Vargas, a central figure in my doctoral dissertation and later my first major book, *Gaúcho Politics in Brazil,* once summed up his political career as follows: "I am not an opportunist; I am one who takes advantage of opportunities." In some respects, that has also been a theme in my professional career. I have been afforded lots of opportunities and have taken advantage of many of them. The results have been . . . Well, I'm getting ahead of my story.

One of those opportunities came in the fall of 2024 when Steven Mandeville-Gamble, the head Librarian on my campus, the University of California, Riverside, asked me to donate my professional papers to the UCR Library's Special Collections. I was both honored and awed. Honored because my professional story would have a permanent home where others could peruse my comings and goings. Awed because it meant culling through the immense amount of stuff I have amassed during my more than fifty-five years at UCR (I began here in 1968).

As I began working my way through the material, something else struck me. My collection was thick, but inert. The letters, manuscripts, lecture notes, videotapes, and conference programs sat as lifeless, disparate factoids on my book shelves and in my file drawers. They had physical presence but lacked coherence or momentum. The collection needed historical context.

My first inclination was to write brief descriptions of the various items. However, that idea evaporated within

micro-seconds. At age 90, I would face a task that would take me until I turned 120. I needed a different strategy. This led me to the conclusion that the best way to bring those materials to life was to imbed them in a story, my story. After all, I am a professional historian. I've spent my life telling stories. Why not one more?

So I decided to create a hybrid document: a combination professional mini-autobiography and sort-of guide to the materials. The autobiography would provide the basic framework of my professional life. The references to the collection items would enable scholars and other interested parties to determine which materials were worth perusing for their disparate investigative endeavors. The document would also assist scholars in interpreting and assessing the various documents within the context of my own professional journey.

At first the idea seemed repetitive and wearying, mainly because I've already written extensively about my life. I've written a family-oriented memoir, *Rose Hill: An Intermarriage before Its Time* (Heyday, 2012). A one-person autobiographical play, *A Conversation with Alana: One Boy's Multicultural Rite of Passage* (Bad Knee Press, 2022), which I have performed nearly 160 times throughout the country. A book of poetry about aging, *Fourth Quarter: Reflections of a Cranky Old Man* (Bad Knee Press, 2016). A semi-autobiographical coming-of-age novel, *Scouts' Honor* (Inlandia, 2025). A book-length collection of reminiscences about my life and thinking, *Backing into the Future at 90: April 6, 2024,* which I wrote in response to questions posed by my grandchildren (although I didn't complete answering all of the questions until I was nearly 91) -- a sort of living will for generations that come after me.

Yet until now I've never written a professional autobiography. The closest I have come was *The Making -- and Remaking -- of a Multiculturalist* (Teachers' College Press, 2002). That book is a collection of some of my previous writings combined with extended introductions to each piece describing the context in which the pieces were written and my latter-day reflections on their significance. In other words, it was a book with autobiographical elements, but it fell far short of being a full professional autobiography. Moreover, it was published more than two decades ago, and much has happened in the interim.

So I decided to bite the bullet. I would try to contextualize my professional collection by finally writing a professional autobiography, of sorts. I say of sorts because something different occurred when I began to put "pen" to paper.

Writing then-to-now didn't work. Let me put it another way. *Thinking* then to now didn't work. My professional life contained too much disparate, seemingly-disconnected stuff to make any sense that way. I needed to approach my task from a different direction.

So I turned my life around. Instead of thinking of it past-to-present, I looked at my professional life backward from present-to-past. I chose notable moments in my life and asked the question: what things had to have happened prior to that event in order for that moment to occur? In that way my personal chronology became an attempt to answer those questions by illuminating the steps that influenced and sometimes altered my journey.

In the Beginning . . .

The process of reconstructing my professional career began with one basic factoid. In January, 1968, I began my college teaching career as a 33-year-old acting assistant professor of Latin American history at the University of California, Riverside. Starting with that factoid, I used my looking-backward strategy by addressing such questions as the following: by what process did that young professor become:

***a pioneer in ethnic studies, multicultural education, and bilingual education?

***a nationally-recognized expert on diversity in the media, culminating with his book, *The Children Are Watching: How the Media Teach about Diversity*?

***a columnist for numerous media outlets, including the magazine *Media & Values,* the monthly ezine *American Diversity Report,* the media giant Univision, and the *Riverside Press-Enterprise*?

***a multi-decade part-time faculty member for myriad institutions, including the Harvard Institutes for Higher Education, the Summer Institute for Intercultural Communication, the Federal Executive Institute, and the University of Maryland, College Park?

***a public lecturer who would speak in 48 U.S. states (minus Delaware and West Virginia) as well as throughout Europe, Asia, Australia, and the Americas?

***a playwright/actor who, among various theatrical endeavors, wrote and performed his one-person autobiographical play, *A Conversation with Alana: One Boy's Multicultural Rite of Passage,* more than 150 times in all corners of the United States?

***the Creative/Cultural Advisor for Nickelodeon's "Dora the Explorer" and "Go, Diego, Go!" and the Cultural Consultant for Dreamworks' film, "Puss in Boots: The Last Wish"?

***a cruise ship lecturer on comparative culture?

***at age 84, an inaugural fellow of the University of California's National Center for Free Speech and Civic Engagement?

***at age 86, the inaugural co-director of the UCR School of Medicine's Health Equity, Social Justice, and Anti-Racism curriculum?

***at age 87, the first UCR professor to receive the Constantine Panunzio Award for achievements by a systemwide University of California retired professor in the arts, humanities, and social sciences?

***at age 91, one of the small number of nonagenarian first-time published novelists in American history via *Scouts' Honor* (Inlandia, 2025)?

To address each of those questions, I had to work backward, creating timelines from speech to speech, from publication to publication, and from fortuitous moment to fortuitous moment. The answer to each question became a story unto itself. It was the story of placing myself in myriad situations, of being open to opportunities, and of being willing to take risks. Later (beginning in 2005) I would try to pass on some of that "wisdom" through my talk, "Learning to Be Lucky: Seven Ways to Control the Fates . . . Before They Control You."

Yet is that all there is? Was my professional career simply a collection of parallel (and sometimes intersecting) stories? Or could I discover an even greater there there? As I created and inspected these parallel timelines,

sometimes-unexpected intersections emerged, intersections that sometimes sent my life careening in unforeseen directions.

Through this reverse deconstruction of my life, my career began to make more sense than it did while I was living it. Previously-unrecognized patterns emerged. Launching pads for different adventures became more salient. My multiple professional directions began to become more coherent. I reveled in discovering serendipitous moments that would unexpectedly propel me into surprising adventures into unforeseen territory.

In many respects my career reflected what Helen Lewis, author of *The Genius Myth: A Curious History of a Dangerous Idea*, has called "the adjacent possible." That is, when one's personal qualities coincide with a time and place where opportunities exist to make the best use of those qualities. As I look back on my career, I was lucky enough to encounter many such moments when what I had to offer was fortuitously juxtaposed with opportunities in which I could make best use of those qualities.

In another lifetime, in another set of circumstances, I might never have had those opportunities. Had I taken a position at another university, for example, I might never have encountered moments when I could avail myself of the best of what I had to offer. But I did encounter many of those moments, pursued them for better and for worse, and as a result etched a career that in some respects may be very singular.

The Pursuit of Transparency

As I tried to resurrect and make sense of my professional life, I was further helped by a fortuitous decision I had made

early in my career. University of California regulations change constantly, including regulations and procedures regarding off-campus service and outside employment. As my off-campus endeavors grew, I decided that the best way to stay within those regulations was to be fastidiously transparent with the UCR administration. (In 1995, a year after my retirement, the University of California conducted a formal review of Academic Personnel Manual Section 025A on Outside Employment.)

As a result I began keeping a precise chronological record of my service efforts and annually submitted that record so that department chairs, deans, vice chancellors, and chancellors would be apprised of my efforts. That way they could inform me if they wanted me to limit them. But quite the opposite occurred. Administrators recognized (and sometimes lauded) my accomplishments and encouraged me to continue contributing to UCR's public visibility throughout the state, nation, and world. Even after I took early retirement at the end of June, 1994, I continued to maintain my chronological record. The result is that I now have a detailed longitudinal record of more than a half century of public and professional service, organized in yearly envelopes.

That fastidious record is now paying off. As I try to reconstruct my career by addressing the factors contributing to my achievements, those chronological records have become fundamental in my quest. I can now identity specific dates of events that contributed to fortuitous future avenues. At times those dates come as a surprise, correcting my all-to-human faulty memory of when events actually happened and in what order they took place. As I worked through those detailed lists and

packed envelopes, which are part of my archived professional papers, my misty professional life unveiled itself to me.

In addition, I wanted the administration to know more than *what* I was doing. I wanted it to know how *well* I was doing it and what *impact* I was having. To help do that I composed a letter that I distributed during some of my speaking visits asking my inviters to send letters of evaluation to my UCR administrators from the chancellor to my dean and department chair. This was my way of saying to the administration that I was delighted to have my service evaluated, not just enumerated.

A Pattern Emerges

As I re-reviewed my career, I concluded that it did have temporal coherence. Therefore, I decided to tell my story by decades, even while recognizing the potential artificiality of employing that organizing tool. Life does not operate nearly that neatly. However, the use of decades as an organizing tool provides a certain coherence to my professional journey and helps to make sense of my many adventures. In that sense, life has unspooled more or less as follows.

The 1960's: Becoming a historian.

The 1970's: Lurching into K-12 education.

The 1980's: Morphing into an all-purpose multiculturalist.

The 1990's: Becoming a national adjunct faculty member.

The 2000's: Gliding into the world of performance and entertainment.

The 2010's: Winding down.

The 2020's: Being reborn.

Helped by this organizing framework, this document is actually three things in one. First, it is my personal

professional story as best I can resurrect it, greatly based on documents and written records, but also relying at times on inevitably faulty human memory. Second, it is a series of musings about the trajectory of my still-developing beliefs and values. Third, it is a sort of context-setting guide to materials in my collection, a context which I hope makes the individual documents come to life and become more comprehensible.

The professional story actually begins in the 1960's. However, for my story to make sense, I feel it is important to first share with you the essence of what preceded those years. A fuller understanding of my pre-historian life may help shed light on the motivations, decisions, and actions that occurred once my professional life began. So on with the show.

Chapter Two:
The Road to Riverside

I, Carlos Eliseo Cortés, was born on April 6, 1934, in Oakland, California, in the heart of the Great Depression. My father, Carlos Federico Cortés, was the California-born, Guadalajara, Mexico-raised son of a Mexican father (also Carlos Eliseo Cortés, the first Latino graduate in the history of Stanford University, which opened its doors in 1891) and, a California-born mother of French ancestry, Reine Blum. My mother, Florence Hoffman Cortés, was the Kansas City-born daughter of a Ukrainian (then part of the Russian Empire) immigrant father, Morris Hoffman, and an Austrian immigrant mother, Ada Weinsaft.

Dad was Catholic; Mom was Jewish. As their oldest child (my brother Gary was nearly six years younger than I), I was the focus of constant religious conflict and tensions. When it came to social life, most of my friends operated within the unchallenged norms and rigid religious boundaries of the early post-World War II Midwest. (In those days it was standard practice for parents to ask boys what church they went to when arriving to pick up their daughters for dates.) I always felt like an outsider among both my Jewish and my Christian friends. I relate this story in my memoir, *Rose Hill,* and my one-personal autobiographical play, *A Conversation with Alana.*

My home was trilingual, sort of. Dad taught me the rudiments of Spanish. Mom, along with Grandma and Granddad Hoffman, taught me the rudiments of Yiddish, the common language of Eastern European Jews and their courtship language. As the only family member who could at least defend himself in three

languages, I often found myself in tri-lingual conversations, usually arguments. Language diversity was not just a source of personal enrichment; it was also a source of family intercultural conflict.

During the first year of my life, my folks moved from northern California to Kansas City, Missouri, so that my mother could become part of her family support system. Both Mom and Dad were graduates of the University of California, Berkeley, but jobs were tough to come by for a history major like Dad. In California he worked as an auto mechanic in a service station. In Kansas City he became a traveling tire salesman for Firestone.

Then, in December, 1941, Japan bombed Pearl Harbor and the United States entered World War II. At age seven, one of my first vivid memories was listening to radio reports of the bombing from Honolulu along with my family. Dad tried to enlist in the Navy, but was turned down because of incipient gangrene in his leg.

Granddad Hoffman, who had started a small construction business in the 1920's, bid on a federal contract to help build Sedalia Army Air Field (now Whiteman Air Force Base) near Knobnoster, Missouri. It was a glider base where troops would be trained for the invasion of Europe. When Granddad received the contract, he recruited Dad because of his automotive background, asking him to join the company and become transportation superintendent for the project. Dad agreed and later stayed on with the company, ultimately becoming vice president.

I graduated from high school in 1952 and followed in my folks' footsteps by going to the University of California,

Berkeley (they were both Cal graduates). I had developed some interest in astronomy, so I began with the idea of majoring in either physics or chemistry. However, by the end of my freshman year I found myself bored with those prospects and became what in those days was known as an Undecided major.

My sophomore year was filled with course work that I truly loved: literature, philosophy, history, art, music. Yet as the year progressed I knew I had to make a decision on a major. In those days the idea of taking more than four years to graduate was unthinkable, so I went to the campus counseling center, which put me through a battery of tests to determine my interests. These turned out to be disparate and unfocused, maybe an omen for my future. Fortunately, one counselor perused the courses that I had taken and identified a major, Communications and Public Policy, which I could complete in the next two years. In those days it was called a group major; later such majors would be re-titled as interdisciplinary. The major involved courses in such areas as communications, political science, and psychology. The result: I graduated on time in the spring of 1956.

By then my career ideas had begun to solidify. At Cal I became the editor of the *Blue and Gold*, the Cal yearbook, and was elected chair of the Student Publications Board (one of my close friends on the board was Joan Didion, then an aspiring creative writer and Ca literary magazine editor). Drawing on my major and my student publications experience, I decided on a media career. So here was my master plan: I would get a master's in journalism, work in media for a few years, and then go to law school to specialize in media law.

With that in mind, I applied to and was accepted into the Columbia Graduate School of Journalism beginning in the fall of 1956. It was an intense year in which I earned an M.S. in Journalism. I also worked at odd jobs, from refereeing intramural basketball and volleyball games to selling libretti two nights a week at the Metropolitan Opera.

My mother was an amateur opera singer and had raised me with a love for opera, so the Met job was ideal. As soon as the overture began, we libretti salesmen (all men) would turn in our proceeds and go directly to the Family Circle (third balcony), where we could stand and watch the performance. If some of the seats were empty, we could take them. Of course, when Maria Callas was singing "Tosca" or "Lucia di Lamermoor," it was no such luck.

I also indulged my love of theatre by going to Broadway or off-Broadway shows nearly every week, viewing them from the cheapest of seats. Then one day I spotted a notice on the school job board for a part-time position working for a theatrical press agent named Frank Goodman. I applied for the position, was interviewed, and was offered the job: mainly writing press releases and theatre programs.

My major assignment was the American Shakespeare Festival, whose summer theatre was in nearby Stratford, Connecticut. Immediately after graduation in the spring of 1957 I moved to Stratford, where I worked as Frank's liaison with Don Glenn, who handled on-site publicity for the festival. (During the rest of the year he managed the Shubert Theatre in New Haven, Connecticut.)

It was an amazing summer. As luck would have it, I found myself doing publicity for and getting to know such festival

stars as Katharine Hepburn, Alfred Drake (the Broadway lead of "Oklahoma"), and others who would go on to solid entertainment careers, such as a very young Richard Cavett. Don Glenn asked me if I would join him as assistant director of the Shubert Theatre during the following year. I said yes, but the U.S. Army had other ideas.

In those days, universal military service was a requirement for young men. I had received a military deferment to go to college, but deferment time was over. In September, 1957, as soon as the festival's summer season ended, I entered the Army.

After completing basic training at Fort Leonard Wood, Missouri, I was transferred to the Signal Corps Center at Fort Gordon on the outskirts of Augusta, Georgia. There I would complete the opening stages of training to become an Army cryptographer. However, to move on to the next level of training, we had to receive security clearances. When my cohort had finished its preliminary training and most of my friends moved on to more highly classified training, my clearance hadn't come through. It never did. Later I learned that having three immigrant grandparents, including one from Ukraine, then part of the Soviet Union, made my receiving a security clearance virtually impossible within my two-year active duty period.

Fortunately I had an M.S. in Journalism, so I was re-assigned to the Signal Corps Public Information Office at Fort Gordon. For the remaining twenty-one months I did publicity for the Army. Instead of stories about Katharine Hepburn, I wrote about the Officers' Wives Club (no sign of gender equity in those days). Not to worry. President Dwight Eisenhower occasionally came down to Augusta for brief stays to play golf at the Augusta National Golf Club, where he was a

member. During those times I would handle some of the publicity for his visits and got to meet the President.

With twenty-one months of Fort Gordon service staring me in the face, I knew I had to do something in town to avoid going stir crazy on base. I learned that the Augusta Players local theatre group was holding tryouts. I had acted in high school, so I auditioned for and got a role in "Ring Round the Moon," the first of several plays I did during my Augusta stay. The theatre bug that I had caught in New York was being nurtured. This connection also opened the doors for a most enjoyable non-Army social life with local women.

On top of that, one of my Columbia U. friends, Steve Gelman, had become an editor with the monthly *Sport Magazine*. He asked if I would be interested helping them with a story about Art Wall, a professional golfer famous for his holes in one. Wall was about to play the 1959 Masters Tournament, so Steve asked me to interview Wall and follow him throughout the tournament. I took two days of Army leave and for four days walked with Wall throughout the tournament. Talk about luck. Wall actually won the Masters, providing the core of the story that appeared in *Sport*. Maybe just as important, being a member of the working press made me eligible for the one-day press tournament on the Monday following the Masters, so I actually got to play a round at the fabled Augusta National golf course.

Luck was becoming an integral part of my life. When would it strike next? It wouldn't be long.

When I got out of the Army in September, 1959, I had vague plans to go back to New York City. In fact, a couple of months earlier I had spent a week in New York scouting for job possibilities. I was interviewed for the media relations

department of the Metropolitan Opera and met with Frank Goodman, my old press agent boss, who had just landed a contract to represent a new musical, "The Sound of Music."

But first it was back to Kansas City for a visit with my folks. Earlier that year they had spent a couple of weeks on a dude ranch in Tucson, Arizona, and Mom asked if I would drive her back down to Tucson for a week's relaxation. I did and found that I loved the warm, arid Arizona fall weather. On a whim I applied for a job with the Tucson daily newspaper. There were no openings, so I zipped up to Phoenix to see if its dailies had any openings. Same answer.

Then luck reared its head again. As I drove down Van Buren Boulevard from the Arizona Republic office, I spotted a squat one-story building with a sign in the window reading "Editor Wanted." Why not? I turned, parked behind the building, walked in, introduced myself, was interviewed by the owner, and within an hour found myself as the new editor of the Phoenix Sunpapers, a chain of weekly newspapers spanning the Valley of the Sun.

Thus began a short but eventful Phoenix stay. I edited the newspaper chain for two years. I met and ultimately married Murielle Bunt, an undergraduate student at nearby Arizona State University. And I met William Lytle Schurz, who would change my career directions.

Chapter Three:
The 1960's -- Becoming a Historian

In my role as editor, I met and soon became friends with a young man named Ray Olding, publicity director for a major local shopping center. Ray then moved on to become public relations director for a small school on the outskirts of Phoenix called the American Institute for Foreign Trade (it later became the Thunderbird Graduate School for International Management before ultimately being absorbed by Arizona State University). Ray urged me to come out to AIFT to interview William Schurz, director of area studies and an eminent Latin American historian.

Bill and I shared a multi-decade generation gap, but despite that we hit it off beautifully. Following my article on him, his Phoenix home became a regular stop. There he kindled my interest in Latin America, particularly Brazil, his specialty. Before long he suggested that I become an AIFT student for its one-year degree program leading to a Bachelor's of Foreign Trade and serve as his student assistant.

So be it. Journalism faded as a career goal. Latin America took its place. In February of 1961 I gave up my Phoenix Sunpapers editorship and returned to school at AIFT. I had learned some Spanish from my father and had studied it in high school, but my fascination with Brazil led me to emphasize intensive Portuguese at AIFT. In no time I fell in love with the language's richness and musicality.

Bill Schurz also encouraged me to follow my new dreams and pursue graduate school. I applied for a number of grants, ultimately securing a three-year National Defense Foreign

Language Fellowship to go to the University of New Mexico. The federal government considered Portuguese to be a critical defense language in the ongoing struggle with the Soviet Union. I became a beneficiary of the Cold War.

In the summer of 1962 I started graduate school at UNM, entering the Ph.D. program in Ibero-American Studies. However, by the end of that first year my focus had sharpened. For the next two years I simultaneously studied for an M.A. in Portuguese and Spanish and a Ph.D. in History. I completed my M.A. in the spring of 1965, writing a thesis on politics in the works of esteemed Brazilian novelist Graciliano Ramos (a thesis that is still being cited). Later that summer I completed my pre-dissertation history doctoral exams.

In the meantime I had received a Ford Foundation Foreign Area doctoral dissertation fellowship to spend eighteen months in Brazil, preceded by a one-semester pre-departure residency (fall of 1965) at my old haunt, Columbia University. In the spring of 1966 my wife and I headed off to Brazil, where we spent a year in the country's southernmost state capital, Pôrto Alegre, and some six months in Rio de Janeiro. During that time I conducted research leading to my doctoral dissertation on the post-1930 political history of the important state of Rio Grande do Sul. I completed the dissertation in 1969 (the book adaptation was later published in English and Portuguese).

While I was in Brazil, opportunity struck again. Returning from several weeks of research in the Rio Grande do Sul interior, I encountered a January, 1967, letter from the University of California, Riverside, asking if I would be interested in a history teaching position. This was despite the fact that I had not yet set up a personnel file or published a

research paper. My teaching experience consisted of one semester as a volunteer teaching assistant for Modern Latin American History, taught by my dissertation advisor, Edwin Lieuwen.

So how did I get that job offer? Blind luck, combined with the way things worked in the good old days. It was called the old boys' network for good reason.

A UCR senior professor named Robert Hine had gone to the American Historical Association national conference, where he ran into his long-time friend Gerald Nash, a UNM American history professor and member of my doctoral committee. I had taken two courses from Gerry. He liked my work, especially a research paper I wrote on U.S. diplomatic involvement in a virtually unknown early twentieth-century minor war between Brazil and Bolivia over a piece of secluded Amazonian territory known as Acre. So when Bob Hine asked Gerry Nash if he knew of any good candidates for UCR's Latin American history teaching position, Gerry suggested me. The department followed up that chance encounter by securing letters of recommendation and other information on me.

I have no idea how many other candidates the UCR History Department considered. I did learn that it favored someone specializing in Brazil. (The current Acting Assistant Professor had failed to complete his doctoral dissertation in time and was being terminated at the end of that academic year. Had he completed his dissertation, I would have not ended up at UCR.) Whatever, without a file, without publications, with little teaching experience, and without an interview, the department reached out to me.

Correspondence began with a couple of preliminary letters, which I always sent in duplicate because of the unpredictable Brazilian mail system, Bob sent me UCR employment forms and indicated that I should fill them out if I were interested in the position. Why not? I had never been to the campus, but UCR seemed like a decent place to start my teaching career. I filled out the papers, sent them back, and soon received notification that I had been approved as an Acting Assistant Professor, the Acting to be removed assuming I completed my dissertataion by June, 1969, the end of my second teaching year.

I was so nonchalant about the offer that I immediately wrote back asking for the fall, 1967, quarter off so that I could stay in Brazil for three more months of research. The department agreed to my request. (Keep in mind that all of this was done by snail mail. Telephone communications between Brazil and the United States were iffy, at best, and horrendously expensive. We didn't have phone service in our Brazilian apartment and for eighteen months my wife and I did not once telephone our families. Not once.)

So in late November, 1967, my wife and I returned to the United States (we landed in the United States on Thanksgiving Day) and in late December, 1967 we arrived in Riverside. The next month, January, 1968, my teaching career began. My future seemed set. I would teach Latin American history (I quickly grew to love teaching), do research about Brazil (which I also thoroughly enjoyed), and write (which had become second nature due to my Berkeley, Columbia, Fort Gordon, and Phoenix experiences).

But the times they were changing. Fate would soon alter my plans, radically. In this case, fate came in the form of the Chicano Movement.

Viva la Raza

Shortly after I arrived at UCR I received a phone call from another UCR professor, who introduced himself as Eugene Cota-Robles. It turns out that he was an internationally eminent microbiologist. The voice asked me a simple question: was I a Mexican American?

I had never given that much thought. My dad was Mexican and I respected my Mexican heritage. But I had never thought much about the idea of "being ethnic," even during my three years at UNM where the Hispanic presence was palpable. I was just Carlos, a guy with a Mexican Catholic father and an Austro-Ukrainian Jewish mother, which I explained to Gene. That was good enough, he concluded, so we agreed to meet for lunch at the Student Commons cafeteria.

When I arrived at the Commons I spotted a short, slender, brown-skinned man looking around. I walked toward him, but he didn't seem to notice this pasty-faced six-footer who was coming his way. It turns out that this became standard operating procedure for my subsequent life, showing up for things with my light Anglicized features and a Spanish surname, thereby confounding expectations and creating cognitive dissonance.

As a matter of fact, this situation became so common that I developed a set of responses. Once I was on a televised panel facilitated by a well-known national newsman. Imagining himself to be oh-so-clever, he introduced me by adding, "You don't look

Mexican," to which I replied something like "You must not know many Mexicans."

Another time I was invited to give a keynote address at a California statewide education conference. My contact person had never met me. When I showed up at the conference and introduced myself, his face fell. Then he said what others may have felt but stifled: "Uh, I was hoping for someone a little, uh, darker." With help from Neil Simon's "The Goodbye Girl," I had a ready response: "This year I'm working on younger. Next year I'll work on darker."

But back to UCR. I finally went up to Gene and introduced myself. He seemed a bit surprised by my appearance, but we quickly hit it off. Over lunch, Gene filled me in about the Chicano presence on campus, particularly the fact that I was the second Mexican American faculty member in campus history. Added to Gene, I had doubled UCR's Chicano professorial contingent.

Gene made two requests. He was coordinating something called the Educational Opportunity Program for poor and underrepresented students. Would I be willing to assist him in the effort? And he was helping UCR's relative handful of Mexican American students (about 100 on a campus of 4,500) form a student organization. Would I help him in that effort, too?

There were myriad reasons for me to say no. I had just arrived at UCR. Because of my limited previous teaching experience, I was creating all new courses from scratch. I had just returned from Brazil with lots of research material but without a single word written on my dissertation, which I had to complete by June, 1969, or lose my position. And my wife was pregnant.

The smart thing would have been to say no. But instead I said yes. That would become a recurring sequence in my professional life.

I'm still not certain why I said yes. I had never been a social activist nor been deeply involved in Mexican American affairs. But something about Gene's appeal resonated with me. I said yes because I had to say yes and never looked back.

Now that Gene had involved me in the Chicano movement, I took a crash course on Chicano affairs. I helped Gene organize UCR's United Mexican American Students (it later became MeCha) and attended several southern California Chicano conferences. I also audited UCR's only course on Chicanos, Chicano Sociology, taught by Joan Moore, who had just co-authored a major study of Mexican Americans.

By that time all hell was breaking loose on college campuses, including anti-Vietnam war and pro-ethnic studies protests. Although there was relatively little student activism at UCR, Chancellor Ivan Hinderaker wanted to get ahead of the game on ethnic studies. In the winter of 1969 Dean Carlo Golino of the College of Letters and Science formed a committee led by political scientist Charles Adrian to consider the establishment of an ethnic studies major. Still an Acting Assistant Professor, I was asked me to be a member.

Fortunately by that time my doctoral dissertation was nearly done. I had written all through the summer of 1968, submitted a draft of my doctoral dissertation in the fall, and received comments indicating that it needed only minor changes. So with those changes completed and that hurdle behind me, meaning that the Acting would be removed from my Assistant

Professor title on July 1, 1969, I accepted the committee assignment.

Our new committee quickly decided that it did not want an Ethnic Studies major, but rather separate majors in Mexican American and Black Studies. The Dean agreed and split us into two separate committees. By the spring of 1969 we had developed parallel degree program proposals, which were approved by the UCR Academic Senate with only minor opposition.

Both Ivan (Chancellor Hinderaker) and Gene asked if I would be willing to be the inaugural chair of Mexican American Studies. I had been saying yes rather consistently, but this was a bridge too far. I had to concentrate on getting tenure, so I declined the offer. However, I did agree to establish a Chicano History course in the winter quarter of 1970, although I had never taken a class on the topic (there were no such courses at the University of New Mexico while I was there from 1962 to 1965). And in 1970 I accepted the chairmanship of UCR's small Latin American Studies interdisciplinary B.A. program, serving for two years.

My involvement with Mexican American Studies (a few years later it was renamed Chicano Studies) soon became an issue among senior professors in the history department. Some were supportive, but others explicitly warned me that it might jeopardize my career. In fact, throughout the next twenty-five years I became accustomed to split votes on my personnel cases because of my professional choices. However, I decided that it was a risk I was willing to take. The cause of social justice was just too strong.

Then there was a familial side note. Through a process too byzantine to recount, my father had become Associate Vice

Chairman of the Kansas Republican Party (my father, who had been a lifelong Democrat and part of the 1960 Viva Kennedy campaign). We now had a new bond. In family gatherings, Dad and I talked endlessly about Chicano affairs, probably to the disgruntlement of the rest of my family.

Within a decade I had morphed from a directionless novice journalist spotting an editor wanted sign in a Phoenix window into a professor of history on a University of California campus. I had earned a Ph.D. in Latin American history in 1969, but simultaneously found myself involved in an entirely new world, the inchoate field of Chicano Studies. I soon found my interest in Brazilian history receding as I got swept up in the Chicano movement. Finally, a new bond had been created between me and my Mexican father, who proudly introduced me to his Mexican American friends "my son, a professor of Chicano history."

Time, place, and my willingness to pursue new directions had changed the course of my professional life. But there was much more to come. A set of fortuitous circumstances in the 1970's would draw me still further away from traditional history and into the mysterious world of K-12 education.

Chapter 4

The 1970's: Lurching into K-12 Education

First things first. Having received my Ph.D. in June, 1969, and removing the dreaded "Acting" in front of Assistant Professor, I dedicated myself to earning tenure. At that point I had only one book-length publication: *Bibliografia da História do Rio Grande do Sul (Período Republicano).* I had co-edited that bibliography in Pôrto Alegre with fellow graduate student Richard Kornweibel (later a professor at California State University, Sacramento). It was published in 1967 by the Faculdade de Filosofia of the Universidade Federal do Rio Grande do Sul.

After completing my Ph.D., I focused on converting my doctoral dissertation into a book. It was published in 1974 by the University of New Mexico Press as *Gaúcho Politics in Brazil: The Politics of Rio Grande do Sul, 1930-1964* and later that year received the Hubert Herring Memorial Award of the Pacific Coast Council on Latin American Studies. Fast forward thirty-three years to 2007, my book was translated into Portuguese and published in Pôrto Alegre by the Pontificia Universidade Católica Press do Rio Grande do Sul as *Política Gaúcha (1930-1964).* My Latin American scholarly cupboard wasn't overflowing, but it wasn't bare.

That book helped me get promoted to Associate Professor with tenure in 1972. As an aside, I should point out that at that time one book could earn you tenure at UCR and there were many full professors who had written only a single book. UCR was still moving from its 1954 founding identity as an undergraduate-focused teaching institution (sometimes known as

the Swarthmore of the West) toward becoming a full-scale research-oriented campus.

Yet even as I completed my book, the 1970's were leading me in other directions full of surprises, opportunities, and career-bending decisions. In particular, those years pulled me in three directions. First, obviously, was the area of ethnic studies, particularly Chicano Studies. Second was the soon-to-be field of multicultural education. Third was the barely-launched idea of bilingual education.

Ethnic Studies

The Ethnic Studies movement erupted in the second half of the 1960's, often driven by student protests. The impetus was simple. We -- meaning what was then referred to as minority groups -- have been excluded from the telling of the U.S. story. We want a place in that story, on our terms.

When Chicano and Black Studies began at UCR in the fall of 1969, those programs consisted mainly of courses taught by faculty trained in other disciplines. How could that be otherwise? Case in point: I had been trained in Latin American history and was now teaching Chicano History.

In the winter of 1970, I inaugurated my course in Chicano History, the first time it had been offered at UCR. I have no way of immersing myself in the psyches of the several dozen students, mainly Chicanos, who found their way into my classroom. What did they think when this pale-skinned guy named Carlos Cortés walked in and proposed to tell them about the Chicano experience? What could he know? How could he know it? What was his background and personal experience?

The students were right to be skeptical. Teaching that class was an exercise in audacity. The only course on Chicanos that I had ever taken came a year earlier when I audited sociologist Joan Moore's class on Chicano Sociology. I had been raised in a middle class Midwestern home distant from Kansas City's Chicano community. Prior to arriving at UCR, my life trajectory had only tangentially involved the Chicano experience.

But I had studied Mexican history in graduate school and had immersed myself in the then relatively sparse published Chicano scholarship. That first year I did my best. As I look back on my early course lectures, I recognize the limitations of my inaugural effort. Yet from a socio-cultural perspective -- meeting students where they were in their personal journeys -- the course was a major success. It also launched me into ethnic studies as a scholarly discipline.

After I turned down the Chicano Studies chairmanship in the spring of 1969, microbiologist Gene Cota-Robles, a human dynamo, chaired Mexican American Studies (its original name) during the 1969-1970 academic year. He also recruited veteran psychologist Alfredo Castañeda to join UCR as chair in 1970. Castañeda stayed for two years before moving on to Stanford. While here he recruited several new Chicano Studies faculty members on joint appointments with other departments.

Chicano Studies Chairmanship

When Al announced in 1972 that he was leaving for Stanford, I faced a critical decision. Chicano Studies was booming around the country. Moreover, there weren't many faculty members with Ph.D.'s and Chicano Studies expertise to staff the expanding

programs. Almost overnight I found myself in demand, receiving feelers from numerous other universities and offers from UC San Diego and Pomona College. The latter also involved the enticing addition of becoming director of the multi-college Chicano Studies Center of the Claremont Colleges.

Learning about those offers, a group of UCR Chicano students came to my home. All were products of my Chicano History class. The students asked me to stay and become chair of Mexican American Studies when Castañeda left. What would it take to keep me at UCR?

Obviously it would require promotion to Associate Professor with tenure. I informed both my department and Chancellor Hinderaker about the situation. My personnel case was accelerated, leading to my promotion to Associate Professor with tenure in 1972. This was three years after completing my dissertation and with my book still two years away from publication.

But there was another issue. I had observed the chairing styles and departmental structures under Eugene Cota-Robles and Alfredo Castañeda. Each was unique, but under both leaders much of campus Chicano stuff was centralized under Mexican American Studies. When approached to become chair, I made it clear: I wanted Mexican American Studies to become a truly academic department, not an unofficial part-time Student Affairs unit. As a condition for my accepting the chairmanship, the administration would have to create a full-time Chicano Student Affairs position operating independently from Mexican American Studies.

The administration agreed. At the same time that I assumed the Mexican American Studies chairmanship, Chicano Student

Programs came into existence under the full-time directorship of UCR staff member Alberto Chávez. Al reported to the Dean of Students.

However, his office sat directly across from Mexican American Studies and adjoining what would become "El Centro," the one-room Chicano Student Center in the South Wing of the UCR Library Building (a basement-to-roof wall separated the new Library's public book space from the temporary office wing where a number of departments, including history, had their offices). Al coordinated multiple student and staff-related activities, including the Chicano graduation dinner to honor families of the graduates the night before the main campus commencement ceremony, which the students and their families also attended.

A couple of years after I became chair, a group of students took over my chair's office and demanded that we change the program name from Mexican American to Chicano Studies. That was fine with me, although as I explained to them I couldn't do it on the spot. (I can't recall why Mexican American Studies was selected as the program name in the spring of 1969.) We voted on the name change and, after we complied with the required process, we became Chicano Studies with little controversy.

My main challenge was to build curricular coherence from the disciplinary skills and knowledge of the handful of young faculty, all on joint appointments with traditional departments. After the departure of Cota-Robles and Castañeda, psychologist Manuel Ramírez III was the only other tenured Chicano faculty member. For purposes of personnel reviews I formed a cross-campus committee involving supportive tenured faculty members who met with Manuel and me.

Al Chávez and I also created an unofficial parallel structure. Chicano Student Programs was separate from Mexican American Studies, but Al and I agreed on the importance of building a campuswide Chicano community. We did so mainly through an all-campus, everybody's-welcome, hour-long gathering each Wednesday in the Chicano Student Center next to Al's office, where we discussed the role of Chicanos across campus. Occasionally we hosted national luminaries who were visiting campus, such as Wilcomb Washburn, Michael Novak, and John Rechy. My old UC Berkeley friend, Joan Didion (we served together on the Cal Student Publications Board), gave UCR's 1975 commencement address, but she arrived too late in the year to be our guest.

Over those first few years (I served as Chicano Studies Chair until December, 1979), the degree program established three operative principles: inclusivity; comparativism; and cooperation. Chicano students provided the natural constituency for our courses, but we also wanted to expand our appeal to non-Chicano students, which we did quite successfully. We felt that it was important for non-Chicanos to be exposed to the Chicano experience. *Intentional inclusivity* became a goal of structuring our courses.

One of the ways to pursue greater inclusivity was through adopting a *comparative framework*. Obviously the Chicano experience was the focus of our courses. However, we also decided that we could enhance an understanding of that experience by drawing consistently on comparisons with other ethnic experiences. We even created a set of courses that were explicitly comparative. I initiated a class on The Chicano Experience in Comparative Context, which attracted an

ethnically-mixed student cohort. Other faculty did likewise with their courses.

Here is one example of integrating comparativity into our courses. In my Chicano History classes I required a research paper, which could be fulfilled via various options. This included writing a history of one's own family or of a Chicano family other than one's own. Alternatively, students could conduct research on a different Chicano history topic.

During one of my early renditions of the course -- maybe even that first year of winter, 1970 -- a young Irish American student came up to me and asked a probing question. Could she write her paper about her own family? I hesitated, then told her I would give it some thought.

How could I turn down such a sincere request from a student who wanted to learn more about her own ethnic roots, a quest which many of the Chicano students were pursuing? So I approved her request with one caveat. It was a Chicano history class, so she could write her family paper, but she would also need to place that story in comparative context with the Chicano experience that we were studying in the course. She accepted the caveat and submitted an excellent paper.

That experience caused me to modify my course requirements, explicitly adding that option to the research paper assignment. While still focused on Chicanos, my course became both more inclusive and more comparative. It fulfilled two dimensions of the operative principles that Chicano Studies was developing.

Then there was a final principle, cooperation. We were a small program with a handful of faculty holding half-time Chicano Studies appointments. If we were to make the most of

our resources, we had to look for opportunities to cooperate with other departments.

The UCR School of Education had an M.A. option in which it worked jointly with a number of UCR departments. I collaborated with the Dean of Education to add Chicano Studies to the list, a proposal approved by the Academic Senate. Graduate students could now earn an M.A. in Education and Chicano Studies, where they would take half of their course work in each unit. According to the School of Education's parameters, that course work would have to include a graduate seminar in the cooperating department. So in winter, 1974, we launched a two-quarter Chicano Studies graduate research seminar entitled Interpreting the Mexican American Experience. I taught the course annually as an overload, meaning it was in addition to my normal teaching assignment. (During my seven years as Chicano Studies Chair I taught a one or two-course overload every year.)

Then there was the matter of college graduation requirements. In cooperation with the new Department of Literatures and Languages, we succeeded in passing an Ethnic and Area Studies college graduation requirement. It consisted of requiring all students to take at least two courses about the topics of ethnicity and/or foreign areas. Twice we repelled faculty efforts to eliminate that requirement.

For seven and one-half years I chaired UCR's Chicano Studies Program. It was time well spent. Thousands of students took our courses. Students graduated with B.A's and M.A's in Chicano Studies. We helped establish an Ethnic and Area Studies graduation requirement in our college. By the time I retired as chair in December, 1979, most of the assistant professors in the department had earned tenure.

But more than seven years of Chicano Studies chairing during the early stages of my career had worn me down. Added to that was the fact that each year I taught a two-course overload because our curriculum needed it. By 1979 I was tired and ready to move on to other things.

Chicano Studies Scholarship

Administrative efforts had dominated much of my Chicano Studies time. Yet I had not neglected Chicano Studies scholarship. Once again opportunity presented itself, in this case involving my friend and mentor, sociologist Joan Moore. Having recently co-authored a landmark study on Mexican Americans, Joan was much in demand. Then along came Arno Press, which published large collections of reprinted books. Arno asked Joan if she would edit a book collection on Mexican Americans. She declined and instead recommended me to be the editor. Arno agreed.

I turned to one of the History Department's senior members, Edwin Gaustad, who had published two series of religious studies book reprints with Arno. He encouraged me to accept the offer, which I did. It turned out to be an immensely time-consuming venture, requiring me to wade through myriad out-of-print materials in order to make my reprint selections.

However, it was a fortuitous journey. That time-intensive venture grounded me in the nooks and crannies not only of the Chicano experience, but also more broadly of U.S. Hispanics. By 1980 I had published not one but three Arno Press book reprint series: *The Mexican American* (21 volumes, 1974); *The Chicano Heritage* (55 volumes, 1976); and *Hispanics in the United States* (30 volumes, 1980).

At the same time I was beginning to expand my scope beyond Chicano Studies into Ethnic Studies writ large. In 1976, Putnam's published my co-edited anthology, *Three Perspectives on Ethnicity: Blacks, Chicanos, and Native Americans*. This book along with my Arno collections unofficially put me on the ethnic studies map.

National and international invitations began to come in. When Harvard decided to publish the *Harvard Encyclopedia of American Ethnic Groups* (1980), the editors asked me to write a 25,000-word major entry on Mexicans (my entry manuscript was 113 pages long). When the Fulbright Committee and the University of Zagreb held a week-long International Seminar on Ethnicity in the United States in Dubrovnik, Yugoslavia (now Croatia) in the fall of 1980, I was invited both to give the conference keynote and to give a plenary talk on Mexican Americans.

Then there were other serendipitous happenings. In 1970, UCR hired a young Chicano political scientist named Mario Barrera, who soon became a good friend of mine. He and I also shared an interest in movies. Mario had a friend named R. Alex Campbell, a professional filmmaker then working in the San Francisco Bay area. Mario invited Alex down to Riverside, where the three of us hatched the idea of making a film on some aspect of Chicano history. But we needed a concept and, of course, money.

Serendipity moved in. At that time the United States was preparing for its massive bicentennial celebration of the 1776 American Revolution. The National Endowment for the Humanities had a grant program for 1776-oriented creative projects.

The three of us came up with the idea of offering a Mexican perspective on the 1776 narrative. We would do so through a

documentary re-creation of the 1776 expedition from northern New Spain (later Mexico) to San Francisco led by Spanish explorer Juan Bautista de Anza. That expedition happened to pass through the land that would become Riverside and ended up in San Francisco, where it founded a Catholic mission. We proposed the project to the NEH, which funded us with a $26,000 grant. Mario, Alex, and I formed a corporation, Matrix Media, and named the film "Northwest from Tumacácori" (referencing one of the towns from which the expedition was launched).

The hour-long film was a shoestring production, a true labor of love. Alex and I wrote the script. We shot much of it over two days at a historic mission near Santa Barbara. As we didn't have actors, our small crew's arms and legs appear throughout to suggest expedition members. We hired professionals to narrate the film and provide Anza's voice.

The film was hardly a blockbuster, but we did show it at numerous conferences and workshops. We talked about making more films together, but we soon moved off in different directions. I built upon that experience in a number of articles, including a 1976 *Educational Leadership* piece entitled, "Need for a Geo-Cultural Perspective in the Bicentennial." In any respect, the movie allowed me to get my feet wet in the area of moving-image media, which would ultimately become one of my major areas.

One final Chicano history venture had a less happy ending. I hatched the idea of recruiting UCR students to conduct research about local Chicano history in the Riverside-San Bernardino Inland Empire. For over a year we worked on the project, with different students writing chapters on Riverside, San Bernardino, Redlands, and Colton. We even came up with a

book title, "The Bent Cross," suggesting the physical relationship of the four communities. The fall, 1970, issue of *Aztlán: Chicano Journal of the Social Sciences and the Arts,* published my article on our project, "CHICOP: A Response to the Challenge of Local Chicano History."

When the student authors moved away from Riverside into other ventures, it was up to me to complete the book. I failed. I'm not sure why. Maybe I had taken on too many professional responsibilities, so some things had to be set aside. "The Bent Cross" became a victim of my over-commitment.

Over the years I periodically thought of returning to the manuscript and giving it another try, but I never have. Dropping the ball on the project is probably one of the biggest disappointments of my professional career, not just because the book was never published, but also because I had let down the fine young people who worked so hard on the project. Nevertheless, chapters of the manuscript-in-progress are part of my professional collection.

Multicultural Education

My ethnic studies efforts were a natural outgrowth of my immersion in Chicano Studies. Less natural or inevitable were my forays into two other new fields: multicultural education and bilingual education. Whereas Chicano Studies lay within the higher education dimension of my professional career, the other two journeys led me into a brand new experience: K-12 education. In both cases serendipity played an enormous role.

In the spring of 1971, Mexican American Studies chair Alfredo Castañeda, his scholarly partner psychologist Manuel Ramírez III, political scientist Mario Barrera, and I organized

a major educational conference, Mexican Americans and Educational Change. Held at UCR on May 21-22, 1971, it drew a huge statewide and even national audience. The conference proceedings were published later that year as *Mexican Americans and Educational Change*, with me as co-editor, and then reprinted in my first Arno Press series.

In a May 22 plenary session I delivered a paper entitled "Revising the 'All-American Soul Course': A Bicultural Avenue to Educational Reform." At that point, ethnic studies courses were being labeled snidely by critics as "soul courses." In other words, their primary value was to feed the souls of ethnic students. In my talk I flipped the script, reframed current U.S. history courses and textbooks as soul courses for Anglo students, and called for the bicultural infusion of Latino content into U.S. history. I received my first professional standing ovation.

What I didn't know at the time was that a parallel journey would soon elevate the importance of my talk. A few months later the Mexican American and Black advisory committees of Los Angeles Unified School District brought a challenge to social studies textbooks then being reviewed for statewide adoption by the California Department of Education. According to Section 9305 of the California education code, adopted books were required to "correctly portray the role and contributions of the Negro and other ethnic groups." If that wording makes you flinch, consider that this was "woke" in 1971.

The two advisory committees argued that the proposed textbooks did not meet that requirement of the state education code. In response, the State Board of Education decided to form

a statewide task force to review the submitted textbooks. It began meeting in the fall of 1971.

Some people who had attended my soul course talk liked the way that I had addressed the topic of textbooks and recommended me for the task force. I was chosen. Open to the public, task force meetings drew publishers, school district officials, concerned citizens, and media representatives. By the time the task force had finished its work, I was becoming known in educational circles around the state. This led to invitations to speak about textbooks and the task force's findings at educational conferences and school districts throughout California.

There was also one other fortuitous dimension of my task force experience. The only non-Californian on the task force was a dynamic young University of Washington education professor named James Banks. Jim and I quickly became friends. The task force experience inspired him to edit a book he titled *Teaching Ethnic Studies: Concept and Strategies.* Jim invited me to contribute an essay on "Teaching the Chicano Experience." Published in 1973 by the National Council for the Social Studies (NCSS), the book became seminal in the development of a new field becoming known as multicultural education. I soon found myself being drawn into this inchoate field. Since at that time there were only a few field thought leaders like Jim Banks and Carl Grant, so almost immediately I became part of the second echelon of national multicultural education champions.

One of the most tireless and imaginative scholars I have ever known, Jim Banks followed up his NCSS book with a second exploratory venture. With support from an outside grant, Jim led an NCSS task force in the development of what would become

the *Curriculum Guidelines for_Multiethnic Education*. Published in 1976, it received the 1977 Eleanor Fishburn Award of the Washington EdPress Association.

In terms of proposing curriculum ideas, the book turned out to be a pioneering venture. Yet in other respects it was behind the times. Multiethnic education was already giving way to multicultural education (including such topics as race, ethnicity, sex, religion, class, language, and disability).

But the transition took time. As late as 1981 the National Education Association published a book-length collection of original articles: *Education in the 80's: Multiethnic Education*. The collection included my essay entitled "The Societal Curriculum: Implications for Multiethnic Education." (Later I will discuss the origins of my concept, "the societal curriculum.")

Now that my name was also becoming known in the area of K-12 social studies, I was invited to give a keynote address for the national conference of the Social Studies Education Consortium (SSEC) in Boulder, Colorado. This led to an SSEC invitation to write a follow-up monograph. It was published in 1976 as *Understanding You and Them: Tips for Teaching About Ethnicity*.

By the end of the decade I found myself deluged with offers to speak and work with school districts, county offices of education, state departments of education, and the federal government on multicultural aspects of education. Almost every day I was faced with choices. A field that did not even exist at the beginning of the decade was now dominating much of my time and effort.

Bilingual Education

My national ethnic studies visibility came as a natural outgrowth of my UCR activities. My multicultural education visibility was more a product of serendipity, based mainly on being spotted at a UCR conference, receiving public visibility as the member of a widely-observed state task force, and meeting Jim Banks, who would become seminal in my career as well as a treasured friend. My entrance into bilingual education was even more unlikely, as well as was my decades-spanning participation in that field.

Bilingual education was a late 1960's invention. Congress had passed a bilingual education act with the goal of improving the K-12 achievement of bilingual students. At that time this meant mainly Spanish-speaking Latino students, although it quickly embraced students from a variety of Asian language backgrounds. But passing a bill and creating a field were two different things. Spanish-speaking teachers found themselves being assigned to teach bilingual education classes for which they had received absolutely no academic preparation. At that moment, bilingual education meant using two languages in the classroom in some way, shape, or form. Virtually no research base existed.

In the fall of 1974 a young man named Fernando Worrell (now Fernando Elizondo), then a bilingual education specialist at the Riverside County Office of Education, chanced to come to my Chicano Studies office. Teachers needed help, he appealed to me. He envisioned mounting a bilingual education conference to help them. Would I, as chair of Chicano Studies, work with him to put on such a conference at UCR? As would happen so many times throughout my career, I couldn't say no.

The conference was held in the spring of 1975 and drew an overflow crowd. We had reserved the student commons cafeteria for the opening plenary session, but so many educators attended from throughout the state and even nationally that we had to set up outside loudspeakers. Fernando asked me to give the welcoming address as Chicano Studies chair. I turned my talk into a battle cry for bilingual education and deeper changes in the process of educating students from multiple language backgrounds.

Teachers attended and teachers presented, sharing the pedagogical they had developed for their classrooms. Going from session to session was both eye-opening and inspiring. Teachers were trying new, sometimes audacious things. They listened to each other and learned from each other. By the time the conference had ended, another idea had been hatched: the formation of a statewide association to deal with bilingual education.

That dream soon became a reality: the 1975 formation of the California Association for Bilingual Education (CABE). Fifty years later, in 2025, CABE celebrated its fiftieth anniversary and made a film on the history of CABE. I was interviewed and filmed for an hour. At its huge statewide conference in Long Beach, I was honored as one of the pioneers of bilingual education. By being at the right place at the right time (Chicano Studies chair in 1974-1975), I had become part of the history of bilingual education.

Latin America

All of this was happening in the 1970's. Ethnic Studies, multicultural education, bilingual education, and more. That

said, what about the role for which I had been hired by UCR: to teach and conduct research about Latin America, particularly Brazil?

Well, there are only twenty-four hours in a day, seven days in a week. Something had to give. Controversy was destined to follow. A segment of my department looked askance at the directions my career had taken. Where is the Brazilian historian we hired last decade? Why is he messing around with K-12 education rather than immersing himself in Latin American archives? What next?

This concern did not stop my progress through the promotion system. I had advanced to tenure as an Associate Professor in 1972, three years after completing my Ph.D. Just four years later I was promoted to Full Professor. Yet Latin America had become a diminishing part of my academic profile.

I continued to teach Latin American history in collaboration with my friend and colleague Leon Campbell. Leon was a colonialist; I specialized in national period Latin America. In addition, Leon and I shared an interest in film. In the spring of 1975 we launched a series of jointly-taught courses on film and history, beginning with The Latin American Experience in Film.

Along with this we edited a series of monographs featuring student essays from our film-and-history classes and published by the UCR Latin American Studies Program. Our list of titles reflected the eclecticism of our approach: *Latin America: A Filmic Approach* (1975); *A Filmic Approach to the Study of Historical Dilemmas* (1976); *Film as Revolutionary Weapon: A Pedagogical Analysis* (1977); and *Race and Ethnicity in the History of the Americas: A Filmic Approach* (1979).

I wrote sporadically about Latin America, sometimes connecting it with the ethnic experience in the United States. The Center for Teaching International Relations at the University of Denver recruited me to write a monograph, *Mexico in the Study of Mexican Americans: An Analysis of Transnational Linkages* (1976), as part of a series of transnational linkages studies that it sponsored. I also drew on that monograph as a topic for workshops that I was doing for K-12 teachers.

Latin America continued to be part of my professional portfolio. However, it was no longer central to my efforts. Nor was it central to the promotion files that my department was assessing.

The Societal Curriculum

There was one final strand to my 1970's professional journey, a strand that in some respects became the most bizarre dimension of that decade. I invented a term, a term that caught on and spread rapidly. The term: The Societal Curriculum.

I'm not exactly sure when I came up with that term. I do remember when I first unveiled it in writing. I launched it in my 1976 Social Science Education Consortium monograph, *Understanding You and Them: Tips for Teaching About Ethnicity*.

That idea received even greater visibility three years later in my short (five page) article entitled "The Societal Curriculum and the School Curriculum: Allies or Antagonists?" The article was published in the April, 1979, issue of *Educational Leadership*, the magazine of the Association for Supervision and Curriculum Development. The article's opening lines made my case, a case I would repeat over and over

throughout the ensuing decades and upon which I would build in my media research.

"Schools are not education. They are only part of education. When curriculum is mentioned, most people think of the *school curriculum*, whether manifest or hidden. In reality, however, two curriculums operate side by side. In addition to the education we receive in school, all of us receive a lifelong education through the *societal curriculum.* What is the societal curriculum. It is that massive, ongoing, informal curriculum of family, peer groups, neighborhoods, mass media, and other socializing forces that 'educate' us throughout our lives."

Nothing particularly profound. Obviously people learn outside of schools. However, I had come up with a simple metaphor of schools and society as parallel curricula, a metaphor that could be quickly grasped and easily articulated. The idea and the term caught on. To this very day it is still being cited.

Throughout the rest of my career I would engage the societal curriculum. For example, in 1981 my article "The Societal Curriculum: Implications for Multiethnic Education," appeared in the National Education Association book, *Education in the 80's: Multiethnic Education.* That same year my article "Historians and the Media: Revising the Societal Curriculum of Ethnicity," was published in *Federation Reports,* a publication of the Federation of Public Programs in the Humanities. In the spring of that year an entire two-day conference was held in Chicago, entitled "The Societal Curriculum: Implications for Multiethnic Education," for which I gave the keynote address.

The concept of the societal curriculum provided the launching pad for much of my subsequent research and

professional activity. That concept raised a number of questions. What does the societal curriculum consist of? Who creates it? How does it function? What impact does it have? What can we -- parents, teachers, and institutions -- do about it, including within the schools?

For the next nearly five decades I would grapple with those simple, yet fundamental questions in my teaching, writing, lecturing, workshopping, and consulting. In particular I focused on the informal pedagogical role of the mass media. It turns out that those simple five pages, particularly those opening lines, would propel much of the rest of my career.

The Art of Being Discovered

As the decade of the 1970's drew to an end, one additional career transition began to emerge. I was beginning to become known outside of the areas of history, ethnic studies, multicultural education, and bilingual education. Like Native American people supposedly "discovered" by Christopher Columbus, I found myself being "discovered" as I progressed into my 40's. Two such "discoveries" exemplify this process.

In 1980 the California Council for the Humanities selected me for the 1980 Distinguished California Humanist Award. My acceptance speech was entitled "The Role of Humanists in Public Affairs: Romantic Sideshow or Bridge to a Better World?" In that talk I kicked off what would become decades of wrestling with the issue of bridging the gap between the university and the larger world around it.

At about the same time I was contacted by Lynda Carl Falkenstein, who was co-organizing an American Bar Association national conference on law-related education. Would I be

willing to present at the conference and contribute a piece to an ensuing publication that she was editing? I can't recall my immediate response, but it probably was something like this: what is law-related education? That was the first time I had ever heard of that idea.

It turns out that LRE, as it was known among aficionados, was an educational reform movement supported, in part, by the American Bar Association. I'm not certain if I asked to learn more about LRE before deciding to write the paper or whether I said yes and then steeped myself in learning about this mysterious new (to me) field. Either way, I ultimately agreed, immersed myself in LRE literature, and presented at the three-day national conference in Chicago in late April, 1978.

(I remember that conference vividly because my new wife, Laurel, and I had just gotten married and our Chicago stay was part of our honeymoon. This also involved flying afterward to Des Moines, Iowa, where we spent a day touring the Iowa State Capitol, with its lovely historic library. The next day I gave a multicultural education workshop for the Iowa Department of Education.)

I later adapted my conference presentation into "Multicultural Law and Humanities Education: Preparing Young People for a Future of Constructive Pluralism," which was published in a 1980 American Bar Association publication, *Daring to Dream: Law and the Humanities for Elementary Schools.* That soon led to my being invited to address other LRE gatherings and ultimately to my being appointed to the ABA's Special Committee on Youth Education for Citizenship. I had broken beyond the boundaries of multicultural education per se and was now applying multicultural thinking to other areas.

The LRE venture also established a pattern that would repeat itself for decades to come. I would be approached to speak on the relationship of multiculturalism (or diversity) to a topic about which I had little expertise (in the case of Law-Related Education, I didn't even know it existed). Then I would have to make a choice: is this a stretch that I want to make or is it a bridge too far?

I ultimately developed the personal motto: "When in doubt, say yes." Life is not for wimps. The 1980's would offer a cascade of such decisions as I dabbled in field after field. The LRE adventure was an early step in my becoming an all-purpose multiculturalist.

The Follies

"The past is a foreign country. They do things differently there." In those prescient eleven words that open his novel, *The Go-Between,* L. P. Hartley perfectly captured the essence of history. Most people reading this document will be viewing it with minds and eyes shaped by the 21st century. The 1970's world of UCR, ethnic studies, multiculturalism, and bilingual education need to be recognized as such a foreign country. We did things differently back then.

The world of the 1970's was one of multicultural optimism and joy, of "we shall overcome" not "I don't feel safe," of taking things seriously but at the same time willing to have fun with them. It was a time when UCR was actually a community with no digital connections. We had very few commuters and most professors showed up nearly every day and left their office doors open. Edwin Gaustad, the History Department's most notable commuter, lived in nearby Redlands.

So we did things together. We had a faculty intramural sports league, for which History and Spanish formed a basketball team. I played for a number of years until the sloppy catch of a hard pass dislodged the joint of my right little finger, creating a T where formerly there had been a straight line. After the doctor popped it back into place and the swelling receded, I decided it was time for this forty-something to hang up his basketball career.

But maybe the social difference between the 1970's and the 2020's, in which I am writing, can be illustrated by one final thing that occurred at UCR. For three years in the mid-1970's we put on a faculty-staff follies. For several nights we made fools of ourselves on stage in order to raise scholarship money for undergraduate students.

Glenda Gleckner, wife of English professor and Dean Robert Gleckner, came up with the idea for the follies and coordinated the production. The first year was called the Forties Follies, a two-hour stage show in the campus' 500-seat auditorium, in which faculty and staff dressed up as classic entertainers and lip synched recordings of their songs. The show sold out all of its performances.

Glenda cast me each of the Follies' three years. In the 1975 Forties Follies I played Shirley Temple, dressing up in a tutu, singing "On the Good Ship Lollipop," and sort of tap dancing. It was drag, pure and simple, but nobody protested. Nobody picketed against cross-dressing or accused me of being a drag queen who was championing some gender ideology. (There are photos of me as Shirley Temple in my papers.)

The next year I played Bud Abbott opposite Dean of Students Al Myles, who portrayed Lou Costello. We lip-synched their

famous “Who’s on First?” comedy routine. One of the other acts involved three faculty members singing in black face in a parody of that racist practice. Black students didn’t protest. In fact, one of the three singers was a Black Studies professor, who charcoaled his face along with the two white faculty members. We did things differently back then.

Forty years later, during a UCR diversity certificate workshop in the late 2010’s, I told that story and illustrated it with a slide. Some workshop participants, composed of UCR staff, were outraged. I hadn’t given them a trigger warning. Although I was one of the founders of that certificate program and had helped develop the curriculum before it was taken over by the DEI office, I instantly became persona non grata. I have never since been invited back to help teach the certificate curriculum that I helped invent.

So what’s the point of this digression? Back then, when it came to issues like inequality, we were critical, dedicated, and determined. But we could also kick back and poke fun at society’s transgressions without overly concerning ourselves about offending or being offended. We were serious without descending into solemnity. We wanted social progress, but didn’t concern ourselves with cleansing the environment.

We did things differently then. The 1980’s would bring changes. Some of my professional career involved responding to those changes.

Chapter 5

The 1980's: The All-Purpose Multiculturalist

When the 1970's began, there was no such thing as multicultural education. By the end of that decade the field was booming, primarily at the K-12 level and in schools of education. Helped by the laws of supply and demand (relatively few multicultural education specialists and a rapidly-growing need for them), I had become nationally-known in the field.

But by the early 1980's my thinking was evolving. I still kept a foot in ethnic studies with a variety of articles and creative ventures. I remained active in the K-12 sphere as multiethnic education was giving way to multicultural education. However, my interests were growing well beyond my 1970's focus on race and ethnicity.

In particular, I began seriously grappling with the broader idea of multiculturalism, a vague term that has resisted being conclusively defined. Two people can carry on a conversation about multiculturalism without ever recognizing that they are talking about very different conceptualizations. But in the 1980's there was growing enthusiasm to embrace multiculturalism, even when people weren't always certain what they were embracing beyond the word itself.

Why did multiculturalism enjoy such a popularity boom? In retrospect I think this happened because the term multiculturalism suggested an inclusive view of the many ways that people could be part of a nation or, if your view were broader, of global citizenry. It provided an antithesis to monoculturalism, "one size fits all" thinking, and the idea of "one model American." It rejected the idea that we live in a

world of cut-and-paste we're-basically-all-alike human beings, but rather in a world of difference, the title of the Anti-Defamation League's popular national training program.

As people increasingly embraced or, at least, became interested in the idea of multiculturalism, they turned to the slowly-growing ranks of multicultural thought leaders for guidance. A division occurred. Some multicultural education advocates preferred to limit their efforts to schools themselves. And, truth be told, there was plenty of work to be done there.

However, a handful of others began navigating sectors outside of multicultural education per se, sometimes even outside of schools. My late 1970's entry into law-related education, a field that I previously didn't even know existed, provided a taste of this new adventure. Throughout the 1980's my activities expanded as a became a multicultural generalist, working in myriad educational realms outside of multicultural education per se as well as in such tangential areas as private business, religion, youth groups, and the mass media. The 1980's put me on the road to becoming a an all-purpose multiculturalist.

My UCR Trajectory

When I stepped down as Chicano Studies chair in December, 1979, I was administratively burned out. For me the 1970's had meant a full decade of chairing, first Latin American Studies, then Chicano Studies. I looked forward to my two-quarter sabbatical and then returning as a full-time professor without major ancillary duties. It didn't take long for that plan to collapse. Three major events led to that change in plans.

***the arrival of Tomás Rivera as UCR chancellor.

***my acceptance of the History Department chairmanship.

***the elimination of Chicano Studies

Tomás Rivera

In 1979, my friend Tomás Rivera was chosen to be the new UCR chancellor, replacing Ivan Hinderaker. In the process, Tomás became the first minority chancellor and second youngest chancellor in the history of the University of California. I wouldn't say that his choice was totally a fluke, but it certainly came as a surprise. Until then his main claim to fame was his novel, *And the Earth Did Not Swallow Them*, which had already become part of Chicano literary lore. However, his administrative experience was limited, most notably his single year (1978-1979) as Executive Vice President of the University of Texas, El Paso.

But those were the days of affirmative action. I can almost hear the higher level conversations: we need to have a least one minority candidate in the final pool. It turned out to be Tomás.

The night before his visit to the UCR campus in the spring of 1979, Tomás asked me to meet with him at his hotel after the official search committee dinner, to which I was not invited. Throughout the decade we had become friends through numerous Chicano conferences. That night we talked and talked and talked. A savvy guy, Tomás realized that he might be merely a token candidate, but he still wanted to do well the next day in his campus interviews. Maybe I could help him. I gave him one piece of advice: just be yourself and whatever happens, happens.

Tomás was a marvelous human being with a natural warmth that could take over a room. Apparently that's what happened the next day. His warmth, directness, and essential humanity overwhelmed the various groups with which he met, vaulting him to the top of the selection heap. In July, 1979, he became UCR's chancellor.

I would like to say that the campus welcomed him with open arms, except that wasn't true. Certainly many people grew to adore him, mainly students and staff. Others, particularly certain faculty, viewed Tomás as the UC system's ethnic imposition, a Chicano with a Ph.D. from Oklahoma State University being foisted off on UCR to show how progressive the University of California was becoming. And Tomás recognized how he was viewed. He mentioned it in his public lectures, particularly at Chicano gatherings, and in our many conversations. The early 1980's meant supporting Tomás as a friend.

But there was another new strand of my UCR life. In 1982, the History Department faculty asked me to become chair. Here I thought I had paid my chairing dues by devoting an entire decade to heading programs. But no. The University of California operates on a "what have you done for me lately" imperative. I briefly resisted, then realized that maybe I owed it to the department for having spent a decade as a professional maverick. From 1982 to 1986 I served as History Department chair. By the end of my term I had chaired three degree programs for more than thirteen of my seventeen years on campus. University administrative service had become my middle name.

This led to an important collaboration with Tomás. The collaboration involved Rupert and Jeannette Costo, founders of

the American Indian Historical Society. The Costos were considering the establishment of an endowed chair and had decided to donate their papers and rich library of Native American books to some university. UCR was in the running.

The Costos preferred UCR. Rupert, who had attended Riverside City College before moving on to Whittier College and the University of Nevada, had long been active in the community. In fact, Rupert was part of the team that helped found UCR, which previously had been a University of California agricultural research station.

However, establishing the Costo chair turned out to be a bumpy process, with multiple complications arising. Vice Chancellor Carlton Bovell handled the lengthy and sometimes tumultuous negotiations. I worked closely with the Costos to keep them focused on UCR even when events were provoking them to think of taking their chair and collection elsewhere. The road to the Costo chair and collection was littered sometimes-conflicting imperatives: university regulations; donor desires; personal clashes; and political conflicts.

But the Costos were a remarkable couple with a magnificent vision. They stayed the course. In 1986 they founded UCR's Costo Chair in American Indian History (currently held by historian Clifford Trafzer) and the Costo Library of the American Indian, now part of the UCR library's Special Collections. It was one of the earliest chairs ever established at UCR. Mission accomplished.

Ethnic Studies

Unfortunately the next mission was even more embattled, drawing me back into the Chicano Studies saga. Since retiring

as Chicano Studies chair and returning full time to the History Department, I was no longer being included in Chicano Studies meetings. However, I did continue to attend the larger Wednesday noon gatherings of Chicanos across the campus. My main contribution to the degree program was continuing to teach my cross-listed (with History) Chicano History course, which I did until retirement in July of 1994. (In the fall of 1982 I had three Corteses among my 44 students in Chicano History.)

But trouble was brewing. By the spring of 1984, both Chicano Studies and Black Studies had become embattled. There had always been pockets of academic skepticism about ethnic studies, but by the spring of 1984 that skepticism had evolved into full-scale opposition. In October, 1982, Dean David Warren launched a review of Chicano Studies (and other small programs). This led to his recommendation that the two ethnic studies programs be disestablished and the faculty be assigned full time to their respective joint-appointment departments.

As I was no longer involved in Chicano Studies faculty meetings, I don't have details to share. However, internal dissensions had developed. As a result, Chicano Studies (along with Black Studies) was in a weakened state when the UCR Academic Senate took up the Dean's disestablishment recommendation at its spring, 1984, meeting.

The Senate took two steps. First, the Senate took an in-your-face-Tomás move, voting to strip the chancellor of the power to make final decisions on interdisciplinary degree-granting programs (he retained the power to make final decisions on departments, but Chicano and Black Studies were not departments). Second, rather than publicly supporting the Dean's disestablishment recommendation, the Senate called for a

mail ballot on a motion to combine the two programs into a single Ethnic Studies entity. The mail ballot approved that motion over the unanimous opposition of the Chicano and Black Studies faculty, who wanted to maintain their singular program identities.

I sat across the aisle from Tomás during the Senate meeting and watched his face. I don't know where he stood on the specific motions being debated. However, based on my conversations with him, I suspect that he viewed this process and the faculty testimony as a surrogate slap at him as UC's "ethnic chancellor." Tomás did not speak, but Vice Chancellor Carl Bovell did. An African American biologist and a member of the original Ethnic Studies formation committee back in 1969, Bovell spoke against the motion.

The aftermath was brutal. Within a week of the Academic Senate meeting Tomás Rivera suffered a major heart attack and died. A commemoration ceremony was held in front of the UCR Administration Building. At the request of his widow Concepción (Concha) Rivera, I read his epic poem, "The Searchers."

Then there was the aftermath. Some faculty hoped that the motion to combine the two programs would lead to a period of inactivity in which Chicano and Black Studies would simply wither and go away. That could have happened. However, the administration acted quickly and assembled a four-person Ethnic Studies Program Formulation Committee to organize the new major. I was named to the committee.

We worked furiously over the summer and came up with a report supporting the creation of a Department of Ethnic Studies with two new positions. To the degree that the Academic Senate decision to eliminate the two stand-alone ethnic studies

programs was intended to eliminate ethnic studies in general, the Senate's tactic failed. Rising from the 1984 ashes, UCR's Ethnic Studies program arose and survives to the present, with even a Ph.D. program.

My dreams of devoting that decade primarily to my research had evaporated. Instead the first half of the decade meant serving four years (1982-1986) as History Department Chair, helping found the Costo Chair, and participating in the 1984 Ethnic Studies salvage job. By 1986 I was ready for my sabbatical leave and some personal restoration.

Japan, 1986

That restoration began with a new opportunity: to participate in a four-week multinational cultural exchange to Japan. I had applied for this Japan Foundation-funded visit organized by Charles von Loewenfeldt, a San Franciscan who had devoted his life to fostering better U.S.-Japanese relations. When I was selected, I found myself part of a cohort of 16 American educators, mainly K-12, with a sprinkling of higher education representatives.

In October, 1986, we flew to Tokyo and met up with delegations from Latin America (15 people), Australia (10), and Indonesia (20). The four delegations stayed together for the opening and closing Tokyo segments of the visit, as well as stays in such places as Hiroshima, Kyoto, and Nara. In addition, each individual delegation spent a week in a different part of Japan. The Americans spent that week in the southern province of Miyazaki.

The entire trip was a blast. I enjoyed learning about Japan. But I also found it fascinating to observe how people

from the different delegations interacted with each other and responded to being in Japan. It was multiculturalism in action.

I found myself spending less time with the American delegation and more time with the others, helped by the fact that I was the only American with fluency in both Portuguese and Spanish. When I returned home, I looked back on the trip as a wonderful addition to my multicultural experience package. I was also able to apply my experience to my expanding efforts back in the United States.

Committee on Academic Personnel

Then it was back to intensive campus service. I was asked to serve for three years on the Senate's Committee on Academic Personnel (CAP), which reviewed and assessed all campuswide faculty promotion files. CAP had always been a mystery to me: an entity that made career-boosting and career-destroying promotion decisions about individual faculty members. I wasn't sure if I had benefited from or lost because of their deliberations about me; maybe both. Solving the CAP mystery was a siren's call. I answered yes, spending three years (1987-1990) on that time-devouring committee.

Vows of confidentiality prevent me from sharing any of the particulars of those fascinating, frustrating three years of committee service. I will only say that, as I read personnel file after personnel file, I became a witness to the best and the worst of university academic life, as well as the functioning and misfunctioning of the UC personnel system. When I finished my three years of service I was more than happy that I had not pursued periodic feelers from other universities to

apply for administrative positions. I was happy simply being Carlos Cortés, full professor and public figure.

In addition, I was able to draw on my CAP experience when the University of California appointed me to a systemwide UC Task Force on Faculty Rewards. We concluded that the faculty advancement system was unduly rigid and needed greater flexibility when it came to evaluating scholarly contributions (changes in the UC Academic Personnel Manual Section 210-1-D). I must admit that I pushed for this conclusion partially based on the years in which I sometimes found my advancement restrained by my campus' unwillingness to give me full credit for my scholarly contributions that did not fall precisely within the perceived boundaries of history. However, I accept full responsibility for making those career decisions with full awareness that I was pushing traditional boundaries.

Wrestling with Multiculturalism

Despite my continued immersive administrative duties at UCR, the 1980's did vault me into becoming more of a public figure. In some respects I became a very different kind of public figure than I had been in the 1970's. In particular, I transitioned from being an ethnic studies/multicultural education specialist into a diversity/multiculturalism generalist. The process sometimes took bizarre turns.

As I prepared this collection of papers, I discovered two huge two huge file drawers jammed with public presentations that I had given. As I perused the talk titles, I was struck by how quickly and broadly my multicultural realm had expanded. I was also surprised by my changes in thinking, particularly about the

very topic of multiculturalism itself, which I did in myriad articles, talks, and workshops.

What did multiculturalism mean? What were its variants? How could it be better conceptualized? How did it relate to and sometimes contend with other constructs, such as cultural pluralism? How did multiculturalism as an idea actually work out in practice? As I wrestled with these questions in my speaking and writing, I developed two formulations that seemed to attain broad resonance.

The first formulation arose from my consideration of the implications of multiculturalism for the ideas of acculturation and assimilation. Some multiculturalists rapidly polarized the conversation: either you assimilate or you remain ethnic. I argued for an alternative formulation, based on differentiating the concepts of assimilation and acculturation. In my presentations I did so through a simple switch of vowels: adopt and adapt.

I framed assimilation as the process through which people of various cultural varieties "adopted" mainstream culture while virtually abandoning their ethnic particularism. In contrast, I argued that people could pursue acculturation through "adapting" to mainstream culture: by learning mainstream American mores and behaviors while at the same time remaining empowered to retain their ethnic identities, practices, and sometimes languages. An either/or choice was unnecessary.

In practice this process was far more complicated than a simple vowel switch. However, my adopt/adapt formulation seemed to resonate because it was easy to grasp and remember. I applied that formulation regularly in lectures, workshop, and writing, as I championed the idea of acculturative

multiculturalism. One could have one's cake (participation in the mainstream) and eat it, too (remaining attached to ethnic pride, identity, and participation).

My second multiculturalism formulation went a bit further. It was more complex, maybe a bit too artificial for comparably broad-scale public consumption. My term for this construct was "multiculturation."

In that formulation I argued that acculturation actually went well beyond "them" (ethnic outsiders) adjusting to "us" (the White American mainstream), as was commonly framed. In place of this one-way, unidirectional acculturation I offered an alternative. Acculturation was actually a multidirectional process. While ethnic outsiders were adapting to American culture and moving into the American mainstream, White Americans were simultaneously adapting to the increasingly diverse world around them. Moreover, that acculturation was not just an individual process. American culture was changing, as mainstream culture acculturated to this growing multicultural reality.

I broke this process into four components. Moving into the mainstream. Building upon qualities and cultural resources of the nation's various ethnic groups. Strengthening intergroup understanding. Developing civic commitment. These four components operated in tandem, sometimes reinforcing each other, sometimes coming into conflict. I championed this idea in my writing, drew on it as my thinking developed, and applied it as I continued with my multicultural efforts.

Take the example of language. Certainly it was important for "them" to learn English. But at the same time "we" (meaning mainstream institutions and practices) were providing greater

access through expanded services in multiple languages. Adaptation through multiculturation made it possible for "them" to function in society and participate in civic activities even as their English-language fluency was still developing. These changes involved not only government and education (such as bilingual education), but also such non-governmental institutions as private business.

How widely did my multiculturation idea spread? I can't say for certain. However, myriad invitations poured in to speak and write on the topic. This process would span several decades. For example, in 2011 I received a letter from Diana Terry-Azios, Director of Corporate Marketing for Univision Communications, indicating that they had read and were "incredibly impressed" by some of my multiculturation articles. This led to my working with Univision, including writing a blog series for its New American Reality initiative.

Throughout the 1980's I explored my continuously-evolving vision of multiculturalism as practice, not just as concept. I also extended the range in which I applied my developing vision. While I continued to be active in school-based multicultural education, I tested my multicultural thinking in a wider range of areas.

***I continuously propounded basic principles for promoting inclusivity while at the same time supporting ethnic specificity, as reflected in myriad articles and presentations throughout the decade.

***I applied my multicultural principles to teaching outside of multicultural education per se.

***I extended my application of multicultural principles to other institutions and societal areas, including the mass media.

***I continued to develop my concept of the societal curriculum and examined how it sometimes operated in tandem with and sometimes conflicted with school education.

***Finally, I sharpened my related research focus. Drawing on my film and history teaching and writing efforts in the 1970's, I decided to focus on the role of so-called entertainment motion pictures. What did feature films teach about ethnicity and other forms of diversity? What did people actually learn from that movie exposure? What decisions did filmmakers make in addressing (or avoiding) the topic of diversity?

The 1980's, in other words, became a time for raising and addressing new questions by proposing new insights rather than offering pat solutions. Those questions and explorations fell into four basic categories:

***Multiculturalism in the schools.

***Multiculturalism in society.

***Multiculturalism in the world.

***The role of media in the multicultural journey.

Multiculturalism in Schools

The 1970's had given birth to K-12 multicultural education as the conscious curricular and pedagogical inclusion of groups of people who had traditionally been marginalized. Ethnic groups, women, gays and lesbians, religious groups, and the disabled were beginning to be incorporated from kindergarten through high school. The action was fast and furious.

Invitations poured in to work with school districts, county offices of education, state departments of education, and higher education institutions. During summers I was constantly on the

road, going from district to district, particularly on the west coast and in the Midwest, where I got to know what seemed like every small city in Iowa and Minnesota. Airport codes and Holiday Inns became part of my DNA. By the end of my career in the mid-2020's, I had worked with over 250 school districts, had spoken at more than 350 colleges and universities, and had consulted with more than 500 organizations.

Given today's polarized political climate, people are sometimes incredulous when I tell them that I worked with liberals and conservatives, Republicans and Democrats in implementing multicultural education. Not that people were always in full agreement. However, they seemed to find common ground around the idea that the United States was, indeed, a multicultural society, that we needed to make in a more equitable multicultural society, and that we should pursue the building of bridges of understanding to make the nation and its communities become more inclusive.

In the 1980's DEI as an organizational entity did not exist. The idea of red states and blue states pursuing culturally-antagonistic educational policies had not yet become part of our national framework. Iowa, which today is a supremely regressive state when it comes to DEI, passed one of the earliest bipartisan bills mandating statewide multicultural education (at one point the state referred to it as multicultural non-sexist education). Multicultural education was viewed as a process of creating greater inclusivity, not as a weapon of divisiveness. The past, indeed, is a foreign country.

The 1980's were a time when people could communicate, cooperate and, yes, consider alternative arguments. Actually

listening to contrarian positions was not a sin. Compromise was not a dirty word. Lifelong learning meant that adults could grow personally from interactions with multiple perspectives, not merely hunker down in ideological bunkers.

In retrospect, it was a constructive era based on the idea that, through schools, we could actually foster a more inclusive, equitable future society. We may have been naively idealistic, but it was an invigorating idealism. It was a time when my pursuit of inclusivity and bridge-building seemed to resonate with both school educators and those outside of the school system.

Simultaneously I found that my learning curve was relentlessly steep. As I spoke my way across the country, I also had the opportunity of working with and learning from teachers and administrators. Moreover, via conferences, workshops, and other training gatherings, my personal vistas expanded as I listened to others address the many dimensions of multiculturalism.

During the 1970's I had thought primarily in terms of race and ethnicity. As the 1980's progressed I became increasingly conversant with other diversity issues. My workshops increasingly touched on sex, religion, sexual orientation, disability, language, and citizenship (gender identity had not yet become a significant multicultural topic).

Multiculturalism in Society

When the 1980's began, I was operating almost entirely within the framework of schools. By the end of the decade I was working in many non-school sectors: youth organizations, religious institutions, government entities, non-profits, and

the private sector. Unlike with some of my other career shifts, I cannot recall any specific events that drove this change. Stuff was happening and I got swept up in it.

As the decade developed, I ceased being surprise when the phone would ring with an offer to become involved in a new (for me) area. Most people didn't expect me to be an expert in their fields. They merely wanted me to apply my multicultural thinking to provide insights and provoke conversations that might enhance their fields. Each new challenge brought excitement and an opportunity to both contribute and to expand my own thinking. The process was both liberating and invigorating.

Take, for example, Los Angeles-based M&M (a shortened version of Merchants & Manufacturers Association), which among many things provided seminars for member organizations. I cannot recall the specific circumstances, but in the early 1980's M&M asked me if I would be willing to offer a series of one-day seminars on Supervising the Hispanic Worker. This was not exactly my cup of tree, but my sense of adventure combined with my confidence in teaching about Latino history, culture, and experience impelled me to say yes. To the best of my recollection, my first such seminar took place in 1982.

In retrospect, I'm not certain that my M&M seminars were consistently very good. They consisted of a mish-mash: a bit of history; a touch of culture; and some tidbits from organizational theory and psychology, in which I did a deep dive. Yet I received decent reviews and continued to be rehired for additional seminars, expanding my topic from Latinos to the increasingly multicultural workforce. I even received

invitations to speak at business training conferences and for individual companies.

In one memorable sojourn I spent an entire week in August, 1982, conducting an analysis of supervisor-worker relations in a Kal-Kan pet food canning factory in Southern California with a largely Latino workforce. The company operated round the clock, with three full shifts daily. Kal-Kan wanted me to interact with all three shifts, so it put me up at a hotel a block away. For an entire week I hopped back and forth between the hotel and the factory, grabbing a few hours sleep before returning to Kal-Kan to observe its operations and carry out interviews with workers and supervisors in English and Spanish.

The process brutalized my body. The night before I was to give my final oral report to management my bodily system was in such turmoil that I actually threw up in my room. However, I made it through the report, in which I suggested changes that Kal-Kan could make to improve worker satisfaction and, with that, productivity.

Might I have been contributing to the exploitive machinery of neoliberal capitalism? That's not how I saw it. I didn't mind helping a company as long as I could do so in a way that also made life better for the workers. In the process, it was another jump in my learning curve.

Multiculturalism in a Global Context

As the 1980's progressed, new opportunities emerged to address multiculturalism not just as a national but as a global phenomenon. My media research had attracted attention in Mexico. This led to a series of invitations to make

presentations about the role of media, particularly motion pictures, in Mexico's national and international journey.

Interest in the Chicano experience had also spread to Europe. A bi-annual conference on Chicanos was held in different parts of Europe. It was an opportunity too good to pass up. Laurel and I attended three Chicano conferences: in Paris; in Torredembarra, Spain (just south of Barcelona); and Germersheim, Germany, on the Rhine. All were a delight, both for the conferences themselves and for the opportunity to visit places we had never seen.

Of particular note was the Germersheim visit because of its aftermath. At the end of the conference we trained down to Strasburg, France, where we caught a three-day cruise up the Rhine to Cologne. Years later we would return for a two-week Rhine/Danube cruise from Amsterdam to Budapest.

The Mass Media Curriculum on Diversity

My multicultural interests and explorations had gone in myriad directions. At the same time, my scholarship had become more focused on the societal multicultural curriculum. In particular I continued my deep dive into the topic of the mass media, particularly motion pictures, as an element of that curriculum.

As I discussed earlier, during the 1970's I had dabbled with movies. My colleague Leon Campbell and I had developed a series of courses on film and history. By happenstance I had co-authored and co-produced a historical documentary, "Northwest from Tumacácori." Along the way I had become involved with the Historians' Film Committee, an entity within the American Historical Association.

In the winter of 1982 I developed what would become a UCR annual course, History of the Mass Media. (When I retired in 1994 I tried to convince my colleagues to keep the course going, even offering to give them all of my lectures and media materials, but I couldn't find a taker. My course lectures are included in this collection). Parallel to that basic media course I also regularized my film courses by establishing a Film and History series (History 114) exploring a number of different topics: the 1960's in film; Latin American history in film; and a filmic approach to the history of ethnicity.

It was a time when my research and teaching worked well together for mutual enhancement. By now my research agenda included a basic question: how have movies, particularly feature films, contributed to the ways that Americans view themselves and interact with those who are ethnically different from themselves? It was an enormous, multi-faceted question. Through articles and public presentations I addressed different slices of the question and, at other times, examined it in a larger conceptual manner. For example, a 1983 issue of the *Journal of Teacher Education* carried my article "The Mass Media: Civic Education's Public Curriculum."

In some cases my engagement with the media drew me into larger ventures. Take, for example, the quarterly magazine *Media & Values*, launched by the visionary Elizabeth Thoman. As part of that project Elizabeth assembled a group of columnists, each of whom would write a column from a particular perspective on that issue's main topic. Elizabeth asked me if I would be interested in writing a column that would be called Minorities.

It was an enticing opportunity. Some of the issue themes were far outside of my expertise and, frankly, my interest.

That made column-writing an ongoing challenge, but one which constantly stretched me and forced me to wrestle with applying a racial lens to varying topics. Overall I was happy during my tenure with the magazine, although I felt overly restricted by my assignment to focus on Minorities.

Even more of a stretch came in 1983 when I received an offer to write and serve as editorial supervisor for a 60-minute PBS special, "Latinos: A Growing Voice in U.S Politics." This was an even greater stretch than writing for *Media & Values,* but it was game on. The producers filmed numerous interviews around the country and then assembled the team for an intense weekend of writing, re-writing, editing, and working with our narrator, René Enríquez, of the hit television series "Hill Street Blues." The program was broadcast nationally that summer.

Yet another offer involved the American Historical Association and the Library of Congress, who jointly sponsored a three-day conference, The Historian and the Moving-Image Media, AHA's first ever national conference on the topic. I was one of twelve scholars asked to give plenary presentations. An adapted version of my talk was later published as part of the collection, *Image as Artifact: The Historical Analysis of Film and Television*.

Writing for *Media & Values*, preparing the script for the Latinos documentary, and presenting at the AHA moving-image conference were further examples of my 1980's stretching. It was a time of choices, challenges, and experimenting with ways of applying academic knowledge in the public square. But maybe my most unexpected foray of the 1980's involved a topic that I had dabbled with in the 1970's: bilingual education.

Beyond Language

Recall that in 1975 I collaborated with the Riverside County Office of Education in holding what turned out to be California's first major statewide bilingual education conference. Out of that conference came the formation of the California Association for Bilingual Education. But there was more to come.

In the early 1980's, the Bilingual Education division of the California State Department of Education launched a new project. It involved the examination of social and cultural factors that influenced the educational trajectories of Language Minority Students (a 1980's term that over time morphed into the current English Language Learners). Until that point, most bilingual education research had focused on language per se. The Bilingual Education division decided to broaden the vistas on this topic.

It did so by commissioning a set of papers written by scholars who had been doing research that seemed to contribute to understanding social and cultural factors in education. The writing team consisted of a number of scholarly pioneers, people like Shirley Brice Heath, John Ogbu, Luis Moll, Esteban Diaz, and Spencer Kagan. They also invited two evaluators for the team: Mary McGroarty, a specialist in English language learning, and me, the progenitor of the idea of the societal curriculum.

The papers were fascinating, covering such topics as funds of knowledge, cooperative learning, and oppositional culture. When we got together for our first team meeting, the discussion bristled with ideas. However, the Department of Education leaders decided that something was missing. They needed an introduction that provided a framework for tying the papers

together as well as a concluding synthesis of practical ideas. They turned to Mary for the conclusion and to me for the introduction.

My challenge: what should the introduction include? Of course, it would include a brief historical trajectory of American education's treatment of language diverse students as well as an indication of how the subsequent chapters contributed to our understanding of the book's focal topic. But the Department of Education team wanted more. It suggested that my chapter could draw on the Department's widely-used Interaction Model for the Education of Language Minority Students.

I took their idea one step further. I suggested expanding their model to incorporate my concept of the societal curriculum. The Department of Education team liked my idea and together we retooled their framework, transforming it into the Contextual Interaction Model for the Education of Language Minority Students. The societal curriculum became the context. My book introduction built on that revised model, explained how the different essays operationalized the societal curriculum concept, and suggested its application for language diverse students.

Published in 1986, the book, B*eyond Language: Social and Cultural Factors in the Education of Language Minority Students*, became an instant classic in the field of bilingual education. Moreover, I had written the opening chapter, which presented the new model. When the book was unveiled at the California statewide bilingual education conference, I was asked to give the introductory address about the book and "my" model (actually a collaborative effort).

By that fortuitous twist, I suddenly became quoted as an educational theorist and public spokesperson for bilingual education. Talks about my model soon became a regular part of my public lecturing repertoire. To this day I occasionally receive invitations to talk about "my" forty-year-old model, while bilingual educators continue to draw on it.

The Art of Being Discovered (and Rediscovered)

My off-beat emergence as a bilingual education voice was one example of the myriad dimensions of my 1980's journey. That decade was characterized by my being discovered over and over and over again. Discovered in the sense of Columbus discovering America. In truth, people of the Americas had been around for eons before Columbus came along and supposedly "discovered" them. I, too, had been around, but people kept discovering and re-discovering me, or at least dimensions of me.

It worked like this. I would publish an article, give a talk, or present a workshop. Somebody would be intrigued by what I had to say and invite me to present it in another context or apply my ideas to a different situation. I would say yes (or no). Game on, opening up the possibility of being further rediscovered.

Consider the following unlikely trajectory. In the winter of 1982 I launched a new course: History 187, History of the Mass Media. My pursuit of the intricacies of the societal curriculum had re-ignited my media interests dating back to my high school days. Constructing such a complex course from scratch was a major stretch, but a fascinating one. My classroom exploration of the mass media both reverberated with

students and opened new personal perspectives on media as part of the societal curriculum

At about the same time I received a phone call from someone representing a new television venture, "Why in the World?" It was the brain child of CBS news anchorman Walter Cronkite, who came up with the idea of a show featuring experts who could share their insights and excitement in different fields for high school students via a series of 30-minute television programs. I have no idea how the "Why" people learned about me, but I soon found myself "auditioning" for a spot on the show: meaning going into Los Angeles where I talked about some topic (I can't remember what) with a group of interviewers.

It must have gone well, because I was soon asked to tape a 30-minute "Why" segment. But about what? They left that up to me. I could have stuck with a topic I had addressed over and over, but I was immersed in the excitement of creating and piloting my new mass media course, so I decided to try to bring that same excitement to the television screen. I came up with the title, "Why in the World Do Major Media so Often Disappear Like Dinosaurs?" The producers liked the title.

On February 4, 1982, I drove to the studios of KCET, Los Angeles' main public television station. The sound stage consisted of a few dozen students sitting in chairs facing me as I presented my talk about media history. Lights, camera, action. Thirty minutes later the program was part of posterity, to be shown and reshown. The show's executives were happy enough that they invited me back for two more episodes: in 1983 ("The United States and the Third World") and 1984 ("Hispanics: The Changing Mosaic of America"). They also named me to the

show's National Educational Advisory Committee. The series ran for three years.

One family sidelight. My mother had come down with lung cancer. In 1983 she was hospitalized in the M. D. Anderson Clinic in Houston. Then my program came on. "That's my son," she screamed. When I visited her shortly thereafter, I was a mini-celebrity, signing autographs for cancer patients.

But someone else had seen it, too: the director of an organization known as the Association of American Schools in South America (AASSA). American schools have become omnipresent throughout the world. Their student bodies consist not only of the children of overseas Americans, such as bank executives and federal government employees. They also attract those from other foreign countries currently living in different places as well as the children of local elites, who saw a U.S.-structured education and English fluency as a leg up on life for their kids.

The AASSA director contacted me and asked if I would be willing to participate in one of their enrichment programs for faculty, staff, and students. He mentioned that he had seen me on "Why in the World?" and that their members would find my insights about the media to be of interest. Here was an opportunity for me to reconnect with South America. It would be funded by the AASSA's Bildner Fellowship program. I could not say no.

My March, 1983, trip was a whirlwind. In the space of two weeks (during UCR's spring break) I gave talks and workshops at two American schools in Rio de Janeiro, three in São Paulo, one in Asunción, and one in Montevideo. Add to that a non-stop string of school-sponsored social events at each stop. By the

end I was both inspired and tired, as well as reveling in an experience unlike anything else I could remember. It was also a chance to use what remained of my Portuguese and Spanish language skills.

Did that trip lead to further discovery? I can't be sure. However, I soon found myself on the American independent school radar, working with schools throughout the country. Were some of those opportunities linked to people I had met on my South American sojourn? I don't know. Let's answer with a resounding maybe.

The 1980's had turned into a decade of discovery. I wasn't Columbus; I was a native being discovered. The major difference was that these discoveries turned into opportunities, not exploitation (or at least I didn't view them as such).

In the early 1980's I was "discovered" by an organization that held an annual multi-week summer institute on K-12 education in Snowmass, Colorado. This brought a serendipitous side benefit. My wife, Laurel, joined me in Snowmass and, perchance, we took a three-hour river rafting trip with a minor touch of white water. We were so excited by the experience that we followed it up the next year with a 13-day trip in a small five-person raft down the Colorado River through the Grand Canyon and a few years later rafted the middle fork of Idaho's Salmon River. I swore that I would take even more adventurous rafting trips in such places as Africa's crocodile-infested Zambezi River, but I never pulled it off.

Divisions within the Diversity Movement

For me, the 1980's was a time of exploring and reflecting. I had ventured off in multiple directions and engaged in

activities that were not even on the horizon a few years before. But while I was busy doing, I became fascinated with changes that were occurring within the diversity movement itself. Three trends stand out:

***the advent of critical theory.

***the emergence of the idea of managing diversity.

***the rise of therapeutic diversity.

Critical Theory: Critical theory's roots actually go back to the 1920's, particularly to the Institute for Social Research at Goethe University Frankfurt. Critical theorists argue for a deep, highly skeptical analysis of the structures of inequality, dominance, and oppression. This includes all elements of society: laws, systems, and cultural practices.

Today we hear quite a bit about Critical Race Theory, but CRT is only one strand of the long critical theory movement. CRT grew out of frustration that the civil rights movement, including school desegregation, had not produced the hoped-for gains, particularly for African Americans. Law professor Derrick Bell kick launched the movement with such books as *Race, Racism, and American Law* (1970). After Bell came a series of disciples such as law professor Kimberlé Crenshaw, who added *intersectionality* to the CRT lexicon.

Criticism of social, economic, and cultural practices existed long before CRT reared its head. However, CRT expanded the list of targets, including such traditional liberal values as freedom and even such traditional minority goals as school desegregation. To its credit, CRT illuminated areas that had previously escaped examination. On the other hand, CRT generated a sense of pessimism that contrasted sharply with the diversity movement's we-shall-overcome optimism of the 1960's

and 1970's. Thirty years later, when I became a fellow of the University of California National Center for Free Speech and Civil Engagement, I would address CRT's role in freedom of speech debates.

Managing Diversity -- Paralleling the rise of American critical theory, although providing a far different perspective, was a framework known as managing diversity. That term is often credited to organizational theorist R. Roosevelt Thomas, Jr., who in 1984 founded The American Institute for Managing Diversity. Thomas focused on systems that fostered "effective management of employee diversity," while writing such seminal articles as "From Affirmative Action to Affirming Diversity," which appeared in the *Harvard Business Review*.

Thomas' ideas morphed in various directions. One was something that became known as the "business case for diversity." The business case's basic premise was that diversity was inherently beneficial for organizations because it provided multiple perspectives provided by people from diverse backgrounds. If "managed" properly, this could help organizations function more effectively and imaginatively. For private entities, it could even improve the widely-proclaimed bottom line.

I met Thomas in 1991 when we co-presented at a diversity conference at Case Western Reserve University in Cleveland. I found his ideas to be interesting, but not something that I wanted to pursue in depth. More than a decade later, however, I chanced to meet a Boeing Corporation diversity trainer named Louise Wilkinson, who was steeped in "business case" ideas. Together we began team teaching classes on diversity at the

Summer Institute for Intercultural Communication and ultimately to writing about aspects of diversity.

Thomas' ideas also influenced the development of something that would become known as Diversity, Equity, and Inclusion and to the appointment of chief diversity officers. Yet I am continually surprised when I encounter DEI enthusiasts who lack an awareness of Thomas' influence or fail to recognize that DEI did not actually become institutionalized until more than three decades after the beginning of the diversity movement in the late 1960's. My campus, the University of California, Riverside, did not appoint an Associate Vice Chancellor for Diversity and Inclusion until 2016.

The rise of DEI led to inevitable contradictions. Managing diversity thinking is very systems based. It inherently clashed with the free-wheeling emergence of diversity initiatives that had provided the impetus of the 1970's and beyond. Both diversity enthusiasts who lack historical awareness and ahistorical contemporary anti-diversity critics contribute to the same distortion: conflating all of these diversity start-ups into the simple DEI framework. I hope that my collection helps to unveil this masquerade, provide light on the rock-'em-sock-'em last three decades of the twentieth century before DEI became prominent, and reveal that those decades were not simply inevitable steps toward a DEI conclusion.

There was one other contradiction. In some respects Critical Race Theory and managing diversity were inherently at odds. It is true that some diversity managers draw on critical theory. This sometimes conflicts with more traditional diversity goals like intergroup understanding, bridge-building, and the advancement of marginalized groups through greater

access to society's benefits. Moreover, diversity managers had to accept one other imperative of employment. They were expected to serve and protect their institutions, the very institutions that critical theorists were excoriating.

These contradictions would ultimately entrap DEI leaders, whose top-down, systems-based managerial styles made them increasingly easy to target. They became targets of right-wing crusaders who longed to roll back diversity gains. They became targets of historical liberals who viewed them as opponents of traditional civil liberties like freedom of speech. They also became targets of critical theorists, who often viewed diversity managers as obstacles to change. As decades passed, my original reservations about Roosevelt Thomas' formulation manifested itself as I operated both within institutions and on the fringes of the DEI universe.

Therapeutic diversity -- Complicating matters even further was the rise of a third competing diversity strand, which I have labeled therapeutic diversity. This strand, too, has historical roots. Language equity had been part of the diversity movement from its inception. This could be seen in efforts to eliminate the public use of negative group epithets and in early steps to create greater use of gender-neutral language.

Then, in 1980, the American Psychiatric Association officially recognized PTSD, Post-Traumatic Stress Disorder. It took this action partially in response to pressure from such cohorts as Holocaust survivors, women's rights advocates, and Vietnam veterans' organization. The idea of trauma ultimately penetrated the diversity movement.

Over the years, some diversity trainers began conducting what they call "trauma-informed" workshops (some that I have

attended amounted to little more than warmed-over recitations of historical events with the term "trauma" injected now and then). And not just *individual* trauma. It can be passed down as *intergenerational* trauma. And those traumas can be triggered. How? Among other things, by microaggressions. And since traumas can be triggered in the classroom, pressures rose for professors to include trigger warnings in their course syllabi.

Like managing diversity, therapeutic diversity did not receive a free ride within the diversity movement. Some critical theorists derided it for its obsession with personal feelings, thereby distracting from more important issues like inequitable structures and systemic racism. Other diversity advocates, like myself, became concerned that by emphasizing mistake avoidance and trying to disinfect the speech environment, diversity language authoritarians were actually undermining robust discussions of diversity issues. People who fear crossing some invisible speech lines and getting "called out" for their efforts choose to remain silent and opt out of important conversations.

I need to point out that none of these changes happened overnight. Seeds were planted in the 1980's. These three perspectives -- critical theory, diversity managerialism, and diversity therapeutics -- developed and metastasized over decades.

These trends did not develop unscathed. Even as the diversity movement moved in multiple directions, a chorus of criticism arose in the 1980's and 1990's. Much of it came from opponents of diversity (Linda Chávez, "Demystifying Multiculturalism," Richard Bernstein, *Dictatorship of Virtue:*

Multiculturalism and the Battle for America's Future," and Arthur Schlesinger, Jr., *The Disuniting of America*).

(Full disclosure: I debated Linda Chávez twice and Arthur Schlesinger once, on October 29, 1993, in front of a packed auditorium in San Antonio. Seven years later, in 2000, Schlesinger and I happened to be interviewed back-to-back for the PBS program, "The Open Mind," in New York City. My book, *The Children Are Watching*, had just been published. We spent some time together and reminisced about our San Antonio experience. Predictably, we remembered the event a bit differently.)

Winding Down the 1980's

The diversity movement was changing, but so was I. I had begun the 1980's as a wandering historian who had been testing the waters of ethnic studies, multicultural education, and bilingual education, with some pedagogical and hands-on side trips into film and history. By the end of the 1980's I had become nationally prominent not only in multicultural education but also in diversity matters more broadly as an analyst, supporter, and sometimes critic. In particular I was increasingly being asked to speak about my concept of the societal curriculum as well as about various intersections of diversity and the media.

The more I ventured into different areas, the more I became aware of the challenges and complexities of applying diversity generalizations to the map of the real world. Even as new strands were developing within the diversity movement -- critical race theory, managing diversity, and therapeutic diversity -- I felt compelled to establish my individual

approach to the topic. This included contemplating contradictions and dilemmas, which I wrote about from multiple angles.

At the same time I had become accustomed to being "discovered" with regularity. Even my hometown newspaper, the *Riverside Press-Enterprise,* "discovered" me. On February 6, 1994, it ran a large feature story, dubbing me the "Guru of Getting Along."

Ironically, the Guru of Getting Along found himself increasingly at odds with others who were part of the diversity movement. I still believed -- and continue to believe -- that diversity is something to be celebrated. But it is also something to be critically contemplated and at times limited. Above all, diversity can only work if it is accompanied by a non-stop commitment to bridge-building among individuals, between groups, and within society. Unfortunately, some of the new trends within the diversity movement were heading in quite the opposite direction.

As I moved from the adventurous, experimental 1980's into what turned out to be a time of major transition in the 1990's, I increasingly shared my concerns and examined the dilemmas inherent to diversity. My 1980's-hatched ideas became the substance of 1990's speech and article explorations. I developed a speech entitled "The New Multiculturalism," in which I riffed on how multiculturalism was constantly changing and suggested how we as a nation should proceed with the multicultural project.

On October 31, 1992, I gave a luncheon address, "The Many Masks of Multicultural Education," at UCLA's The Art of Teaching History-Social Sciences: Linking Schools, Colleges, and the

Universities conference. When in 1994 Phi Kappa Phi asked me to write an article on diversity, I titled it "Limits to *Pluribus*, Limits to *Unum*: Unity, Diversity, and the Great American Balancing Act." When the journal *Liberal Education* approached me in 1995 to write a brief piece about how to reclaim the diversity dialogue, I answered with the following: develop principles; become proactive; reframe questions; and break dyadic thinking.

When *MultiCultural Review* asked me for an article in 1996, I titled it "Beyond Affirmative Action." In 1997, I wrote an article, "Diversity Workshops: Possibilities and Paradoxes," for the American Association of Colleges and Universities' publication, *Diversity Digest*. A dedicated diversity advocate, I had also become an interrogator wrestling with dilemmas and paradoxes rather than a cheerleader belting out clichés and buzzwords.

Maybe a culminating effort in synthesizing my constantly-changing ideas came on April 14, 1991, when I keynoted a three-day Faces of Diversity conference at Case Western Reserve University in Cleveland. I called my talk "Us and Them: A Sociographic Portrait of Multicultural America." In that talk I tried to sketch the current American multicultural reality using conceptual categories that I had developed over the years and to suggest directions toward which our nation was likely to move. The conference coordinator was planning to publish the collected talks, but to the best of my knowledge this never happened. However, a copy of the talk is in my collection. While I have not re-read it as I prepare my collection, it may provide special insight into where I had

temporarily arrived after a two-decade journey through diversityworld.

As I entered the 1990's, I was thinking about themes like limits, beyond, and principles upon which we could build a more inclusive and equitable nation. Underlying this was a series of questions about my future. What do I do next? Where do I go from here? What new ventures might I engage? What new avenues should I pursue? As it turned out, the 1990's would provide a series of answers as it became a decade of major transitions. Much of that revolved around making the most important life-changing decision of my professional journey: the decision to take early retirement and devote myself full time to my multicultural journey.

Los Corteses: A California Saga

There is one final twist to the 1980's, a decade that seemed amorphous when I began writing this retrospective, but has become increasingly seminal as I proceed with this project. The final twist has to do with my family. More specifically, my mother and father.

In late 1982 my mother, a lifetime sometimes-two-packs-a-day smoker, was diagnosed with lung cancer. In late December of that year my father took her down to M. D. Anderson Clinic in Houston, where I joined him. We stayed in a two-bedroom hotel suite directly across from the clinic so that Mom could get her daily chemotherapy treatment.

Added to that was the fact that Dad had been stricken with Parkinson's, which was worsening, although it had not yet turned into dementia. My brother Gary and I took turns flying down to Houston to support the two of them, but the logistics were

impossible. Gary was running the family construction business in Kansas City while I was chairing the UCR History Department. Dad was becoming increasingly disoriented. We finally got Mom transferred to a Kansas City oncologist so the two of them could get back to their comforting home surroundings.

I spent much of the summer of 1983 in Kansas City trying to help reduce the load on my brother. When Mom died in late 1983, Dad tried to make it alone in their sprawling ranch-style house, but his Parkinson's was progressing too rapidly. We found him a nice seniors' complex, where Dad moved into a two-bedroom suite so that I could stay with him during my regular visits to Kansas City. I spent much of the summers of 1984 and 1985 with him. By then his dementia was advancing rapidly.

This is where scholarship comes in. Dad had graduated from UC Berkeley with a degree in history and was working toward his M.A. when the Great Depression hit. When Mom, a Berkeley senior, met him in the fall of 1932, he was working as a mechanic in a service station. Later he would join my grandfather, my mother's father, in his construction business. But he never forgot his desire to become a historian.

My Columbia University friend Max Nichols wrote a wonderful book entitled *Every Single Good Day* (2005) about how he and his children had coped with his wife's advancing Alzheimer's disease. That was the path I took with my declining father: the cherishing of every single good moment, even as they became less frequent. One of the cores of that pursuit was our joint interest in history.

One of Dad's dreams was to write his family's story. He had even chosen a title: "Los Corteses: A California Saga." During his last two years Dad and I focused on "Los Corteses."

Not that we got much written, but it gave us something to focus on together during those long days in the seniors' complex when his memory would wander in and out. (One day in the summer of 1984 we were watching the Olympics. Dad went to the bathroom and came back asking, "Is this the Super Bowl?")

Working together on the never-to-be-written "Los Corteses" brought us many wonderful moments together. We tried to identify and label old family photos. We struggled together to translate mid-19th-century family letters. We corresponded with other members of the family, some of whom had become dedicated to creating a family tree. We particularly connected with my cousin Gay (daughter of Dad's younger brother Alejandro), who lived in Salt Lake City and had spent countless hours in the Mormon archives. Gay's niece Jennifer Carroll, has now taken over that family-uniting role.

I had no illusions that "Los Corteses" would ever become a book. Dad had neither the energy nor the attention span for that. But together we enjoyed the pursuit of an unattainable destination. When Dad died in late 1985, the "Los Corteses" project came to a halt. Many of the documents that we worked on are part of my collection. What I didn't know is that some of our work together would bear fruit in later years when I wrote my memoir, *Rose Hill: An Intermarriage Before Its Time*.

Chapter 6

The 1990's: Everybody's Adjunct

When the 1990's began, I was a happy 56-year-old full professor at the University of California, Riverside, with courses I enjoyed teaching, colleagues whom I liked (for the most part), and an active professional life that was taking me all over the nation and, at times, the world. I had more than paid my administrative dues, having spent half of my UCR life chairing (and rescuing) degree programs. My classes on Chicano history, history of the mass media, and film and history had become popular staples, while I continued to teach undergraduate and graduate courses on Latin America. With excellent health, I looked forward to a long and rewarding teaching and research future combined with fewer administrative responsibilities.

What a difference ten years would make. When the 1990's ended, I was an even happier 66-year-old retired professor emeritus. I was still teaching, but under far different circumstances, as a part-time professor for higher education institutions and other organizations throughout the United States (and no papers to grade). My national and even international visibility had moved far beyond what I could ever have imagined a decade earlier, while being "discovered" over and over had become almost routine.

Maybe I could say that these changes came out of nowhere. But maybe not. As the fates would have it, a series of early 1990's events may have provided signals for what was to come. Consider two such ventures that suggested my expanding vistas.

American Commitments

In early 1993, the then-named Association of American Colleges (later American Association of Colleges and Universities) asked me to serve on the National Panel of its new project, "American Commitments: Diversity, Democracy, and Liberal Learning." It was the kind of broad-scale, visionary project into which I could sink my teeth. Moreover, it was a multi-year project based on hope, inclusivity, and bridge-building, not the kind of dour, bitter, sometimes fatalistic directions that were beginning to infect parts of the diversity movement.

As I re-read the documents produced by the American Commitments project, the process provokes many thoughts. Was this project a step toward what would become Diversity, Equity, and Inclusion? Or, on the contrary, did the project lay out a vision that got lost in the wake of the DEI cavalcade?

At this point, I'm not sure. In any respect, participating in the American Commitments project, with its myriad meetings and provocative discussions, drew me into a more expanded consideration of my long-term areas of interest: ethnic studies; multicultural education; multiculturalism; diversity; and their implications for American institutions. It also led to my speaking at a number of AAC&U events.

Tokyo Bound

While the American Commitments project expanded my thinking about multiculturalism and diversity, a surprise invitation would further open up my professional vistas. The invitation came from Charles von Loewenfeldt, the San Franciscan who had coordinated the 1986 educational visit to Japan. Charles wanted me to return to Japan and join him on a more focused endeavor.

He was organizing a week-long seminar on diversity and intercultural relations for selected leaders of the Japanese national chamber of commerce. Would I be willing to be the main American presenter and discussant?

I'm not certain how Charles plucked me from the various delegations that he had sent to Japan over the years. I asked him as we rode together from the Tokyo Airport to the hotel. However, his response was vague. He had simply spotted me as the right person. Al caballo regalado, no se ve la diente.

In some respects, presenting to Japanese business leaders was an enormous cross-cultural stretch. However, I had become accustomed to and enjoyed taking risks. In addition, I had chalked up some experience with the business world, particularly through my seminars for Los Angeles-based M&M and my work with individual companies.

So in July, 1991, it was back to Japan for two weeks in Tokyo, staying at the Imperial Hotel directly across from the Imperial Gardens. I spent half of my time in intensive seminars with Japanese business leaders, but I also had opportunities ranging from attending an evening of sumo wrestling with my Japanese hosts to seeing "The Silence of the Lambs" in a Tokyo movie theatre. Who knows? Maybe that Tokyo visit helped prepare me for something that would could later that decade, becoming a faculty member of the Summer Institute for Intercultural Communication.

Those two ventures -- American Commitments and Japan's national chamber of commerce -- signaled something, although I doubt that I consciously picked up all of the signals at the time. They were signals that I was ready for something more, something above and beyond continuing as a professor. In

retrospect, I was probably ready to move on. I just needed a little push. In 1994, the University of California gave me that push. It was called VERIP.

VERIP: June 30, 1994

I almost didn't realize it then, but fate was about to give me a helping hand in the form of VERIP, an early retirement program offered by the University of California in three separate years. The fiscal goal was simple. The university's operating budget had declined, but its retirement program was flush. UC came up with the idea of coaxing higher paid professors, staff, and administrators to take early retirement in order to get them off the active payroll and shift them to the robust retirement fund. Then UC could rehire some of them part-time on severely-reduced salaries. It was win-win.

VERIP II had occurred in 1992. My wife Laurel had taken VERIP II in November, 1992, upon the birth of our first granddaughter. At that point Laurel was the chief administrative officer of UCR's large Department of Literatures and Languages. At much as she enjoyed her job, she wanted to spend time with her grandkids (there would be six of them), not with university paperwork.

VERIP III came along with a target retirement date of June 30, 1994. Because I would turn sixty that April, I casually but not particularly seriously considered that possibility. I was in no hurry to retire, but the option was there. I discussed the idea with colleagues, some of whom admonished me with "you're too young to retire" and "once you become an emeritus you're viewed as irrelevant." Fortunately I took such advice with many grains of salt mixed with decision-making inertia.

At first VERIP seemed unnecessary. I had a great position that gave me the opportunity to do the teaching I loved and also allowed me considerable flexibility to be involved in numerous off-campus ventures. I had paid my administrative dues. I enjoyed teaching my courses as well as working with doctoral students. Why take a significant pay cut just to have a little more time to myself?

An excerpt from a History Department chair's letter during one of my last personnel evaluations provides a glimpse into how my department viewed my journey. "Cortés' service record simply overwhelms. Cortés served as Chairman of the History Department for four years and left all of us with a sense of nostalgia for the good old days of his reign. Following that Cortés served on CAP, a task which is sometimes enough in itself for ordinary mortals. Yet Cortés sat on many other University committees, and also shirks no Departmental task."

Then things began to mount up. Little on-campus irritants began to bother me more than usual. Campus administrative decisions. A few unpleasant run-ins with colleagues. Recurring battles when it came to my merit increases. The growing realization that I absolutely detested grading papers and examinations.

I imagine there was something else. Maybe it was an inner drive for total liberation from campus obligations so that I could pursue opportunities whenever and wherever they occurred. This was particularly true if I could do things that I felt contributed to a more constructive multicultural future, the kind of things we had been discussing in American Commitments and maybe I had done in my Tokyo trip. Maybe I was tired of

balancing obligations, juggling schedules, and turning down opportunities because I had classes to teach.

Those thoughts must have been weighing on me when one day, in my campus office, I began going through my mail. Something got to me. Maybe a request for a meaningless, time-consuming report. Maybe some little departmental or administrative annoyance. Maybe a note from a colleague that rubbed me the wrong way.

Whatever, there came a moment when I said to hell with it. I decided to take VERIP III. I drove home early, walked into the house, and announced to Laurel that I was going to accept VERIP III. With her usual insouciant nonchalance, she smiled and simply said, "What took you so long to make that decision?"

That was that. I completed the paperwork. A few months later, on July 1, 1994, I became a professor emeritus. In retrospect, it was one of the wisest decisions I have ever made. Certainly I could have stayed the course, earned some advancements, and retired at 70 or 75 or 80 with a much larger monthly retirement stipend. But I would have sacrificed years of liberation, never to be recovered.

Remaining Attached

In actuality, I did not fully secede from UCR. In fact, in retirement I remained more active on campus than I had planned. For three years I taught part-time at UCR, which I continued to enjoy. I tried to peddle my courses to other faculty, in particular my courses on History of the Mass Media and on Film and History, but I couldn't find any takers despite my offer to give them all of my materials. Oh, well. The Ethnic Studies Department, which I had helped salvage ten years earlier, was

now motoring along and was delighted to continue offering the ever-popular Chicano History. Rob Patch, my fellow Latin Americanist, picked up the slack caused by my absence, while I joined him on the search committee to choose my replacement, Jim Brennan.

After those first three years of part-time teaching I stayed busy with other campus initiatives. I taught diversity sessions for the Graduate School of Management's Executive Management Program. I was one of the founding presenters for UCR's Diversity Certificate Program (I gave my first session on April 30, 2009), and continued presenting for the program for more than a decade until the UCR Office of Diversity, Equity, and Inclusion decided to drop me from its participating faculty.

I selectively continued with graduate students. One of them, Shola Lynch, curated a powerful public exhibit, "How Far Have We Come? The Media's Past and Present Representations of African Americans," as her final project. Shola later went on to become a lauded documentary filmmaker (films on Shirley Chisholm and Angela Davis) and a member of the Academy of Motion Picture Arts and Sciences.

I continued to receive sporadic offers to carry out special campus assignments. At the invitation of newly-arrived Chancellor France Córdova, I designed and moderated a televised public roundtable entitled "Creating a New Curriculum for Higher Education," held in conjunction with her March, 2003, inauguration. In 2017 our college dean appointed me to organize the 2018 Tomás Rivera Conference, which featured a student-produced performance of "Stand and Deliver" and a Chicano faculty panel on cultural appropriation.

In addition, over the years the Guru of Getting Along was developing a reputation as a go-to trouble shooter. Our college dean recruited me to spend two years as part-time vice chair of the History Department to help it weather a period of faculty clashes. A few years later I reprised with a one-year dean's assignment to help the Sociology Department, which was also involved in an internal crisis. I was becoming viewed as a fixer, although I'm not certain that I ever truly fixed anything.

I also took great pleasure in maintaining the legacies of two of my late colleagues, Chancellor Tomás Rivera and former Literatures and Languages Chair (and comparative literature guru) Jean-Pierre Barricelli, who died shortly after my retirement. I served on the committees that established scholarship funds in their names (the Rivera fund would ultimately be reformulated into the Tomás Rivera Endowed Chair), continued to participate on the committees that organized the annual Tomás Rivera conferences, and from 1997 to 2025 served on the selection committee for the graduate student winner of the Barricelli award.

I enjoyed remaining active as part of my campus, even as growth and greater commuting made it less of a community. However, now liberated from full-time faculty obligations, I could more freely pick and choose among external opportunities without concern for conflicts with campus duties (except those that I voluntarily accepted). It turns out that this temporal liberation came just at the right time. An opportunity deluge was about to occur. No longer a full-time faculty member, I was about to become a nationally in-demand adjunct. Within a few

years I became a regular part-time faculty member for four institutions:

***The Harvard Summer Institutes for Higher Education.

***the Summer Institute for Intercultural Communication.

***the Federal Executive Institute.

***the University of Maryland, College Park.

Harvard Bound

The 1980's had been great. However, the decade didn't end with me musing, "What's next? Maybe I'll join the faculty at Harvard University." But that's exactly what happened, although I'm not quite sure how that came about. As with so many things in my career, being at the right place at the right time helped.

The Harvard Graduate School of Education offers a variety of advanced education programs, including myriad offerings through the Harvard Summer Institutes of Higher Education focused mainly on college administrators. Around the end of the 1980's the Harvard Summer Institutes decided they needed to do more to incorporate the idea of diversity. But how? And by whom? That's where blind luck entered the picture.

For some of its programs, Harvard had national advisory committees. On one of those committees was a senior California community college administrator. That administrator had heard me speak about diversity at several California statewide conferences and liked the way that approached the topic. He threw my name into the hopper. I was selected. I never found out how or why.

Teaching at Harvard was radically different from anything I had ever done before. The Graduate School of Education had built its reputation around the Harvard case study method, in

which participants read a case, sometimes analyze it in small groups, and later discuss it in large plenary sessions. At Harvard the participants were college administrators, mainly from the United States with a smattering from around the world.

I made my Harvard debut in the summer of 1990 via a 90-minute diversity session for Harvard's Management Development Program. The day before my class I observed a couple of Harvard professors conducting their sessions in the steeply-banked Larson Hall basement classroom amphitheatre. I watched as they nimbly led conversations with some 100 participants forming a tiered semi-circle around the presenter, operating at the base of the classroom in front of huge sliding chalk boards.

It looked effortless. Just get the participants talking and all's well. No problem. After all, I had won UCR's Distinguished Teaching Award and had earned national commendations as a diversity workshop presenter. What could go wrong?

Just about everything. I made three mistakes. I didn't know how to write a good case study. I didn't know how to lead a good case study discussion. Most important, I didn't know how to construct a session that builds incrementally from start to finish the way skilled case study teachers do. In other words, good case study teachers know how to start with conversational chaos and shape it so that, by the end, they are able to draw from those conversations to provide perceptive learning ideas that benefit participants. I wasn't a good case study teacher.

Oh, well. Three strikes, you're out. After the master teachers who had preceded me, I must have come across as a rank amateur. Bye-bye Cambridge, Massachusetts. Except that's not what happened.

All thanks to my institute colleagues. They could have eliminated me on the spot. But something magical occurred. Despite my flailing efforts, some of my colleagues spotted potential. Harvard invited me back for the following summer (1991), this time to teach in two other residential institutes (Management of Lifelong Learning and Institute for Educational Management). I soon began teaching in all three programs.

As the years went by I was also invited to present about diversity at Harvard's various K-12 oriented institutes, such as the Institute for School Leadership and the Harvard Principals Center. Each summer was a different experience. Until the late 2010's and the advent of COVID, I taught for at least one Harvard institute every summer for nearly three decades.

My longevity didn't come about by accident. I benefitted from the hands-on mentorship of a group of Harvard veterans. I became friends with and was mentored by such case study experts experts as Dick Chait, Lee Bolman, Bob Kegan, Joe Zolner, and Jim Honan. It was like attending to a super graduate school. (Bob Kegan and I also did a number of joint presentations for other institutions, including one memorable co-lectured plenary for an island-wide educational conference in San Juan, Puerto Rico.)

I learned that effective case study teaching was an art form. I learned to write case studies that stimulated multiple perspectives, provoked new thinking, and opened the door for constructive conversations rather than leading to pat solutions. I learned how case study artists listen perceptively, draw nuggets from disparate participant comments, and build on those comments to provide broader insights.

I never became a true case study artist, but I did get better. Within a few years I could more-or-less hold my own with the Harvard veterans. Moreover, the Institutes gave me the opportunity to dabble in diversity management before it became calcified by DEI.

Those summers also opened up a new world for me. Invitations to present began arriving from attendees' home institutions. Administratively I had never become more than a department chair, but I was soon advising college presidents, provosts, and deans about diversity issues. One of those invitations came from an MLE attendee who worked at an institution I had never heard of. It was called the Federal Executive Institute. But more on that later.

Summer Institute for Intercultural Communication

I don't know the details of my being tapped by Harvard. However, I vividly remember the circumstances that led to my becoming a faculty member for the Summer Institute for Intercultural Communication. That journey began in the spring of 1991, when I received a call from Lee Knefelcamp, a Columbia University Teachers College professor, who had read some of my articles about diversity and the mass media. Lee asked me to participate on a three-person panel, Toward a Curriculum of Inclusion, for the opening plenary session of the March, 1991, national conference of the American Association for Higher Education.

I arrived in Washington, D.C., a couple of days before the conference. Looking over the list of pre-conference workshops, I chose one that looked interesting, a session on the tension

between Black and White communication styles. It was a career altering choice.

The session was presented by a married couple I had never heard of named Milton and Janet Bennett. It turns out that they were luminaries in the area of intercultural communication, a field that I knew little about. I enjoyed their session and marveled at the way that they fielded tough questions with calmness and dexterity. Afterward I went up and introduced myself.

The next day the Bennetts came to my plenary session. Later they asked me to join them for lunch. Before we had finished, they inquired if, down the line, I would be interested in presenting at their Summer Institute for Intercultural Communication, a three-week gathering at Pacific University in Forest Grove, Oregon. (Years later the Institute would relocate to Reed College in Portland, the city where the Intercultural Communication Institute had its headquarters.)

In July of 1994 I visited the Institute, where I gave the keynote address for one of the Institute's week-long sessions and later gave an evening presentation on diversity in the media. With coaxing from the Bennetts, I returned a year later, in July, 1995, to teach my first regular course there in collaboration with Milton Bennett. We called it Developing a Multicultural Vision (it later morphed into Developing a Multicultural Vision for the New Millennium). From then on I taught every summer until the Institute ceased operation more than twenty years later.

Each week of the Institute was structured around a set of week-long courses on interculturalism (particularly intercultural communication) taught in parallel. Like at

Harvard, the student body consisted of professionals, including many from the business consulting world and even more broadly representative of the world. In addition to the courses, there were nightly two-hour sessions offered by faculty, students, and guest presenters.

SIIC was an instant community. Most of the faculty, attendees, and support staff stayed in campus residence halls and ate their meals in the school cafeteria. Nightly wine-and-cheese gatherings and a boisterous Thursday night Karaoke session added to the communal sense. The Institute was also a time to have fun. Veteran UK interculturalist Richard Harris came up with the idea of our co-authoring a song, "I Am the Very Model of a Modern Interculturalist," based on Gilbert and Sullivan, which we delightfully performed several times at the opening plenary session. Interculturalists took their work seriously, but not solemnly.

In addition to teaching my courses, I also presented evening sessions on diversity and the media. The first one was an eye-opener and in some respects a disaster. It was a presentation on intercultural humor in which I showed film clips of movies, television shows, and stand-up comedians and led attendees in a discussion of what samples might be offensive and why. I thought the session went well, but the next day Janet Bennett called me in and told me that some of the participants were offended by my presentation. They suggested -- maybe beyond suggested -- that the session never be offered again. It wasn't, although in its place I developed an annual popular evening session, Media and the Societal Curriculum.

Life's ironies never cease. Years later Janet Bennett edited The Sage Encyclopedia of Intercultural Competence (2015).

She asked me to write a lengthy entry on Intercultural Humor. I wrote the entry and never heard that it offended anyone (although it may have).

SIIC proved to be an excellent alternative -- maybe even an escape -- from what I perceived as the increasingly dour tone of ethnic studies and multicultural education. There was growing contentiousness within diversity ranks, with sometimes tense debates about multiculturalism, its purposes, and its practices. In contrast, intercultural communication was relentlessly sunny. It unabashedly fostered such constructive ideas as bridge-building and mutual understanding. But there was a downside.

Interculturalists paid minimal attention to systems, particularly their negative ramifications. Critical race theory was nowhere to be found. Janet and Milton identified this as a gap in SIIC's offerings and encouraged me to explore more edgy topics than most of those offered at SIIC. (Interculturalists are intermittently introspective about this deficit, as suggested by the title of the 2025 Society for Intercultural Education, Teaching, and Research national conference --- Inclusive Interculturalism: Purpose, Possibilities and Progress.)

In July, 2002, at SIIC I was fortunate enough to meet Louise Wilkinson, a savvy Boeing diversity trainer. I later invited her to become my teaching collaborator. Since my days with Leon Campbell, I had done little team teaching. Louise brought years of private enterprise experience that I lacked. It turned out to be an excellent fit. Beginning in 2005 we launched a series of new SIIC courses and sessions on such topics as Privilege, Equity, and the use of film in teaching

about similarities and differences based on a developmental model that Louise had created as an outgrowth of her doctoral dissertation.

Participating at SIIC and collaborating with Louise launched me on another new learning curve. This time it was learning about intercultural communication, an under-the-radar academic field. I also became exposed to developmental models and assessment tools used by interculturalists. I became conversant with some of the interculturalist lingo, but at most I considered myself as sort of an "honorary interculturalist." For example, I was never certificated in using any of the field's arcane instruments for measuring such things as intercultural development.

This led to a subsequent irony. In the early 2020's two experienced interculturalists decided to put together a book-length autobiographical collection of people they dubbed "interculturalist pioneers." They selected me as one of those pioneers. I wrote an essay on my late-starting thirty-year pioneering experience in interculturalism.

Federal Executive Institute

Each Harvard summer institute had a specialization. The Institute for the Management of Lifelong Education (MLE) focused on administrators of university outreach programs. For example, it included those involved in what was then known as University Extension: lifelong learning programs oriented toward those already active in professional ranks.

Designed by Robert Kegan and Clifford Baden, MLE walked the walk. Program participants lived in a small residence hall a few blocks from the Larsen classroom where plenary sessions were

held. For two weeks they lived together, ate meals together, and socialized constantly. So did I, housed in the residence hall supervisor's spartan two-room suite.

During one of my MLE sojourns I met Linda Winner, an administrator for another institution I had never heard of: the Federal Executive Institute (FEI) in Charlottesville, Virginia. FEI specialized in the training of federal government leaders. FEI ventures included both specially-designed training sojourns for specific government agencies and more general multi-week residential programs for high-ranking civil servants (mainly GS-14 and GS-15) eager to rise in the ranks to what was then known as the Senior Executive Service.

To that point FEI had done little in the area of diversity, but its leaders were beginning to think about it. Linda liked the way that I approached the topic at Harvard. She asked if I would be willing to help them design the FEI diversity dimension.

My first visit to FEI came on October 23, 1997. It was partly a diversity workshop for FEI faculty and partly an exploratory session about various ways to build diversity into its training program. The conversation ranged widely into the realm of possibilities, including how to integrate the topic into the FEI culture and structure.

As a result of that conversation and follow-up explorations, in early 1999 FEI began inviting me to participate in selected programs being designed for specific agencies. Later, after those "tryouts," I was invited to give a plenary presentation for their bread-and-butter multi-week program: Leadership for a Democratic Society (LDS), whose description echoed American Commitments. My first plenary presentation

occurred on November 9, 1999. It went well enough that FEI began inviting me back several times a year to present two and three-hour diversity workshops for the entire training cohort.

Over the years my diversity plenary sessions changed as I adapted my teaching to the varying needs of government employees and their different agencies. My sessions used various titles, such as "The Changing Face of America." Ultimately my signature session became "Challenges of Leadership in a Changing America." In some respects, that session involved applying American Commitments thinking to the real-life experiences of these varied federal government professionals. Underlying my sessions was one basic question: What leadership qualities can you develop and draw upon to build constructively from diversity and in addressing diversity-infused challenges?

The sessions dealt with diversity writ large. It was not a surrogate term for race and ethnicity. Topics ranged from sex, gender identity, and sexual orientation to religion, disability, language, and citizenship. I had moved well beyond the strictures of both ethnic studies and multicultural education.

My FEI affiliation was the first major situation in which being retired and not having a regular UCR class schedule made a real difference. Because my Harvard and SIIC sojourns came during the summer, they did not conflict with my UCR classes. FEI, however, operated year round and I found myself visiting its Charlottesville campus multiple times a year.

Teaching at SIIC and Harvard had been major transitional experiences for me in subject matter, pedagogical style, and target audience. Likewise FEI. An LDS training cohort consisted of 70-100 high-ranking federal government employees, including physicians, attorneys, scientists, and many others

with advanced college degrees, including Ph.D.'s ranging from astronomy to political science. It was an audience that forced me to operate at the top of my game.

As with Harvard, FEI programs were residential. Participants lived in FEI residence halls on its hilly Charlottesville campus, ate together in the FEI dining room, and socialized nightly. When rooms were available I, too, stayed at FEI. When it was full up, I usually stayed at the nearby English Inn.

Also as with Harvard, I learned while I taught. I left each visit with new insights and understanding. In this case, I left with insights into the myriad ways that the federal government interacted with the American people. I also observed the complexities that inevitably arise from the diverse nature of American society and the resulting challenges faced by different agencies when dealing with diversity realities and imperatives. In some sessions I encountered frustrations and tensions, but overall I left with increasing respect for the professionalism of participants and, in most cases, their willingness to address diversity-related challenges.

Unfortunately this story has a sad postscript. With the 2020 arrival of COVID, my trips to Charlottesville ended. Five years later, in early 2025, President Donald Trump issued an executive order shutting down the Federal Executive Institute.

University of Maryland, College Park

My SIIC, Harvard, and FEI sojourns had introduced me to new audiences. This required adjusting my teaching to the different circumstances and grappling with the everyday application of ideas I had beeen wrestling with since the 1980's. There was no

room for a standardized, boiler plate, buzz word approach to diversity.

In each situation I was far removed from the undergraduate-and-graduate-student focused teaching I had grown accustomed to at UCR. That was a life I had left behind, I thought. However, it turned out that I wasn't through with undergraduate students, after all. But those students would be at the University of Maryland, College Park, not at the University of California, Riverside.

Fortunately I have developed a long-term friendship with Steve Petkas, the now-retired Assistant Director of Maryland's Department of Resident Life. I asked him if he could help me recreate the series of events that brought me to the university and he obliged. Following is that story as he reassembled it.

In 1994 I was the keynote speaker at the Association of College and University Housing Officers (ACUHO) national conference in San Antonio. Steve (then responsible for developing his office's Diversity Action and Implementation Plan) and Pat Mielke, director of Resident Life, were in the office. According to Steve, one of my keynote themes concerned the importance of helping students to develop a better understanding of each other. As Steve wrote, "Pat looked at me and said 'we need to get him to College Park.'"

That led to an invitation for me to visit the Maryland campus in January, 1995, to help Resident Life develop a student dialogue program that Steve had drafted. At that meeting I raised other topics about how their office was addressing student diversity. Ultimately this contributed to the department's development of a Multicultural Philosophy statement.

Future consulting visits paved the way for a year 2000 stay in which Steve, Pat, Sue Briggs, and I hammered out a course/dialogue plan. The University of Maryland featured a large number of living-learning programs, with residential clusters focused on different themes. Sue was the director of the brand new CIVICUS Living-Learning Program based on the concept of civic leadership development.

Along with their varied majors, CIVICUS students took one year-long CIVICUS basic course in the hall's basement classroom. During their first year they studied "Leadership in a Democratic Society." At our meeting, I suggested that the second year's required course be "Leadership in a Multicultural Society," which would explore the special qualities of leading amidst diversity, a theme I had been exploring since the early 1980's. We hammered out the contours of the course. From then on I became a U. of Maryland regular, visiting every fall for two-to-four-week residencies to conduct staff training and to teach segments of "Leadership in a Multicultural Society" beginning in the fall of 2000 and running until the late 2010's.

As one of the capstone options for the course, selected students would be trained as dialogue leaders who, in turn, would facilitate campuswide student dialogues on difficult topics. As well as teaching, I worked closely with Steve and his assistant Rhondie Voorhees in shaping what became known as the Peer Dialogue Leader training program. Students who completed that training would then become discussion leaders in the new Common Ground Multicultural Dialogue Program.

Teaching at Maryland was a constantly-changing, constantly-challenging process. I had helped create K-12 multicultural education from the detached perspective of a

college professor. Now I was actually in the classroom trying to make a difference with college sophomores and, in turn, training them to conduct difficult dialogues. In addition to directing the dialogue training and implementation, Rhondie was completing her higher education doctorate. Her doctoral dissertation was based on an analysis of the Common Ground program.

My staff training efforts were also expanded. Steve became co-director of the Student Affairs Diversity Initiative. This meant my annual visits now involved training sessions for Student Affairs writ large, not just Resident Life.

As in my other three adjunctive ventures, I also became part of a community. This often meant staying in a large private room in a residence hall and eating regularly in the school cafeteria. Over the years these same-time-next-year ventures into Maryland, Harvard, Charlottesville, and Portland led to some of the best friendships I have ever had.

So that was how my "retirement" played out. In many respects I was doing much more teaching than I ever did as a full-time faculty member at UCR, minus the grading of exams and papers. Rather than abandoning teaching, I had entered a migratory world of varying topics, multiple audiences of different ages, professionals involved in widely-differing ventures, and varied circumstances demanding distinct pedagogical styles. It also meant often facing skeptical (sometimes hostile) audiences and continuously challenging my own multicultural thinking. My trajectory had become one of sharing my expertise while simultaneously benefiting from personal lifelong learning.

Branching Out

These four annual teaching ventures provided the backbone of my 1990's post-retirement career. However, there was much more. Lecture and workshop invitations continued to pour in, often from people I had met at those different institutions. People still wanted me to talk about diversity, multiculturalism, the societal curriculum, and my Contextual Interaction Model for the Education of Language Minority Students, but new topics were continually arising.

I even began receiving invitations to give commencement addresses. This involved both community colleges and four-year universities (for example, Depaul University [Chicago], Evergreen State College [Washington}, and Frances Marion University [South Carolina]). As it had been throughout my career, way often led to way through the serendipity of being in the right place at the right time with the right message.

Recall the 1994 ACUHO Conference where Pat Mielke and Steve Petkas "discovered" me for the University of Maryland. At that very same talk was a group of Australian resident life leaders, who invited me to keynote the September, 1995, Australian Association of Heads of Colleges and Halls national conference (there was also a large delegation of New Zealanders). That's when being retired really helped. I didn't have to worry about missing classes or required meetings. I was free to say yes, meaning Laurel and I could spend two glorious weeks in Australia.

The three-day residential life conference was held in Canberra, the Australian capital. Moreover, the conference was book-ended by extended stays in Melbourne and Sydney, connected by wonderful, scenic train rides from Melbourne to Canberra and

from Canberra to Sydney. In Melbourne we stayed in a sprawling top floor residence hall room at the University of Melbourne, a very short walk from the Melbourne Zoo, meaning that we could listen to animal roars from our room. We also had a week of breakfasts of vegemite.

There must be something lucky about San Antonio. Maryland and Australia had "discovered" me there in 1994. Six years later South Korea "discovered" me there. On February 15, 2000, I delivered the keynote address, "Language and Education in the New Millennium," for a National Association for Bilingual Education international conference in San Antonio. Present in the audience was a representative of Yoon's, one of South Korea's largest private English-language academies. Shortly after the conference I received a phone call from the Yoon representative inviting me to give a plenary address at the Korean Association of Teachers of English conference at Hanyang University in Seoul. Of course I was willing to speak. On top of that, Laurel and I had never been to South Korea.

On June 30, 2000, I delivered my plenary talk entitled "Language and Culture: Inevitable Intersections." It was later published as part of the conference papers. A few days later, I gave a series of workshops for the faculty of Yoon's. Added to that, we did our share of touring and every night enjoyed a sumptuous seafood buffet on the roof-top restaurant of our lovely hotel. The Australian and South Korean lecture tours were indicative of the ongoing expansion of my journey into the complex world of diversity and multiculturalism.

Media Man

However, as busy as I became, I never lost my concern with the media. I continued to focus on the idea that had super-charged my career: the societal curriculum, particularly its mass media dimensions. But a shift in emphasis was beginning to take place.

Most of my media effort had involved analysis, with a handful of side ventures into creativity. I had helped create the documentary "Northwest from Tumacácori" and had written the script for a PBS documentary on Latinos in politics. I had also made three guest host appearances on the national PBS series "Why in the World?" However, in the 1990's, even though I continued to write and speak *about* the media, I began edging into greater involvement in the creative side of media. Consider two examples.

Kansas City's Hallmark Foundation decided to launch a youth conflict resolution project called "Talking with TJ." It would involve creating a video series that youth groups could use to help young people learn to deal with social challenges in a collaborative and constructive manner. The project director invited me to serve on the small advisory committee. It was an ideal fit, particularly considering my growing dedication to the idea of bridge-building.

In the real world of advisory committees, there is great variation. Some are little more than window dressing involving some paperwork, a few desultory meetings, and random ideas left behind (and often ignored) as you moved on to your next meeting. But this was not the way "Talking with TJ" worked.

"TJ" was hands on from the beginning, with deep discussions about plot concepts, interpersonal relations principles, and how we could draw effectively on scholarly research to actually help

young people. Scripts were vetted in detail. Filming did not go forward until we felt confident that we had good scripts and effective training materials for youth group leaders.

Was "TJ" a good series? I think it was first class, particularly for its time (1993 and 1994). Moreover, it was supremely "woke" back before "woke" became an ideological football. The series featured a super-sharp Black high school girl in a wheelchair who conducted a call-in talk show for kids who encountered personal problems. For each segment we created a brief video dramatizing the conflict and resolution, while we also developed support materials for discussion leaders in youth groups that used the series. Each episode and training package bore the marks of intensive committee activity. By the time we had finished the two-year project, the committee felt pride in a project well done.

"Talking with TJ" was one example of how my career was moving beyond both college and K-12 education tightly defined. There was a whole societal curriculum out there and I was moving beyond writing about it. I was helping to create it.

But "TJ" wasn't alone in my media adventures. At about the same time that Hallmark "discovered" me, I was contacted by the Video Journal of Education, which was developing a video-based training series for K-12 teachers and administrators. Would I be interested in being the main speaker for a video on multicultural education? Interested? Try stopping me.

On December 12, 1993, the Journal team filmed me while I was giving a day-long multicultural education workshop at the National Staff Development Association national conference. This was followed by on-site filming of classrooms and interviews around the country, including in districts with which

I had worked (I was not involved in the filming itself). The two-video series, "Diversity in the Classroom," was completed and published in 1994.

Two years later Lee Canter & Associates, an educational firm, decided to create a video-based teacher training course. They asked me to be the featured speaker in a video segment entitled "Introduction to Diversity." The session was filmed with a live audience of teachers in 1995.

My corpus of media-related activities was expanding. Along with my media scholarship, I was becoming involved in media creation. But more was yet to come.

"How the Media Teach about Diversity"

Despite my many activities, I hadn't stopped writing. In fact, as the decade moved toward its conclusion, my research and experience were about to produce maybe the most significant published product of my years of grappling with the media. Once again, my friend and mentor James Banks played a key role.

Teachers College Press had contracted with Jim to edit a new book series on multicultural education. In February, 1996, he proposed that I write a book about the media for his series. This was both an opportunity and a challenge.

It was an opportunity to culminate my exploration of an area in which I had been involved since the late 1970's, when my first article on the societal curriculum was published in *Educational Leadership*. For two decades I had massaged that concept in talks, workshops, and myriad articles. I had drawn upon it for the Contextual Interaction Model that had become foundational for bilingual education. Jim's proposal meant that it was put-up-or-shut-up time.

However, Jim's offer also created a conundrum. Since the 1980's I had been writing articles, giving lectures, and conducting workshops on the topic of feature motion pictures as a multicultural curriculum of their own. I had completed several drafts of a book-in-progress with a working title of "A History of Race and Ethnicity in American Motion Pictures." I still had a ways to go, but I was excited about the prospects.

Considering my already congested schedule, accepting Jim's proposal would require setting aside work on my movie book. I would need to deal with the media more broadly (mass media writ large rather than only feature films) and in a more applied manner (the implications and applications of media within the classroom). Not that I was starting from scratch. For two decades I had been exploring my idea of the societal curriculum, particularly through the lens of the media. Take, for example, my 1992 article, "Pride, Prejudice and Power: The Mass Media as Societal Educator on Diversity."

But conceptualizing and writing an entire book on the topic was a different degree of challenge. As I pondered the decision, I realized that devoting so much time to Jim's book might also mean that I would never get back to my movie book. As it turns out I didn't, although the latest book draft remains as part of my papers for those interested in what might have been.

I accepted Jim's offer. My possible place in film studies scholarship had to give way to my commitment to multicultural education and the completion of my societal curriculum journey. I had to start that book from scratch, but writing that manuscript became a true labor of love and the culmination of a journey.

I completed the book in 1999. My hope was that it would help teachers and contribute to greater multicultural understanding. I also hoped that it would take the field of K-12 education by storm, which it didn't. But what I had no way of knowing was that the book would launch me on an entirely new journey in the first decade of the 2000's.

Part of that fortune lies with my Teachers College Press editor, Brian Ellerbeck. In writing the manuscript I had used the working title, "How the Media Teach about Diversity." The title conveyed that the book was about the theme of diversity, not just about the media treatment of individual societal groups based on race, ethnicity, sex, sexual orientation, religion, and disability. There had been hordes of books about the media treatment of those different groups. To the best of my knowledge, mine is still the only book to grapple with the media treatment of the larger theme of diversity.

Here's where luck entered. Brian wanted a catchier title. He came up with "The Children Are Watching." When I raised the issue that the book was not about children's media per se, Brian responded that much of the book dealt with children, so we were in the ballpark. His title would capture more attention. I agreed. He was oh so right. That book title alone helped put me on the children's television radar and would radically alter my 21st-century trajectory.

Chapter 7

The 2000's: Curtain Going Up

The 1990's had been a decade of major transitions. I had begun the decade as a full-time UCR professor combined with a busy schedule of professional and community service. I ended the decade as a nationwide faculty member for various institutions teaching myriad diversity-related topics to vastly different audiences.

Come the 2000's, my professional terrain would shift again. The 1990's shift had been driven by offers from institutions. The 2000's shifts came mainly as the result of a series of muses: various women who inspired, prodded, and advised me as I faced multiple decisions. Together they pushed me into a series of enormous leaps from critique into creativity, including both television and theatre.

I suppose I had always had a creative itch, starting with modest roles in high school theatre productions. Over the years I had continued to dabble in theatre. I had taken theatre classes while pursuing my Columbia Journalism degree, including one notable course with famed cultural critic Gilbert Seldes. I had worked as a publicist for the American Shakespeare Festival, had found an acting niche with the Augusta Players while in the Army, and even played the head of the band of murderous knights in a Phoenix production of T. S. Eliot's "Murder in the Cathedral."

There had also been occasional forays into film and television. "Northwest from Tumacácori." A documentary film on Latinos in politics. Three guest host appearances for "Why in the World." "Talking with TJ." The Video Journal of

Education. I guess I should add brief on-screen appearances in two feature films shot in Riverside: the science fiction "Bug" (1975), in which I had two brief walk-on moments as a professor, and the short political thriller "Graffiti" (1985), in which I appeared in one scene with my wife, Laurel, as a Latin American elite couple.

Alongside these ventures into media-making I had developed a comprehensive knowledge of the feature film treatment of race and ethnicity and had spent more than two decades examining the societal curriculum's impact on school education. This led to the completion of my manuscript, "How the Media Teach about Diversity," which my editor retitled *The Children Are Watching,* relegating my original words to the subtitle. My fortune in having such an imaginative editor became clear in January, 2000, when I met the decade's first two muses.

Dolly and Dora

That first magical meeting occurred on January 25, 2000. I had gone to Los Angeles to give a plenary address, "The Power of the Media and Its Impact on Latinos," for the Sparking the Connections: La Familia, los Niños y la Comunidad Conference of the Families and Work Institute and the National Latino Children's Institute. My talk was followed by a panel providing other media perspectives. Among the panelists was a young lady named Dolly Espinal, who described her role in the development of a new Nickelodeon pre-school children's show featuring a Latina heroine, which would begin screening that fall.

Following the session the show's executive producer, Chris Gifford, a children's television veteran, asked me to join him and Dolly for lunch. We talked about the show, including how it

had originally been constructed around "Benjamin the Bunny." However, one of the Nickelodeon vice presidents had attended a Latina conference where she her criticisms about the absence of Latina role models in children's television. Returning to Nickelodeon, she announced that Benjamin the Bunny would be transformed into a young Latina. That young Latina was ultimately named Dora the Explorer.

The producer needed help making the Benjamin-to-Dora transition. Might I be interested in working with the show? I was interested, but restrained. With my multiple teaching positions, busy public lecturing schedule, and numerous articles due, I wasn't sure about making such a time commitment. So I countered with the suggestion that he, Dolly, and rest of the Nickelodeon team read my new book, *The Children Are Watching*. If they liked the way that I approached things, we could explore the possibilities.

It turns out that Nickelodeon purchased several copies of my book and some of the Nick folks actually read it. They invited me to New York. On May 22, 2000, I had my first meeting with the Dora team and a variety of Nickelodeon executives. By the time the day was out I had signed on as a part-time consultant for "Dora the Explorer." It was the beginning of an adventure that would unwind for the next two decades.

I began a new learning curve, starting with getting to know the "Dora" team structure. The show had two driving forces. First was the creative team, led by Chris Gifford, which developed storylines, wrote scripts, and supervised the show's production. Then there was Dora's educational team, which came up with the idea of building the interactive show around Howard Gardner's idea of multiple intelligences (at that time seven).

When I joined the "Dora" ensemble there were about a dozen consultants. Within a few years Nickelodeon whittled the consulting team down to three: an educational consultant; a Spanish language consultant; and me as *the* cultural consultant. Ultimately my title became Creative/Cultural Advisor not only for "Dora the Explorer," but also for its sequels, "Go, Diego, Go!" and "Dora and Friends: Into the City."

I don't know about the other original cultural consultants, but I felt very comfortable working with Dora's educational team and drawing on Gardner's multiple intelligences. My close friend Sue Teele, director of UCR's educational extension, happened to be an internationally-recognized expert on multiple intelligences. Over the years she and I had collaborated in a number of joint workshops combining multicultural education and multiple intelligences. For one of Sue's multiple intelligences conferences I gave the plenary address and later served as a co-panelist with Gardner. So in those early Dora consultant gatherings I had the advantage of being highly conversant with the educational principles informing the show.

My major role became reading and commenting on treatments and scripts for each show, as well as helping to shape overall themes and series arcs. When I joined the group, planning for "Dora" was well along. My early contributions were value added. In contrast, I was on the ground floor of discussions and planning for such sequels as "Go, Diego, Go!" and "Dora and Friends: Into the City." In the process I returned to my theatrical public relations roots and began writing a series of mock interviews for the "Dora" and "Diego" creative team. In these ersatz encounters I had the interviewer pose tricky and

sometimes hostile questions, for which I wrote possible answers for the creators to consider.

I had truly turned the corner. No longer was I merely critiquing the societal curriculum. I was contributing to that curriculum.

As my children's television bona fides grew, other Nickelodeon producers began asking me to help in the development of their series. I also started giving talks and workshops on children's television, as well as writing articles on "Dora" and other related topics. My book title had hinted at some expertise in the field. My year of work with "Dora" and its sequels added knowledge that could only be gained through hands-on experience.

Alana

Dolly and Dora were newcomers to my life's journey. Another muse, my daughter Alana Madrugada Cortés, had been part of my trek since her birth on September 6, 1968. Somwhere in the mists of the late 1990's, the now grown-up late-twenties Alana made a simple but life-altering request. It went something like this.

"Dad, over the years I've heard lots of family stories. But nobody ever writes them down. I'm afraid they're going to get lost. Could you write some of them down for me?"

That simple request added to my increasingly unsimple life. But it was a request I couldn't ignore. I began writing down family stories. Individual incidents. Mini-portraits of family members. Reflections on my past. Sketches of various trips. The recollection and recording of personal and family stories became part of my writing routine. .

Recall that for two years (1984-1985) I had worked with my Parkinson's-challenged father on the never-completed (actually barely started) "Los Corteses: A California Saga." Those two years gave me a head start on the Alana project. The random documents that Dad and I had collected were there for reference.

I chose not to give my stories to Alana to read. Rather I took advantage of her periodic visits to Riverside to read them aloud to her. This gave her the opportunity to react, ask questions, and pursue clarifications. That process went on for I don't know how many months until Alana hit me with a new request. My stories were all over the place. She couldn't keep track of what happened and how the various events fit together. Would it be too much trouble for me to create a family and personal chronology?

Alana was right. The stories went every which way. So I rearranged the things I had written in rough chronological order and added material to fill in the gaps. I didn't keep track of the page count, but before I was aware of length I had written several hundred pages about myself and our family.

Then came an eye-opening event. One day I was reading vignettes to Alana while we were sitting in Bob's Big Boy restaurant in Riverside. One of the vignettes was particularly dramatic, funny, and, in its own way, shocking. It was the story of my father's brief late 1940's flirtation with becoming a polo player. He actually joined Kansas City's Mission Brook Polo Club and even bought a polo pony. His major problem was that he could barely ride a horse, so his forays into games were both comical and terrifying. The frustration of Dad's riding inadequacy finally hit home for him. Sadly (but with relief

from the family), Dad ultimately sold his horse, quit playing, and resigned from the polo club.

As I read that story to Alana, there was a man sitting in the adjoining booth with his back to her. When I finished the story he got up, came over to us, told me how much he enjoyed my tale, and asked if I had any more. That stroke of fate ignited something in me. If that one story could draw a stranger's attention, how about some of the others? Maybe, just maybe, my family-oriented chronology had the potential for becoming an actual book.

From that point forward, my writing changed. When I thought about readers, I went beyond family members. I began looking for connective themes upon which I could hang my family narrative. Sometimes serendipity opened doors to personal discovery. In April, 2002, I spent a week as writer-in-residence at my former independent school in Kansas City, Missouri. I arranged a night with three of my former high school classmates to drink wine and reflect on our time together, unearthing long-submerged memories and unanswered questions.

I also came up with the idea of embedding each vignette in a letter, beginning with "Dear Alana" and ending with "Love, Dad." My Alana project was now going on five years. Myriad stories, all beginning with "Dear Alana" and ending with "Love Dad," had been organized into a rough chronology. The project wasn't yet ready for prime time, but I felt the need for professional feedback.

In October, 2002, I sent my sprawling manuscript-in-progress to my long-time history book agent Gerard McCauley and asked if he would give the manuscript a quick look

to see if it had real potential. Gerry read the manuscript and saw promise, but wrote that he wasn't the right agent for this particular project. Instead he sent it on to Geri Thoma, a well-known literary agent friend of his, part of the Elaine Markson Literary Agency. I was blown away . . . for a short time.

In early 2003, a package arrived from New York. It contained my manuscript. Geri's letter informed me that she wasn't interested in the book. I wrote her back asking why. She responded that she had read enough to conclude that she didn't want to handle it. In particular she referred to my letters-to-Alana format as a "stilted device."

Geri was right. My manuscript wasn't really a book-in-progress. Rather it was a rigid, suffocatingly-detailed family chronicle. Instead of a whammo opening chapter followed by an engrossing narrative structure, the manuscript began with a reasonably deadly explanation of my family tree, starting with my three immigrant grandparents, and then wandered into a series of letters of varying interest. The manuscript didn't perk the agent's interest. It wouldn't have perked mine either. (Note: the rejected "Letters to Alana" manuscript is part of my UCR collection.)

Geri Thoma had done me an immense favor. She woke me up. I had to make a decision. Should I just complete the family chronicle, give it to Alana, send a copy to my brother, and that's that? Or should I try to turn it into a book? I decided to go for it: a book it would become.

That brief interaction with the distant agent created three challenges. I needed a better book structure. I need to find a

coherent and compelling basic theme. And I needed to junk the "Dear Alana Love Dad" artifice. I began serious rewriting.

I also needed reader feedback. To test the waters I came up with an idea. I had developed a lively lecturing schedule --- sometimes 75-100 talks a year --- so I was constantly finding myself at conferences and college campuses. My new gambit was this: when I received invitations, I would negotiate the terms of the deal, including what I would do. Then I would offer to do an unpaid extra: a reading from my new book-in-progress. That was my way of getting ongoing feedback on my efforts.

The process worked. Audience responses gave me a sense of reader reaction (OK, listener reaction). Audience questions suggested where I had not been sufficiently clear. Maybe most important, audience reactions revealed what themes had come through most effectively. One theme topped them all: my experience of being raised by a Mexican Catholic father and an Austro-Ukrainian Jewish mother at a time and place of absolute racial segregation and deep religious divisions (Kansas City, Missouri, in the early post-World War II era). It was not only my youthful experience that grabbed listeners. It was also the long-range impact of that experience on the rest of my life.

Dawn and Bethany

Then came an auspicious night in July, 2003, when lightning struck again in the form of my next muse. It occurred at the Summer Institute for Intercultural Communication, where I was giving an evening reading from my manuscript. Among the several dozen attendees happened to be a young lady named Dawn Davies. After the reading Dawn made a startling suggestion: she liked my

story and suggested that I turn it into a good one-person play. It had the right elements: compelling narrative structure infused by drama, conflict, humor, and surprises. Dawn, a former theatre director and now an English language teacher in Seoul, South Korea, offered to help me.

Dawn's suggestion and offer were too tempting to turn down. They appealed to the ham in me. I didn't jump right into writing a play, but I began contemplating the idea and sketching its possible structure. I continued working on the book, but in the next few months the idea of a play continued to crystallize.

I had junked the "Letters to Alana" concept for my book, but the idea of communicating directly with Alana still intrigued me. This led to the idea of building the play around a conversation with my daughter. In that conversation I would relate stories from my life, while focusing on the theme of ethnic and religious conflict both within my family and in other dimensions of my personal journey. I bounced the idea off Dawn, who liked it.

Then I did an audaciously mindless thing. As part of being a public lecturer, I continually updated a list of topics on which I could speak: mainly workshop and lecture titles. When requested, I would send the list to those interested in inviting me to speak. In November of 2003 I updated my list for 2004 and decided to include my play title, "A Conversation with Alana: One Boy's Multicultural Rite of Passage." Since it would be months before anyone expressed any interest in the play, I would have plenty of time to write it.

Wrong. Shortly after I had updated my list, I received a December speaking invitation from Valencia Community College in Orlando, Florida. They would like me to give a morning

diversity workshop for the college executive team and then do an afternoon public event on December 4, 2003, less than a month away. This was an unusual invitation, as December tended to be a dead month for presentations. So I sent them my presentation list without thinking that I had recently added the unwritten "Alana." Guess what they chose? "Alana."

The smart thing would have been to explain the confusion and ask them to pick another topic. But the challenge was too exciting. I would write the play and debut it in Orlando. I contacted my friend Eric Barr, chair of the UCR Theatre Department, and asked him how long a one-person play should be. He told me that, for a non-actor (me) performing a play written by a non-dramatist (also me), if I could hold an audience's interest for sixty minutes it would be a miracle. Well, sixty minutes it would be.

So in Orlando on December 4, 2003, I gave my first performance of "A Conversation with Alana." Well, maybe not. It was hardly a performance. In front of an audience of several hundred people I stood behind a podium and told my story -- spoke to Alana about my story -- for sixty minutes. I thought I had delivered a good tale. However, it wasn't really a play, just a narrative from behind a lectern to an unseen Alana. I could tell from the muted audience reaction that I had not hit a home run.

Afterward I chatted about the play with a few people. During a lull in the conversation a young man came up to me and asked if we could talk privately. A Muslim, he thanked me for telling my story and then related his own situation. He was engaged to a young Jewish woman, but the two of them had avoided talking about religion. No longer, he said. My story had

reached him. They would start discussing religion that very evening.

That one serendipitous moment encouraged me to continue with my playwriting quest. At that moment I fully realized how significantly the idea of intermarriage and its ramifications for people's lives lay at the heart of my Alana-inspired journey. It sharpened the focus of both my play and my book, which I had set aside during that furious month of playwriting. My story would no longer be a desultory recounting of my life. It would be a personal exploration of the human implications of ethnic and religious mixedness.

The play didn't take shape quickly. I tried it out in a few other settings, but the "performances" remained little more than structured readings from my book-in-progress clad in the form of telling my story to my daughter. I tried to enliven the performances by asking one young lady in the audience to serve as my Alana so I could talk directly to her. It worked, but only up to a point. The gimmick was too constricting and artificial. The so-called play remained me just telling a story.

Then, on September 18, 2004, some nine months after my inaugural effort, Alana saw my play. She came with her husband Richard Lawton, a talented furniture designer. Afterward Rich came up with an idea that began the process of transforming my narrative into a play. Instead of choosing an audience members to be my Alana, why not personify Alana by using an empty chair on the stage next to me. Talk to the chair as if Alana were sitting in it.

Rich's suggestion liberated me. It gave me greater freedom to actually talk to Alana: that is, to the invisible Alana in

the chair. And listen to her. I wrote her lines -- responses and questions -- so that I could pause and listen to her silent voice as she reacted and interrogated me. As my voice became more responsive to Alana, the story began to flow more freely.

I was on my way. The play, however, although more interactive was still mainly a narrative. Dawm spotted this during the following summers when I reprised "Alana" at the Summer Institute. Dawn insisted that I needed to get away from just telling my story. I needed to get out from behind the podium, which held my script, and start acting out the vignettes. Make them come alive. Turn "Alana" into a real play, not just a me-talk-you-listen narrative.

Dawn also made another critical suggestion. I needed to rehearse with an Alana. Maybe hire a UCR theatre student to react to me as a stand-in for Alana. So it was back to my friend Theatre professor Eric Barr, who recommended one of his best students, a young lady named Bethany Kramer. who was studying acting and directing.

My first workout with Bethany occurred in February, 2007, in the UCR History Department library. It felt awkward as hell to put on a 60-minute performance for a young lady I didn't know, a young lady periodically jotting down notes about whatever. When I had finished, Bethany made it clear. No, "Alana" was not yet a real play. Yes, we can turn it into a play.

In a series of one-on-one sessions, Bethany pushed me in the directions suggested by Dawn. I transformed stories into real scenes, using multiple voices. I began doing accents: my formidable Ukrainian grandfather; my charming Austrian grandmother; my sometimes-fierce Mexican father; and my

flamboyant, erratic Jewish mother. I even developed specific gestures and body positions for each character.

The effort paid off. Through the guidance and prodding of Dawn and Bethany and the use of Rich's chair idea, "A Conversation with Alana" finally made the transition from book draft through oral narrative and finally into a real 60-minute one-person autobiographical play. In the process the play developed a bit of a cult following. To date I have performed it nearly 160 times around the country, primarily at conferences and on college campuses. In 2022 the play was published by Bad Knee Press, although to the best of my knowledge nobody else has performed it.

Maybe most rewarding have been the post-performance discussions, which sometimes run for over an hour. Lots of questions and personal testimonials. Audience members of various ethnic and religious backgrounds sharing their stories and pointing out where elements of Alana made special connections with their own experiences. I had finally written a play.

Back to My Memoir

But not just a play. Writing and performing "Alana" infused my book-in-progress. No longer "Letters to Alana," the book manuscript had morphed into "Rose Hill: An Intermarriage before Its Time." The intermarriage referred to involved my Mexican Catholic father and Austro-Ukrainian Jewish mother getting married in 1933, when such marriages were an anomaly. Rose Hill was the Kansas City Jewish cemetery where my folks are buried, a cemetery that plays a dramatic role in both the book and the play.

Writing and honing the play had taken me away from the book. Now the play was galvanizing the manuscript. In 2009 I happened to mention my book to a close friend, Marion Mitchell Wilson, founder and director of Inlandia Institute, a Riverside writers collaborative. Inlandia had launched a publications program in collaboration with Heyday, a well-regarded Berkeley, California, publisher. Marion asked if Inlandia could consider my book.

At that point I hadn't begun thinking about a publisher. I trusted Marion and, with delight, said yes. I put the manuscript through another polishing and then gave it to her. She read it and liked it. The next step was sending it to Heyday for approval.

But Heyday didn't accept it. The press turned me down. Oh, well, maybe it needs more work. I was disappointed but determined to keep trying.

Then occurred one of the strangest events of my career, a meeting with Malcolm Margolin, Heyday's founding publisher. Marion had scheduled Malcolm to come to Riverside on March 4, 2010, to speak about publishing. I had a scheduling conflict, but asked Marion if I could meet with Malcolm earlier in the day.

Malcolm and I met at the Inlandia office and immediately hit it off. Our delightful conversation ranged into various subjects. Almost offhandedly I mentioned "A Conversation with Alana." Malcolm seemed intrigued and asked me to tell him more about the play. Well, why tell him about the play when I could actually perform scenes from it, even without a script?

Malcolm seemed taken with the play. After several scenes there was a long silence. Malcolm shook his head and told me he

was going to do something he had never done before. Could he take another look at my "Rose Hill" manuscript? Why not? I told him I would send him a more up-to-date version

I well remember the night when I learned that Heyday wanted my book. I had just given a conference talk and a play performance at Central Michigan University, to be followed by a talk at the University of Vermont. When I got to my Burlington, Vermont, hotel, late that evening, I checked my email. There was a letter from Gayle Wattawa, Heyday acquisitions editor. Heyday had decided that it wanted to publish "Rose Hill."

But Gayle's letter was not just a simple letter of acceptance. It was an incisive multi-page analysis of the manuscript with pointed recommendations for improving it. I had a presentation scheduled the following morning, but the adrenaline was too much. I stayed up and wrote her a lengthy response with my ideas for addressing her recommendations. Game on.

The crazy journey had been launched more than a decade earlier by Alana's request for written family stories. It had been fostered by various muses along the way until it arrived at a happy ending. *Rose Hill* was published by Heyday in 2012. Combined with the cult popularity of "A Conversation with Alana" and its later (2022) publication, I had hit an autobiographical grand slam.

Two final notes. I still hadn't given up on my father's dream of "Los Corteses: A California Saga." *Rose Hill* and *A Conversation with Alana* turned out to be different kinds of animals. So I made another effort, one I never fully followed through on (maybe I will one of these days). My effort consisted of a September 9, 2009, letter to a number of my

Cortés cousins with the idea of writing a collaborative history of the family. We would pose family questions to each other, collect our varying answers, and publish them as a multi-perspective recollection of family lore. I called it sort of a Wikinquiry. I didn't receive many enthusiastic responses, so I let the idea drop. Maybe someday I'll return to it.

Second, the *Rose Hill* journey also connected with my scholarly thinking. My parents' intermarriage had helped shape my life. What about other people? What about the personal journeys of the millions of others who came from mixed backgrounds? I began exploring these questions in workshops, lectures, and professional articles. My article, "Mixed-Race Children: Building Bridges to New Identities" appeared in the Winter, 1999 issue of *Reaching Today's Youth.* The following year my article, "The Diversity Within: Intermarriage, Identity, and Campus Community," was published in the March-April, 2000, issue of *About Campus.* Years later I would become a member of the advisory board for the *Journal of Critical Mixed Race Studies*.

The Grier Living Histories

Once again way led on to way. My Rose Hill/Conversation with Alana journey had led me to the directing mentorship of Bethany Kramer. Circumstances would extend that collaboration.

The city of Riverside had just built a new outdoor terrace on the top (seventh) floor of City Hall. Named the Grier Pavilion, it honored a number of people of varied ethnic backgrounds who had contributed to the city. To dedicate the terrace, Mayor Ron Loveridge came up with the idea of staging a performance piece about the honorees. Ron, a UCR political

science professor, and I had been friends for some thirty-five years. He asked me for advice. Did I know anyone who might be able to create such an event?

I immediately thought of Bethany Kramer. Ron ran with my suggestion. He met with Bethany and the city ultimately contracted with her to create a performance piece, the "Grier Living Histories."

Bethany was starting from scratch. However, in contemporary lingo, Bethany was truly networked. She knew writers, actors, and others in the theatre world. She commissioned the writing of a series of theatrical vignettes to bring to life the Grier Pavilion honorees.

One of the honorees was Jesse Ybarra, the late director of Riverside's Eastside Settlement House. Playwright Kate Anger had written a riveting two-person vignette involving Jesse and a young Chicano who had stumbled into bad circumstances in the Eastside neighborhood, which had its share of youth crime. Scenes on the Eastside were interspersed with flashbacks to Ybarra's soul-stirring experiences as a World War II medic.

Bethany approached me about playing the part of Jesse Ybarra. At first I turned her down. I had known Jesse and I neither looked nor spoke like him. I even gave Bethany the names of other possibilities to play that role.

But Bethany was determined. She had helped me bring "A Conversation with Alana" to life. She convinced me that I could become an excellent Jesse Ybarra. Kate Anger's wonderful script sealed the deal. The more I read it, the more I realized that I really wanted to play Jesse.

I performed the vignette some half dozen times around the city in 2008. Jesse Ybarra's daughter attended one of those

performances and thanked me afterward. I was no longer Carlos Cortés playing himself. I was actually becoming an actor, albeit a not-very-experienced one. It had been a long arc since my high school days more than fifty years earlier when I played Casca in Shakespeare's "Julius Caesar."

Homage to Tomás Rivera: A Trilogy

Between "Dora the Explorer," "A Conversation with Alana," and the vignette about Jesse Ybarra, I was on a creative roll. Nothing in the previous decades had prepared me for this new life. However, there was more to come: a series of performance pieces about my late friend and UCR Chancellor Tomás Rivera.

It started quite innocently, much as had Alana's request for me to write down family stories. In this case my muse was Concha Rivera, Tomás' widow, who was still living in Riverside. Concha's idea was very simple. She would like to commemorate the twenty-fifth anniversary of Tomás' becoming UCR chancellor in 1979 by holding an event in his honor. Of course I agreed to help carry out her wishes for a twenty-fifth anniversary event.

But let's back up a bit. When Tomás Rivera died suddenly of a heart attack in 1984, I lost a dear friend even as UCR lost a Chancellor. His wife, Concha, had lost the love of her life. Concha, however, was determined that Tomás would not be forgotten. UCR soon became dotted with the Rivera name. The small space in front of the UCR administration building was renamed Rivera Plaza. A short time later the central library was named the Tomás Rivera Library. And there was more.

Concha decided to launch an annual Rivera conference at UCR. She convinced my friend Robert Nava, a UCR community affairs stalwart, to take charge of the conferences. The 1990's

featured a series of conferences with major national speakers and a Rivera banquet in the Student Commons restaurant.

In addition, Concha decided to establish a Rivera scholarship fund to provide fellowships for Chicano (maybe Chicano/Latino) students. She asked me to work with her on the project and to serve on the scholarship selection committee. I couldn't say no.

Then California voters stepped in and passed a statewide proposition making race-based scholarships illegal. The scholarship fund could no longer serve its original purpose. So Concha pivoted, transforming the fund into an endowed chair in literature and creative writing in honor of Tomás' literary achievements. Making that shift turned out to be a convoluted and sometimes fiery process, with various administrators trying to make the fund more flexible and easier to change. But with my support Concha stuck to her guns and the Rivera Chair came into existence.

The first Rivera Chair turned out to be Juan Felipe Herrera, a supremely imaginative literary artist who would go on to become the California and then U.S. Poet Laureate. I continued to serve on the Rivera committee and worked closely with Juan Felipe, particularly as he coordinated the annual Rivera conferences. Three of those conferences would provide an opportunity for me to honor Tomás while also honing my newly-discovered theatrical bent.

For the April 29, 2005, Rivera conference, I envisioned, wrote, produced, and served as narrator of an 80-minute story of Tomás' life. Juan Felipe came up with the main title, "After the Rain," referring to the fact that an unexpected rainstorm had struck Riverside in the middle of Tomás' inauguration

ceremony. The outdoor ceremony was halted before Tomás had the opportunity to complete his chancellorial acceptance address. That unread address, as read in part by Juan Felipe, became a core part of "After the Rain. Tomás Rivera: The Legacy and Life." (The official title of the day's celebration was "Tomás Rivera: Celebration of a Life. The story of Tomás Rivera as told in his own words and those of his friends and admirers.")

Four years later Juan Felipe asked me if I could come up with a shorter homage to Tomás, to be performed as part of the evening program at another Rivera conference that took place on April 24, 2009. Once again working with Bethany Kramer to stage the piece, I devised a point-counter-point performance piece entitled, "Tomás Rivera: A Eulogy," involving me and Hector Ceballos, Jr., a talented singer-guitarist who had also performed in "After the Rain." For twenty minutes Hector and I alternated voices. I told Tomás' story, read from his epic poem, "*The Searchers,*" and drew on some of his public pronouncements, interspersed with Hector playing and singing Mexican music. We received a standing ovation.

A few years later, maybe drawn by the success of "After the Rain" and "Tomás Rivera: A Eulogy," Juan Felipe approached me with the idea of our jointly creating a full-scale musical tribute to Tomás. I agreed. We called our show "We Are Not Alone: Tomás Rivera, a Musical Narrative." "We are not alone" echoes a haunting, oft-repeated line in Tomás' *The Searchers.* We staged the piece once, on April 22, 2011, at the UCR art museum in downtown Riverside.

Our project turned out to be a bridge too far. The piece contained some nice ideas, interesting music by Occidental College music professor Bruno Louchouarn, and a decent book and

intermittently imaginative lyrics written by Juan Felipe and me. But the show didn't quite gel. The production was also plagued by the fact that the sound system failed during the performance, making much of the music (and therefore some of the plot and lyrics) unintelligible. Nice try, but not what we had hoped for.

"We Are Not Alone" completed my Rivera trilogy. Four years later, on December 3, 2013, I participated in another production about Rivera, this one mounted by Tiffany Ana López, Juan Felipe's successor as Rivera Chair. Tiffany had taught a research seminar on Rivera's life. This led to a 2013 public presentation entitled "Civic Morality: The Role of the Chicano Academic and the Chicano Non-Academic Community." Under Tiffany's direction, her seminar students drew a verbal portrait of Tomás administrative and public service journey. She also recruited me to participate in the presentation, speaking about my personal relationship to Tomás.

But my chancellorial creative activities didn't end with Tomás Rivera. In 2002, physicist France Córdoba became the UCR Chancellor. As part of the planning for her March, 2003, inauguration, she decided to hold a two-hour televised roundtable on the future of higher education. The dozen or so participants consisted of college presidents who had come for her inauguration, UCR faculty, and Riverside community leaders. France asked me to moderate and help design the event, which I gladly did.

Quite unexpectedly, creative endeavors had become the center of my 2000's. Working with Nickelodeon, writing my memoir, performing my one-person play, playing Jesse Ybarra, creating my Rivera trilogy, and moderating France Córdoba's

inauguration roundtable made for a full ten years. The Harvard Summer Institutes for Higher Education, the Federal Executive Institute, the Summer Institute for Intercultural Communication, and the University of Maryland filled up much of my remaining public lecturing dance card.

However, my publications journey continued. I took a first stab at a book-length reflection on my professional career. And I became a co-author of a K-6 social studies textbook.

The Making – and Remaking – of a Multiculturalist

Jim Banks and Teachers College Press were happy with the success of *The Children Are Watching*. As a result, Jim encouraged me to put together an anthology of some of my most important writings. I agreed, but responded with a hybrid idea: why not turn that anthology into a mini-professional memoir?

In contrast to *Rose Hill*, which focused on my personal and family life, I viewed *Making* as a way of exploring some of the evolution of my thinking about multiculturalism. I selected articles and excerpts that illustrated my professional journey, both what I had published and the circumstances in which those publications occurred. Moreover, the lengthy introductory sections before each selection also contained my reflections on those pieces, including how those experiences had modified my thinking.

I encouraged readers to approach the book in two ways. They could read each introduction and article as a cuplet. They could also read all of the introductory pieces in linear fashion as an episodic sketch of my professional life. In that sense the combined introductions of *Making* became a sort of

mini-version of the professional sketch that you are currently reading, but with a more peripatetic and less coherent story.

My idea worked, sort of. *Making* turned out to be more of an interesting experiment rather than a fully engrossing story. From a genre perspective, it was neither fish nor fowl: not really a professional autobiography but more than an anthology.

Maybe the book reflected my relative youth. I was still only 68 and hadn't yet reached the stage of decade-spanning personal reflection, the kind of reflection that I hope comes through in these pages. At that point I didn't have the thirst to tell my professional story the way I am currently doing.

Anyway, it was done. People interested in my ideas and trajectory could find something in the book. The broader and longer story would have to wait . . . until right now.

Houghton Mifflin Social Studies

Prior to the 2000's I had never been an author of an elementary school social studies series. That situation changed beginning with a 2004 invitation from a long-time friend, Sharryl Hawke, who at that point was a senior consultant for Houghton Mifflin. In particular, she was designing a new K-6 social studies series. Would I be interested in becoming part of the author team? Would I!!!

I joined the team and began to learn the in's and out's of this new (for me) form of textbook publishing. I was not totally without experience in that area. Back in the 1970's I had written a fourth grade California history textbook for Scholastic social studies. In the 1990's I had been a senior consultant for Scott Foresman's integrated language arts series. In the early 2000's I had been a consultant for the McGraw-Hill

elementary social studies series. But this was the first time that I had been a co-author of an entire series (I also worked with McDougal Littell's related 6-8 world history series).

Our author team included specialists in government, economics, geography, and other areas. My role was to focus on history and diversity, for which I wrote a position paper on including diversity themes in the series. Meeting with Sharryl and the other authors on a regular basis was both exciting and creative.

In our roles, the authorial team came up with ideas for the books, read drafts of the huge textbooks, and made copious notes suggesting changes. We authors worked closely with the Houghton Mifflin and McDougal Littell in-house editorial and writing teams. These included myriad grade-level writing specialists who better understood what language could and could not be used for students of different ages.

Then, of course, the authors committed themselves to visiting school districts that were considering or had adopted the series. This meant more travel and more visits to communities that I had only read about (and occasionally I had never heard of). It was a heady few years until ownership changes caused our series to become marginal to the company's overall efforts. So it goes in the textbook business.

Mayor's Multicultural Forum

One final new venture marked the 2000's. It started innocently enough in late 1999 when Riverside Mayor Ronald Loveridge, a long-time friend and UCR political science professor, asked me to do him a favor. Would I be willing to facilitate a gathering of Riverside community leaders to talk

about the rapidly-changing city's growing multiethnic population? His goal was to make Riverside a more inclusive community? I had been trying to build better communities around the country. How could I turn down my own city?

In December, 1999, Ron gathered a group of several dozen community leaders, referring to them as the Mayor's Multicultural Forum. We held a vigorous early morning discussion about the city and agreed to meet again after the beginning of the year. The Mayor also made a proposal: he would like the group to develop a multicultural bill of rights for the city.

Ron's proposal drew a tepid response. Participants seemed to exhibit "rights fatigue", a reluctance to propose yet another set of "rights." However, they did see the importance of addressing community inclusivity, but they wanted to emphasize "responsibilities" rather than "rights." Using "responsibilities" as the launching pad, we held several more meetings to generate ideas and build consensus. Based on participant input I drafted a public statement, "Building a More Inclusive Riverside Community." Each meeting provided critiques of my drafts until, finally, the Forum coalesced around the statement. The final statement was based on three sets of responsibilities for fostering inclusivity: individual; group; and institutional. Ron took it to the City Council, which adopted it.

But there was more to come. Mayor Loveridge was now on a roll. He wanted the meetings to continue to provide ongoing input on diversity-related questions emanating from the community. So the Mayor's Multicultural Forum went on, now open to the general public. It usually met four times a year

from 7:30 to 9 a.m., in the Mayor's Conference Room on the top floor of City Hall.

The Forum was sort of a rump operation. It was not an official city endeavor, but rather the Mayor's personal brainchild and initiative. Many who came to the original December, 1999, gathering dropped out, but others took their place. The Forum never became a formal organization. It had a meeting notification list of those who had been participating, but it was open to the public: sort of an informal, ongoing public town hall. Ron and his successor mayors were active in national gatherings of city leaders, but they never encountered anything else that had our kind of ongoing, informal, and open-to-the-public structure.

I hadn't signed on for the long haul, but inertia took over. Ron asked me to continue as leader of the forum, although I never had an official title since we weren't actually an organization with rules and by-laws. When Ron's successors -- Rusty Bailey and Patricia Lock Dawson -- took over, I suggested that they replace me with someone of their choosing. Both asked me to stay on, which I did until a quarter century later, 2025, when I asked to be replaced (I had turned 91).

If this all sounds sort of loosey-goosey, it certainly was. Our quarterly meetings were casual, conversational, informal, and direct. No rules of order or discussion guidelines. Just show up, think seriously, say your piece, and listen to others.

Forum topics varied. Sometimes we dealt with issues of community climate, the kind of climate aspired to by our Inclusive Community Statement. Other times we dealt with specifics, such as a community incident or an issue that had come up for the City. At times the Mayor would bring up special

personal concerns, asking Forum participants to weigh in on them. And, occasionally, the Mayor would ask us to support projects.

Take, for example, the Grier Pavilion. Our meetings were held in the City Hall's seventh-floor Mayor's Conference Room, which opened out onto an open-air rooftop terrace. One Forum participant, the visionary Sylvia Martin James, came up with the idea of transforming that barren expanse into a space dedicated to diverse Riversiders who had contributed to the development of our community. She also proposed that it be named after two African American community leaders, Barnett and Eleanor Jean Grier.

The Forum supported her proposal and provided input. The City doubled down on the proposal by adding a solar roof, a series of panels that would generate hot water for City Hall. This enabled the City to apply for and receive a California state grant to make this a solar heating demonstration project.

It was a long slog, but Sylvia was a force of nature. Almost single-handedly she refused to let the project die, even when the odds were stacked against her. The Forum provided moral support and some ideas, but it was truly the Sylvia Martin James show. When the Pavilion was completed, the Mayor's office sponsored the performance piece that I wrote about earlier, the one in which I played Eastside Settlement House director Jesse Ybarra.

To this day the Pavilion remains a lovely gathering place as well as an illustration of the power of one, in this case Sylvia Martin James. The Forum was proud to have helped her. In a sense, it was our Inclusive Community Statement come to life.

Ron’s successor, Mayor Rusty Bailey, took things a step further. In 2016 he established an annual Mayor’s diversity award for a community member who had made significant contributions to building a more inclusive Riverside. He asked me if he could use my name for the award: The Dr. Carlos E. Cortés Award. It was an enormous honor. The first award occurred during the Mayor’s State of the City gala event on January 28, 2016.

But maybe that moment signaled that time was marching on. When you start having awards named for you, it sort of suggests that you are part of history. I was 76 when the decade of the 2000’s ended. My mind was still active, but my bones were feeling the years. Maybe the time had come to begin winding down.

Chapter 8

The 2010's: Winding Down

As I entered the 2010's I was sort of on professional auto-pilot. I still enjoyed my on-going roles on various faculties, although I could feel my energy flagging. I was still working with "Dora the Explorer" and its sequels, "Go, Diego, Go!" and "Dora and Friends: Into the City." I was still performing my one-person play, "A Conversation with Alana: One Boy's Multicultural Rite of Passage," ultimately reaching more than 150 performances. I was still coordinating the Mayor's Multicultural Forum. My Rivera Trilogy was still unfolding.

But I felt a growing sense personal fatigue. My physical stamina was beginning to ebb. When it came to my presentations, I was feeling less inspired. And I was noticing an emerging generation gap as increasingly I was presenting to participants the age of my grandchildren. Yet the 2010's demonstrated that there was still something left in the tank, while serendipity remained my constant companion. As a result, winding down was accompanied by four unexpected new ventures.

I edited my first encyclopedia. I published my first book of poetry. I made my Los Angeles stage debut. And I became involved in a project with the Academy of Motion Picture Arts and Sciences.

Multicultural America Encyclopedia

I had dabbled in all kinds of professional nooks and crannies. My publications included books and articles, as well as editing three large reprint series for Arno Press. But there were still publishing adventures that I had not yet taken. For

example, I had never edited an encyclopedia. Nor did I ever expect to.

Then lightning struck in the form of a July 4, 2011, email from a man named Geoffrey Golson. Would I be interested in serving as General Editor of an encyclopedia for his company, Golson Media, which created encyclopedias for various publishers? In this case it would be a four-volume encyclopedia of Multicultural America for Sage.

Our follow-up telephone conversation the next day led to a rapid acceptance. The project was just too intriguing to say no. I looked forward to creating a resource that I could have only dreamed about fifty years earlier.

Editing the encyclopedia turned out to be an enormous, time-consuming, but endlessly fascinating process leading to the publication of *Multicultural America: A Multimedia Encyclopedia* in 2013. I found that editing that encyclopedia was a little bit of this and a whole lot of that. Stage one involved developing the list of 900+ entries to fill four volumes.

While the title of the series was *Multicultural America*, the encyclopedia focused on race and ethnicity. Both Geoff and I were determined that our encyclopedia would not be a rewind of previous efforts, like the *Harvard Encyclopedia of American Ethnic Groups*, for which I had written the entry on Mexican Americans. We wanted entries that reflected both tradition and surprise. We also wanted a unique structure.

Of course there would be the obvious entries. There would be essays on individual ethnic groups. This involved my drawing an arbitrary line between those groups that were included and those small, in some cases tiny, ethnic groups that were not included (we ended up with about 200 ethnic group entries among

the 900+ entries in the encyclopedia). There would also be obvious entries on seminal events and topics in U.S. racial and ethnic history, although this too required making tough decisions about inclusion and exclusion. But what would make our encyclopedia even more unique?

Geoff came up with the splendid idea of leading off the encyclopedia with a section on the U.S. census, including analyses of the just-completed 2010 census. I developed a list of general entries on various aspects of the census. I also chose to include entries on how, over the years, the Census had created and modified the classification, language, and identification process for specific racial and ethnic groups. For example, consider the curious evolution of the way that the U.S. government has categorized and counted Latinos (at one point categorized as WPSS, White People with Spanish Surnames, not to be confused with BPSS, Black People with Spanish Surnames).

I made the case for featuring popular culture, with entries on books, movies, and stage productions that provided illuminating treatment of America's racial and ethnic trajectory. Geoff was all aboard on this. So it was a matter of selecting those entries and getting appropriate writers. Fortunately Geoff assigned an exceptional author manager named Lisbeth Rogers. Lisbeth was responsible for recruiting writers for the various topics (I sent her some suggestions), allowing me to focus on entry content.

One critical decision was that we *would not* include entries on individuals. We had space limitations and ended up with more than 900 entries, even without biographies. Moreover, it would have been a nightmare trying to choose which of the tens of

thousands of significant ethnic individuals should be included or excluded.

We also ventured into the sometimes murky line between ethnicity and religion. Certainly Judaism is a religion, but the Jewish experience in the United States has also been profoundly ethnic. Likewise Muslims, Amish, and certain other religions where people's lived experience was ethnic, including the ways that they were perceived and treated by outsiders. Moreover, some entries examined the intersections of ethnicity and race with other social categories like sex, class, sexual orientation, generations, disability, and gender identity.

For two years I immersed myself in reading and commenting upon entries. It was an eye-opening experience for me and probably a frustrating experience for some of the writers, leading to rejections for those entries that did not adequately deal with their subjects. But ultimately it came together in a lovely four-volume package, made even heartier by a special editor who dealt with the selection of photographs.

In some respects, my four-volume *Multicultural America* (2013) excursion was a perfect career-winding-down project. It drew on my generalist historian's knowledge of the racial and ethnic dimensions of the American past. I could do it in bits and pieces without the challenge of creating the overall narrative coherence necessary for a scholarly book. And it had a finite ending with my reading and commenting on the more than 900 entries.

In terms of my personal scholarly trajectory, editing the encyclopedia also afforded me the opportunity of synthesizing my evolving thinking about diversity. I did so through my 19-manuscript-page introduction. In that essay I addressed such

topics as the decline of the melting pot myth combined with the rise of ethnic pride and the idea of multiculturalism. It also gave me the opportunity to again argue for my concept of multiculturation (multiple acculturation), a multidirectional process of acculturation involving individuals, groups, institutions, and society at large. Finally, I ended the introduction by posing a series of critical questions that needed to be dealt with given the ongoing changes in ethnic diversity.

When I received my copies of the encyclopedia I could only marvel at the product of good teamwork, with readers having no idea of the myriad bumps and grinds in the complicated creation process. I was relieved when the arduous process had ended. But I was also delighted with the result. Now I could turn to other things, having added encyclopedia editorship to my record.

Fourth Quarter

Parallel to my encyclopedia and social studies adventures, I had stumbled into another new writing form. I had previously wandered into playwriting (combined with acting) as an outgrowth of my efforts to create a family chronicle and through my determination to pay tribute to my friend Tomás Rivera. But for the life of me, I don't know why I decided to get involved in writing poetry.

I do recall reading a notice about a multi-week poetry workshop being led by local poet Angela Thomson-Brenchley at a small art store about a mile from my house. Almost on a whim, I decided to give it a try. Angela was patient and at times inspiring. Give it a try. Take a chance. To use an over-used cliché, she was highly supportive.

The last night of our workshop series consisted of a public reading, with each of us intoning one of the poems we had written during the workshop. The collected poems would be published as a small collection for distribution to the participants. It came down to two choices, one safe and guaranteed inoffensive, the other a more edgy poem called "The Candidate."

"The Candidate" drew on a personal experience in which I had shown up at a hotel for a luncheon address, noticed bird-dung on the roof of my car, spit into my right hand, wiped off the dung, and then headed for the hotel bathroom to wash my hands. However, a political candidate whom I knew stopped me in the corridor and, despite my evasive efforts, grabbed my hand for a hearty shake. Then he headed off for the luncheon while I headed for the bathroom.

Trusting Angela, I gave her both poems and asked her to choose which one she thought was better for the occasion. Not until she introduced me as the next reader did I know which poem Angela had chosen. When she announced that I would read a poem entitled "The Candidate," my lot was cast. I read it and it was a hit, with people actually laughing.

From then on it was full steam ahead as I (and Laurel) took a series of creative writing workshops, mainly those sponsored by Inlandia Institute, a Riverside writers collaborative. At times I wrote prose, including excerpts from my novel-in-progress. But mainly I wrote poetry until I had amassed enough to become a book.

In the process I came up with a book concept. I had reached age 75, meaning I was entering the fourth quarter of my prospective 100-year-life. Why not use that moment to reflect?

This led to the title, *Fourth Quarter*, with the sub-title, *Reflections of a Cranky Old Man.* I organized the poems into four perspectives: Looking Back; Looking Out. Looking In (declining bodily functions); and Looking Ahead. I also inserted a three-poem section entitled "Intergenerational Trilogy," in which all three poems were written in a particularly avant garde style: actual rhyme.

My son-in-law Richard Lawton, the person who had suggested using a chair for "A Conversation with Alana," had started his own small press, which he called Bad Knee Press. He offered to publish *Fourth Quarter*. The book came out in 2016.

Almost on a whim, we decided to enter the book in the International Latino Book Awards competition. It fell into the competitive category of English-language poetry. Lo and behold, it received Honorable Mention. So not only did I have a book of poetry, but I had a book of poetry that had won a minor prize.

After that I continued writing poetry, but not with the same zest that led to *Fourth Quarter*. I am still considering compiling a sequel called "Tenth Decade," referring to my perspectives as a nonagenarian. But I haven't yet pulled it off. Maybe later. But first another creative side trip.

"The Shit Show"

Serendipity continued to operate. In this case, my flirtation with poetry led to a most unexpected acting opportunity. It worked out like this.

A public poetry slam was scheduled at UCR. I decided to sign up and read one of my *Fourth Quarter* poems. Then, as I followed online notifications about the upcoming event, I ran across a strange little appeal. As part of the slam, a UCR

graduate student playwright named Leelee Jackson wanted to stage a brief scene from one of her plays and was looking for two actors. She needed a girl to play Little Red Ridinghood and an older man to play the Big Bad Wolf. Well, if I could become Jesse Ybarra, why not the Big Bad Wolf?

I went to Leelee's office and read for the part. She chose me, although in all honesty I don't know if I had any competition. We performed a four-minute excerpt from the piece in which I play the Big Bad Wolf as a dirty old man (typecasting?) who lusts for Little Red Ridinghood but is frustrated by society's new rules that he has to ask her for permission before proceeding. Great fun. But there would be more.

Some time later Leelee contacted me again. She had completed the play, "The Shit Show: An American Allegory," a bawdy interracial satire, and asked if I would like to reprise my role in Los Angeles. But not just the Wolf. Would I be willing to play several small parts, including a slaveowner and a contemporary white racist? Having given workshops and written a long encyclopedia essay on intercultural humor, I was more than intrigued.

Leelee staged "The Shit Show" as a public reading on March 30, 2019, one week before my 85th birthday. It was held on a warm Saturday morning in the small Celebration Theatre just off Santa Monica Boulevard in Los Angeles. I had read the entire play and noted that the N-word was used more than a dozen times. Fortunately, it didn't appear in any of my lines, although one of my characters comes close to saying it, then restrains himself.

It turned out that I was an "only" in the cast. The only reader who was not a professional actor. The only reader who was not Black. The only real amateur in the crowd. The all-purpose White man.

With Laurel and my daughter Alana in the audience, I tried to hold my own with the pros. In any respect, it was a blast. And I had made my Los Angeles acting debut.

(I should add that, at about the same time, I was involved in one other performance piece. Back in the late 1950's Laurel had developed a friendship with famed novelist Raymond Chandler. Respecting the 49-year-old difference in their ages, the courteous Chandler consistently referred to Laurel as "Miss Vermilyea, " her maiden name. Lo and behold, Chandler made "Miss Vermilyea" a character in his final novel, *Playback.* We turned that circumstance into a twenty-minute performance piece, which we presented as a fund-raiser for the Riverside Public Library.)

And the Oscar Goes to . . .

"The Shit Show" was great fun, although it didn't lead to acting accolades. No offers for movie roles and therefore no shot at an Oscar. But I did get an offer from the Academy of Motion Picture Arts and Sciences. Yes, THE Academy.

The offer started with a telephone call from an old friend from 1970s' Chicano conference days, the brilliant Latina film director Lourdes Portillo. At one of those conferences Lourdes had screened a scene from her feature film "Después del Terremoto," a scene that illustrated her imagination, artistry, and daring. Later she had gone on to a distinguished,

award-winning career focused on documentaries, including "The Mothers of Plaza de Mayo."

Lourdes and I had not talked in years, so her call came as an absolute surprise. Even more surprising was her message. She was involved in a major project for the Motion Picture Academy and asked if I would like to serve on the advisory committee. She didn't have to twist my arm.

The Academy project was part of an enormous venture entitled Pacific Standard Time: LA/LA, Latin American and Latino Art in LA, sponsored by The Getty and Bank of America. The project, which involved some seventy institutions, was scheduled to take place in 2016 and 2017 throughout Southern California. The Academy had received a grant to pursue a series of ventures related to Latinos and film. They were now in the early stages of planning.

Serving on the advisory committee involved a series of trips into Los Angeles for meetings. As much as I had grown to detest driving into Los Angeles, I felt a true sense of excitement as I headed into the city for our first meeting on May 16, 2014. I would be going to a meeting in THE Academy.

Actually we met in the old May Company Building on the corner of Wilshire Boulevard and Fairfax Avenue. It was all torn up, being remodeled to become the Academy Museum of Motion Pictures, which would open in 2021. No matter. I was working with the Academy.

The project went off in multiple directions. This included a series of interviews with Latino film luminaries throughout the hemisphere conducted by Lourdes and project director Ellen Harrington. Our committee provided advice on those to be chosen, as well as counsel on other project dimensions.

Providing advice for the Academy seemed like a great follow-up to my work with Nickelodeon.

But my role turned out to go beyond giving advice. The Academy planned to produce a book about Latinos and film. The book, *From Latin America to Hollywood: Latino Film Culture in Los Angeles 1967-2017*, was published in 2017. They asked me to write one of the chapters on a topic of my choosing.

I was intrigued by the lengthy recorded interviews. In particular, I became fascinated by the fact that three of the interviews were with prominent U.S. Latinos: Edward James Olmos; Luís Valdez; and Gregory Nava. I decided to build my essay around an analysis of those three multi-hour interviews.

I viewed this as an opportunity to tie together diverse strands of my career, from multicultural education through the societal curriculum to Latinos in film. Here were three Latino film luminaries who personified my idea of the multicultural societal curriculum. By creating alternative film "textbooks," they had helped "educate" the viewing public about the Latino experience in the United States. I pursued that image with my chapter title, "Latino Filmmakers as Multicultural Educators."

To approach the project, I delved deeply into their multi-hour reflective interviews. Those interviews provided copious examples of my idea of the societal curriculum. As I wrote in my article, "these three filmmakers have been acutely aware of their pedagogical function. That is, they attempted to use their feature films to try to teach, thereby influencing the public image of Latinos. . . . these three have tended to view themselves more specifically as revisionist historians, intercultural anthropologists, civic values inculcators, and educational reformers." I documented my analysis with selections from their interviews.

Shortly after the book's publication, I had an opportunity to meet Edward James Olmos at a public screening of a modernized version of Robert Young's film, "The Ballad of Gregorio Cortez" (no relationship to me, to the best of my knowledge). Olmos thanked me for the article and signed the book. Later that night, seated in the bar of Riverside's Mission Inn, Olmos and I watched the Los Angeles Dodgers lose to the Houston Astros in a world series game later revealed to have been stained by Astro sign-stealing.

Diversity and Free Speech

So this is what professional winding down amounts to. Writing a book of poetry. Playing the Big Bad Wolf. Hanging out at the Motion Picture Academy. And don't forget that I co-wrote and produced a musical as well as continuing to perform my one-person play and teach at institutions around the country. This was my kind of decade.

But there would be more. In November, 2017, I ran across a call for proposals for a new University of California entity: the UC National Center for Free Speech and Civic Engagement. UC was looking for applicants to become inaugural fellows of the Center.

At my age, I had pretty much given up applying for things. I had grown weary of starting new ventures. Moreover, application processes had become more and more complex and burdensome. But not this one. It was simplicity personified. Basically it asked for a 500-page personal description and brief project outline. Great! Brevity is right down my alley.

The Center description triggered something that had increasingly been bothering, particularly as I observed changes

within the diversity movement. Since my high school days I had been a firm supporter of free speech, freedom of the press, and freedom of religion. As a senior at Cal and chair of the Cal Student Publications Board I had even given a speech on these freedoms as part of a major public ceremony honoring the UC president. These freedoms were part of my DNA.

But also firmly entrenched in my psyche was my support for diversity, including all of its verbal knockoffs like inclusivity, equity, and social justice. Since the late 1960's these ideas had been a driving force for my life. They, too, had become part of my DNA.

Therefore, it was with some dismay that I watched a growing segment of diversity supporters becoming opponents of free speech. Maybe not in so many words, but in practice. It was part of the process I described in my section on the 1980's. For example, some critical race theorists had come out publicly with their opposition to freedom of speech. Advocates of therapeutic diversity were becoming increasingly restrictive on speech through the spawning of equity language lists and microaggression mania. Even some diversity managers had begun to incorporate speech restrictions in their efforts.

Not that they didn't have a point. Language equity is an important issue. It had been since the 1960's. I clearly recall the day in the 1970's when a female department head stormed out of a college meeting when the man facilitating the gathering repeatedly and over her objections continuously referred to her as "madam chairman." She finally returned when he promised to stop referring to her that way.

The noble pursuit of language equity continues to the present. Creators of language equity lists have at times made

valuable and overdue suggestions about how to improve language use. Yet over time those language lists were becoming increasingly absurd, filled with imagined insults, convoluted alternatives, and ominous implied threats against those who did not adhere to the list.

Maybe most disturbing was the rise of such concepts as microaggressions. A perfectly useful and illuminating concept in its early formulations, microaggressions were accompanying language equity lists on the road into absurdity. In particular was a ten-point microaggression list formulated by psychologist Derald Wing Sue. As the basis for exploratory discussions, Sue's list serves as a useful tool for analysis. Unfortunately some of Sue's disciples had mindlessly transformed it into a dogmatic set of punishable no-no's.

Consider that the first item on Sue's list was the question, "Where are you from?" Sue's valid point was that some questioners refuse to accept the original answers to that question and instead challenge the respondents, "But where are you *really* from?," implying that the original answer was a smokescreen. One common example was refusing to accept an Asian American's answer that she was from San Antonio since she must *really* be from somewhere like Singapore, Shanghai, or Seoul.

The obvious lesson to be learned from Sue's list is that if you ask someone where they're from, accept their answer. Full stop. But that wasn't sufficient for microaggression hardliners. Some insisted that the only way to avoid that secondary possibility was to refrain from asking anyone where they were from. In other words, don't just throw out the bathwater, toss out the baby, too. And if someone should ask you the original question, look upon them negatively as

"othering." (Such microaggression mania clashes with the interculturalist principle that you should show interest in a person's background. My response has been to suggest that organizations have "Where are you from?" days to encourage interest in each other.)

I should add that I have not been alone in standing apart from and criticizing some of the ideas emanating from what one might call the current diversity establishment. Such authors as Musa Al-Gharbi (*We Have Never Been Woke*) and Olufemi O. Taiwo (*Elite Capture*) have weighed in with pro-diversity critiques of some of the directions that elements of the diversity movement have taken. In particular they have criticized the overemphasis on the purification of elite spaces.

My concern for such developments within the diversity movement (although certainly not the totality of the movement) led me to the question: through what historical process has the tension between diversity and free speech developed? I applied to investigate that topic, then immediately forgot about the application. Then, in January, 2018, while Laurel and I were cruising past Antarctica, I received an email that my proposal had been accepted and I had become part of the Center's first national cohort of some dozen fellows.

It was a prophetic moment for me. At 84, with my lecturing career winding down, I had latched onto a topic that fascinated me. Since 2018 I have immersed myself in the topic with the goal of completing a book manuscript on the historical trajectory of the diversity-speech relationship. Twice I thought I had the book framed properly, but in both cases the rapidly changing times rendered the last part of the book outdated. Just the diversity-related and speech-related actions

of the Trump administration in 2025 have forced me to recast multiple chapters to avoid completing a book already doomed to be placed in a time capsule. With some luck, the project will still see the light of day. In any case, drafts of my book are part of my special collection public papers.

As the 2010's wound down I was savoring a graceful voyage into my career twilight. The major exception was my diversity-and-speech book. My adjunct days had pretty much come to an end (the 2020 arrival of COVID would guarantee that). Nickelodeon was no longer making "Dora" or "Diego" episodes (there would later be a reboot in a different format by a younger team). But I now had a fascinating new research project to keep the juices flowing as my clock ran down. It felt good to finally be retiring. How wrong that prognostication turned out to be.

Chapter 9:
The 2020's: Zombie Time

On April 6, 2020, I turned 86 years of age. Particularly with COVID having halted most of my professional travel, I assumed that the winding down 2010's would become the wrapping it up 2020's. Except that's not what happened. In fact, like a good zombie I found myself springing back into action.

The 2020's have become a surprising decade of professional renewal. Some of this has involved ventures into new areas. In other respects it has come in the form of re-engaging my professional past, particularly the big three areas of the 1970's: ethnic studies; multicultural education; and bilingual education. At times that re-engagement has involved challenging both changes in those fields and my thinking about them.

Harold Bloom once wrote, "It's hard to go on living without some hope of encountering the extraordinary." Even with the inevitable growing fatigue of age, maybe I was still driven by the pursuit of the extraordinary. But I'm getting ahead of myself. Back to basics.

My 2020's actually got a running start in 2019 due to two occurrences. First, I discovered or was discovered by American Diversity Report. Second, I was drawn back into ethnic studies via a state of California controversy.

American Diversity Report

I can't recall how I "discovered" American Diversity Report or how ADR discovered me. In any respect, we found each other. By 2019 I was writing a monthly column for this national ezine.

This was thefourth of that decade's column-writing ventures. I had written a few online columns for an organization known as OrgSync, a higher education student affairs support entity. In 2013 and 2014 I had written about a dozen English-language columns for Univision, the huge Spanish language television network. Maybe most significantly, I (along with my wife, Laurel) had become occasional newspaper columnists for a series on writing coordinated by Inlandia Institute and published weekly (every Sunday) by the Riverside Press-Enterprise and other associated dailies throughout southern California. To date, I have written about three dozen columns over the past decade.

Then I encountered American Diversity Report, a fine little monthly ezine emanating from Chattanooga, Tennessee, and run by a visionary editor named Deborah Levine. By 2019 I had begun writing a regular monthly column for her ezine. She liked the column well enough that she made it the lead item in the ezine.

At first I focused my columns on the topic of diversity and speech, since I was deeply engaged in the topic. In reality, however, the columns went well beyond those narrow confines to explore a variety diversity-related topics, although speech was generally connected in some way. It was a liberating experience that allowed me to reflect on the topic of diversity from a variety of perspectives.

Then, in 2024, Donald Trump was elected President. Diversity, particular DEI, found itself in Trump's crosshairs. Could diversity survive the onslaught? My answer was yes, but only if the diversity movement as a whole and individual elements of the movement took a good look in the mirror and thought seriously about a deep and honest renewal.

I suggested to Debra that we change the theme of my column from Diversity and Speech to Renewing Diversity. She fully supported the idea. I was off on a new adventure, an adventure fueled in part by other factors that had come crashing unexpectedly into my professional life.

California Ethnic Studies

Almost simultaneous with my American Diversity Report connection came a singular 2019 event that supercharged my 2020's. I well remember the day the day that my former student, long-time friend, and then California state assemblyman José Medina reached out to me. José had been one of my earliest students at UCR (my wife actually hired him to be a student assistant in the Casa Hispánica, a Spanish-based living-learning unit of the UCR residence halls).

José needed my help. Now. Please call. I did. I can't recall the exact details of the phone call. However, between a series of calls, emails, and a bit of digging, I learned the essence of his dilemma. It went something like this.

José had proposed a bill mandating ethnic studies as a California statewide high school graduation requirement (he was a former high school Chicano Studies teacher). At about the same time, the state legislature had passed a different bill instructing the state Department of Education to develop an ethnic studies model curriculum. The two bills were not legally connected except for the fact that José's bill specified that the new model curriculum would serve as one option for school districts to use in implementing his bill.

The state Department of Education formed a task force to draw up an ethnic studies model curriculum. I vaguely recall

seeing an application notice for serving on the task force. I thought about it for a few seconds, then quickly realized that I lacked both the energy and the interest in serving.

The 18-member task force (officially known as the History-Social Science Subject Matter Committee, sometimes referred to as the Ethnic Studies Model Curriculum Advisory Group) met a number of times, creating a May 16, 2019, draft of the model curriculum. By state law, the draft was posted online for public comment. By the time of José's phone call, the draft had received 21,000 responses, more than any other model curriculum draft in state history. 3,000 of the responses supported the draft; 18,000 opposed it.

Some of José's legislative compatriots had made it clear. They would not vote for his bill until the model curriculum was significantly revised. The state board of education, which seemed supportive of the Medina bill, had fallen into a state of paralysis, unsure of how to address the stand-off between the determined model curriculum task force, overwhelming public expression of opposition, and resulting legislative hesitance.

José's request: could I help him rescue his bill? More specifically, would I be willing to talk to Linda Darling-Hammond, an old friend of mine and chair of the state Board of Education to see what might be done? I had not been in the least bit involved in the growing controversy, but I wanted to help José. So I called Linda.

Linda's question was more strategic. Could I think of a way to address the impasse? I gave a simple answer. The situation needed a third perspective, not some mushy middle ground or a massaging of the original model curriculum draft. But where should that third perspective come from? I suggested

that the state recruit an outside expert to provide some basic ethnic studies guidelines as the framework for further discussion. I actually gave her a few names to consider. There was a long silence, hinting at what was coming next. "Carlos, would you be willing to write such a set of guidelines?"

Having wound down my professional life to one all-absorbing project, this was not a detour this 85-year-old wanted. The easiest and maybe the wisest thing to say was "no." However, I didn't want to let José down. Moreover, I saw bridge-building ethnic studies as an opportunity to foster intergroup understanding and greater insight into the American journey. After a brief moment of contemplation, I said yes.

I knew the ramifications of my decision. I told Linda that no matter what I wrote I would be painting a public target on my back because my position paper would not please the task force members, their supporters, or their critics. I would not write a hit piece on the model curriculum draft nor would I ride to its defense. Rather I would write an alternative view, which the state could consider as it moved ahead.

Once I returned from my family gathering, my position paper became the focus of my attention. I carefully assessed the Ethnic Studies task force draft that had generated so much controversy. And I immersed myself in the 21,000 public comments that had been posted by that time. (Full disclosure: I did not read all 21,000 of them. Many of them were repetitions of form letters submitted by myriad individuals.).

My conclusion was this. The publicly-exhibited Model Curriculum draft was not a good document, but it contained worthwhile elements. It proposed ideas that deserved inclusion in ethnic studies courses and indeed had been themes since the

1960's, when I first got involved in the field. However, the document buried these good ideas in a hyperbolic ideological framework using esoteric jargon that failed the basic test of a good public document: present a clear explanation in publicly-accessible language that can be understood and supported by ordinary Californians of varying backgrounds. (The state had charged the task force with making the report accessible to multiple audiences.) Instead the document emerged as an echo chamber treatise that seemed to be written for those in faculty lounges.

As I waded through the 21,000 posted responses, patterns took shape. Supporters lauded the draft, accused critics of nefarious thoughts, and plastered them with labels ranging from racist to neoliberal. Critics seemed to fall mainly into three camps:

***those who claimed that they supported the general idea of ethnic studies but disliked the approach taken in the model curriculum draft.

***self-appointed spokespeople for groups who felt excluded from or improperly treated in the draft.

***and, of course, those whose vitriol suggested that they basically detested the idea of seeing people of color become a greater part of the high school curriculum.

Within a few weeks I had drawn up my "Ethnic Studies Graduation Requirement: Suggested Basic Curriculum Principles." It consisted of eight general principles that high schools could use to organize and implement an ethnic studies requirement. I voiced neither support nor explicit criticism of the task force report itself. Rather I offered an alternative perspective on viewing the topic, while incorporating some of the points made

by the task force. On September 17, 2019, I submitted my first version to the State.

As for painting a target on my back, my premonition had been correct. I caught hell for it from multiple directions. I caught hell from authors and supporters of the original Task Force draft for being a turn-coat against ethnic studies. I caught hell from critics of the original draft because I had not explicitly lambasted it. I caught hell from others because I did not champion the inclusion of their specific ethnic groups. I had made the latter decision on purpose, since I was seeking to establish a common ground, not litigate the specifics of what ethnic groups should be included and how.

So be it. I then circulated my draft to colleagues around the country and held meetings with community groups to get their feedback, particularly as to the clarity of my proposal (a place where the original report had failed badly). On June 26, 2020, I submitted my sixth and final draft.

Question: was the effort worth my time? I can't say for sure. In the short run, certainly. The state incorporated a slightly-modified version of my eight principles in the opening chapter of the final version of the Ethnic Studies Model Curriculum. The state legislature ultimately approved the Medina bill and, after one gubernatorial veto demanding more changes in the model curriculum, Governor Gavin Newsom signed it. I have no hard evidence concerning the role that my Eight Principles played. However, Representative José Medina indicated to me that he had used my document to garner support for the bill. And the California Latino Legislative Caucus did not revoke the Latino Spirit Award the Caucus had bestowed on me in a Sacramento public ceremony on May 6, 2019.

At that point I bowed out of what would become an ongoing conflict among those with different positions on ethnic studies. Was it a constructive venture? Should it be required? If so, how should the requirement be fulfilled? What about content and pedagogy? What further role should the state play? I had little interest in continuing in the fray.

Then, in 2024, the Riverside County Office of Education invited me to be a plenary speaker at the first of its series of ethnic studies implementation conferences. I would be paired with my UCR School of Education colleague and friend Joseph Kahne. I said yes and in preparation for the conference I found myself re-entering what had become a contentious and sometimes bitter statewide struggle.

In preparation for the first conference and drawing on my half century of diversity-related experience, I came up with a concise student-centered framework for ethnic studies. I called it the I/You/We Framework. Conceptually the framework was simple.

Teachers should select a series of ethnicity-related topics and address each topic from three perspectives. I: how have I and my group (family, community, ethnic group) experienced that topic? You: how have other groups, including those reflected by my fellow students, experienced that topic? We: how have We as a nation experienced that topic?

With I/You/We displayed horizontally across the top of the matrix, three other categories were displayed vertically: Past, Present, and Future. How did that topic play out in the past, where do things stand in the present, and how can we build a more constructive future? The result was a matrix of nine cells generated by the intersection of the three horizontal (I/You/We)

and three vertical (Past/Present/Future) themes. Easy to remember, convenient to draw on, and available to consider while assessing student learning.

Beginning with the Riverside County conference. I presented my matrix at other conferences around the state. Some school districts have drawn on it to inform their ethnic studies approaches. Once again, mission accomplished. However, the statewide controversy goes on.

Then Along Came COVID

The 2019 Ethnic Studies sidetrip was a time-limited interlude, although I stayed marginally involved in the statewide process. 2020 would have a much greater long term impact on my professional journey. It came in the form of COVID.

At first COVID meant a slew of cancellations of live presentations. Maybe most significantly, COVID wiped out a planned Viking cruise on which I was to lecture. The cruise had a marvelous three-week roundtrip itinerary out of San Juan, Puerto Rico. First we would cruise south through the Caribbean (including a stop at Devil's Island, which had secured a bizarre place on my bucket list). Then it would be up the Amazon River to Manaus, where Laurel and I could visit the famous Opera House (another of my I'd-like-to-see's). Finally would come a return trip down the Amazon and stopping at additional Caribbean ports.

This would be an ideal follow-up to my previous cruise lecturing venture: a two-week roundtrip out of Istanbul with visits to Ephesus, Athens, and numerous Greek islands, including our favorite, Santorini. I had developed a series of lectures on such intercultural topics as Gestures, Time, and

Interpersonal Space, so I was ready to rumble. But COVID arrived and the cruise was canceled.

However, along with talk cancellations came something unexpected: feelers to see if I would be willing to adapt my presentations by using zoom. This raised the question: what is zoom? I had heard the word, but that was about the limit of my knowledge. Now I was being asked to actually use it professionally.

Fortune struck in the person of my friend and UCR History Department colleague Juliette Levy. I happened to mention my dilemma to her. No problem. She would teach me zoom, which she did with patience and graciousness. I was back in the game. In fact, I grew to love the ability to remain active professionally without having to travel, which was becoming increasingly onerous. Getting up in the middle of the night to catch 6 a.m. flights out of Ontario Airport had lost its charm.

I adapted quickly to this new style of teaching and living. Soon I was speaking across the country and around the world without leaving home. Now this is the way to wind down!

The Aftermath of George Floyd I: Anti-Racism Statement

Then occurred the second major happening of 2020. In May, 2020, came the Minneapolis police killing of an African American man named George Floyd. It quickly became an epic scandal with national ramifications. In my case, it soon led to two professional ventures.

George Floyd's death coincided with a changing of the guard in Riverside government. Mayor Rusty Bailey was stepping down, to be succeeded by Patricia Lock Dawson. But being a lame duck didn't slow Rusty down. In fact, he decided on a last hurrah

involving me and the Mayor's Multicultural Forum, which I had been facilitating since 1999.

On June 11, 2020, the Forum held its first-ever zoom meeting with remarks by Rusty, Riverside Chief of Police Larry González, and Fair Housing Project Director Rose Mayes to discuss the city's response to Floyd's death. On June 30, the Riverside City Council adopted a resolution declaring racism to be a public health crisis. Rusty took it from there.

He told me that he would like Riverside to take the lead by developing an Anti-Racism Vision Statement. He asked me to facilitate the process through the Mayor's Multicultural Forum. We didn't have much time (the Riverside Inclusive Community Statement had required nearly two years to complete). Rusty would need to propose the statement to the City Council for a vote at its October 20 meeting. This meant we had to get down to business.

On August 13, 2020, the Forum met again via zoom. The Mayor sent out a public invitation to attend the meeting to develop ideas for the statement. Dozens of Riverside residents showed up.

For ninety minutes I took notes as residents presented their ideas. By the time the meeting ended, I had plenty of material. My challenge was to put it into a form that was concise and to the point. And, by the way, the statement would have to be adopted by an ideologically-varied, seven-person City Council in the middle of an election season.

Following the Forum meeting we had six weeks to create the anti-racism statement. There was no time to go through the cumbersome process of forming a writing sub-committee and holding multiple Forum meetings. Instead Rusty and I opted for

a full-speed-ahead approach. Based on ideas generated at the Forum meeting, I composed a statement draft, circulated it online among Forum attendees and others whom Rusty might add, gave them three days to provide feedback, and then revised the statement. I repeated this process several times before the Forum met again on September 24 to review the final draft.

Writing the draft turned out to be one of the most challenging tasks of my entire professional career. I was working with comments and suggestions from myriad Riverside residents with strong, sometimes conflicting opinions. There were even disagreements over the title of the statement (a few opposed including "anti-racism" in the title). There was disagreement over the meaning of anti-racism and whether or not we should adopt some expert's definition (we developed out own definition in terse, basic language and quoted nobody throughout the document). There was a split between structuralists (anti-racism begins by looking at institutions and practices) and hearts-and-minders (anti-racism begin by focusing on individual attitudes). There were some who wanted to include jargon, but I opted to make the document simple, direct, and non-jargony.

As I moved from draft to draft, I tried to be inclusive, incorporating multiple perspectives while still melding them into a strong core of ideas. In the process I may have alienated some people who wanted their ideas to reign supreme, as well as those who wanted to include quotations from this expert or that, a strategy I unilaterally rejected. I was the one who would have to present our case to the City Council, and I didn't want to be put on the defensive trying to justify some

outsider's assertions. I wanted our statement to reflect the words and ideas of Riverside residents.

The process was direct, straight-ahead, and lightning-quick. By the time the Forum met again by zoom six weeks later, we had a nearly final document. The meeting led to a few cosmetic changes. Not an established organization but rather a kind of open town hall, the Forum had no voting procedures, so there was no official way to adopt the draft. The Forum was the Mayor's unofficial baby. So, on zoom, I turned to the Mayor and asked the simple question: Rusty, are you happy with this document? He was. Statement adopted.

Sure enough, when the City Council met on October 20, 2020, council members voiced varying opinions. One of the council members, Chuck Conder, asked me directly (and courteously) if our statement was based on Critical Race Theory. Since I had strategically (and unilaterally) rejected the idea of drawing on external documents or quoting outside experts, I could answer quite honestly that the statement was a direct expression of Riverside residents. Rusty and I hoped that we could get a majority vote in favor of the statement. In fact, the motion passed by a 6-to-1 vote, with only Chuck Conder opposed.

But that wasn't the end of the story. The *Los Angeles Times* picked up on our action and ran a front-section feature story on Rusty's (and the Forum's) achievement. We also heard from other communities, some incredulous that we could pull off this feat so quickly and effectively. Whatever, Riverside had staked out a position. Although I would continue as Forum chair until 2025, the Anti-Racism Vision Statement remains the capstone of my twenty-five years in that unofficial position.

Aftermath of George Floyd II: UCR School of Medicine

Writing the Riverside Anti-Racism Vision Statement was a brief, intense experience. The second impact of the killing of George Floyd turned out to be complex and ongoing. It was also very surprising, since it involved the UCR School of Medicine (commonly referred to as SOM).

SOM was a unique institution. It began in 1974 as a joint program of UCR and the UCLA School of Medicine. A select number of students would pursue a UCR degree in Biomedical Sciences and, at a certain point, would become eligible to apply for transfer to UCLA for the remainder of their medical education.

Four decades later, in 2013, the UCR program evolved into a free-standing campus medical school. It began with forty students. In addition, the Division of Biomedical Sciences continued with its own Ph.D. program, while providing basic science courses for medical school students. Each year the medical school expanded its curriculum. The death of George Floyd galvanized SOM into creating a health equity thrust, which it named Health Equity, Social Justice, and Anti-Racism (HESJAR).

So what trail led me into becoming part of HESJAR? Somewhere in the past, probably in the 1980's when I was spreading my wings into multiple areas, I had begun giving talks and workshops on the topics of cultural competence and of diversity and health. I recall speaking at some health care conferences, even spending a few days doing a multicultural workshop for a nursing school in El Paso, Texas (the first time I ate Cajun blackened redfish) and giving a series of cultural competence workshops for the San Bernardino County Department of Behavioral Health. I even gave a well-attended public lecture

at Houston's M. D. Anderson Hospital, where my mother had gone for lung cancer treatment.

Shortly after UCR's School of Medicine opened, I was asked to give a two-hour presentation on health care cultural competence to first-year medical students. It went well enough that SOM invited me back for reprises until 2020, when George Floyd's death upped the ante. In July of that year I received an email from the academic dean about the school's new HESJAR curricular track. Would I be willing to help? When I answered yes, the dean responded with an offer: would I come out of retirement and serve as part-time co-director of the new curriculum, which at that point did not exist.

In my long history of unexpected opportunities and surprising offers, this one ranks near the top. Here I was, at age 86, being asked to take charge of a medical school curriculum even though I was not a physician. Here I was being handed a six-word title and tasked with building a curriculum around it. Here I was being asked to help the School deal with a delicate topic in a super-heated national environment. In my long list of learning curves, this one might be the steepest.

But I couldn't say no. Here was an opportunity to build an important curriculum from scratch. It was an unforeseen opportunity to improve the lives of under-served and ill-served patients. At the tail-end of my professional life, here was the possibility of making a real, tangible difference for marginalized communities.

Things moved quickly. For my co-director, the dean selected a fine young Ghanaian pediatrics professor named Adwoa Osei. It could not have been a better choice. Adwoa turned out to be a dream to work with.

Jointly we decided that we needed a year to conceive, construct, and launch the curriculum. It became a year of reading medical literature, attending medical conferences, and examining health equity approaches used on other campuses throughout the country. We also decided we needed to listen to the community, so we held a year-long series of public gatherings involving students, faculty, and of course community informants. By the end of the year, we felt ready to transform study into action.

Adwoa and I launched the HESJAR curriculum in the fall of 2021. It consisted of a series of two-hour modules on various topics related to health equity, social justice, and anti-racism. Since then we have massaged, fine tuned, and expanded our vistas. Given the limited number of class hours each year (8-12), we decided that we needed a focus. We chose patient care: how to apply diversity thinking to diagnostics, communication, interpersonal relations, dealing with diverse families, and addressing divergent community experiences. In addition, we wrote a series of joint-authored American Diversity Report columns documenting and reflecting on the development of our curriculum.

In the spring of 2025, the fifth year of HESJAR, Adwoa was promoted to an administrative position. Having just turned 91 and with upcoming prostate surgery, I sensed that this was the moment to step away and let others take over the HESJAR leadership. However, the dean asked me to stay on for at least one more year to help the new co-director get started. At this point I plan to make this my last year, although my career has taught me to expect the unexpected.

Adventures in Chronologyland

There was one more professional offspring of COVID. For a number of years Laurel and I had benefited from taking creative writing workshops through Inlandia Institute, but we were wearying of the repetition. With the shift of all Inlandia workshops to zoom, we decided to bail out. But Inlandia had other ideas. Thus came the offer: would I be willing to teach (not just participate in) a zoom-based creative writing workshop?

Let's make it simple. I am not a creative writing teacher. I lack the skills, background, or interest in teaching writing. So what could I do? Well, I am a historian. I had written a memoir and a one-person play about growing up. Maybe I could put together a class drawing on historical perspectives on one's personal life.

This soon resulted in the working title for the class: Adventures in Chronologyland. I would build the course around personal chronology, which each participant would create. Then at each subsequent class I would provide an interpretive angle for bringing chronologies to life. Angles would be drawn from history, literature, and sometimes film. The idea was to challenge participants to rethink their lives using different perspectives and writing challenges.

The standard Inlandia in-person format was two-hour sessions. Typically the teacher introduces a topic and provides a writing prompt. In response, participants write in class and then share their writing in small groups or with the entire class. While that structure generally works when all were gathered in a room, in zoom sessions it turned out to be distancing. As I put together the course, I decided that this

format was misuse of time: having participants sit around in their homes writing at the same time.

So I proposed an alternative framework. Each session would be one hour, in which participants would read brief excerpts from their writing assignments. I would conclude each session by framing the assignment for the next class. Participants could choose their own time to write and come to class ready to read.

The format worked. The class started with several dozen participants, mainly from the Inland Empire, but also a few elsewhere. Ultimately some dropped out, but those who remained grew into a real online community. So when my class ended, participants wanted to keep going.

Inlandia asked me if I would repeat the course. My answer was a firm no. I had found the process intriguing, but also fatiguing. I didn't feel like starting from scratch with a new bunch and I sensed that I lacked the imagination and energy to keep coming up with new ideas on a bi-weekly basis for the returnees.

So we came up with another alternative structure. Those who wanted to continue with Chronologyland would meet once every three months. My format would remain the same: participants would have three minutes to read excerpts from their writing and I would present a new writing challenge for their next Chronologyland assignment.

The result: we have become a community. Approximately a dozen adults, many in their golden years, coming together once every three months for an hour of sharing and camaraderie. The metric for success: this has been going on for five years and

the regulars keep returning. That's all the feedback that I need.

New Adventures in the Arts

Being asked to co-direct a medical school curricular thread and to teach a creative writing course were not quite what I envisioned as part of closing up shop in the 2020's. But there were two more intriguing invitations. First, I was asked to serve as the Consulting Humanist for the opening exhibit of Riverside's Cheech Marín Center for Chicano Art and Culture. This included conducting two hour-long taped interviews with Cheech and with the de la Torre brothers, who created the museum's signature art piece, a mesmerizing lenticular tower that greets visitors as they enter the building.

Then, for the first time, I was asked to become a consultant for a major motion picture. In this case, it was an animated feature film. The offer came from DreamWorks. Here's the background.

When the Nickelodeon series "Dora and Friends: Into the City" came to an end during the previous decade, I had assumed that my adventures in animation had come to an end. I was correct, with one major exception. One of Dora's creators, Valerie Walsh Valdez, and her husband Leslie had come up with the idea for a new Nickelodeon series, "Santiago of the Seas." I signed on as Creative/Cultural Advisor. The series produced a handful of episodes and then it was over.

A few years later Nickelodeon decided to reboot "Dora the Explorer" in a different and shorter format. At first Chris Gifford, Mariana Díaz-Wionczek, and the old Dora team, including me, were involved. But Nickelodeon finally decided that it

wanted fresher, meaning younger, thinking. I don't know about freshness, but I haven't been getting any younger.

Given what had happened at Nickelodeon I was surprised -- make that shocked -- when I was approached by DreamWorks. Once again, previous accomplishments triggered this stroke of luck. Teri Weiss, a former Nickelodeon executive, was now at Dreamworks (she became Executive Vice President of Television Development). Teri and I had worked together at Nickelodeon, she was familiar with *The Children Are Watching,* and she had observed my contributions to "Dora" and "Diego." When Dreamworks decided to make "Puss in Boots: The Last Wish," she recommended me to the movie's executive team as a possible consultant. From that sequence came the offer.

The "Puss in Boots" experience was both fascinating and exciting. As I did with Nickelodeon, I signed a non-disclosure agreement concerning my activities. Therefore there's not much I can tell you. Let's just say that I became deeply involved with the movie, including numerous zoom meetings with the show's creative team and my providing responses to various iterations of the film. I loved the results, including my first three-line movie credit for a feature film as the final credits scrolled down. So this is what it's like to be approaching 90.

Teachers Pay Teachers

Quite unexpectedly, other opportunities began arriving from multiple directions. In some respects they led to the way to new adventures. In other respects they drew upon elements of my past.

More than four decades earlier I had come up with the idea of the societal curriculum. This, in turn, led to years of

media research and the year 2000 publication of *The Children Are Watching.* Then, in 2022, I was approached by the organization Teachers Pay Teachers to serve on its Content Moderation Advisory Board.

When I began my media research, the internet as we know it today did not exist. In fact, the penultimate chapter of *The Children Are Watching* was a late add-on. I entitled it "Multicultural Education in the Cyberspace Era." In retrospect, the chapter isn't bad despite not being overly visionary.

Since the publication of that book, the flood of internet material, including a deluge of hate speech, has raised the issue of restricting online content. This in turn has led to efforts at content moderation of inappropriate (whatever that means) content. Entities like Facebook and Twitter have experimented with various approaches to content moderation. Teachers Pay Teachers proposed to do the same thing.

Content moderation is distinct from pre-publication censorship. In a content moderation system, material may be displayed but retroactively taken down if it doesn't meet what has become known as "community standards." The trick is enunciating those standards with precision, coming up with guidelines for implementing those standards, and training people to consistently apply those standards for displayed material.

Teachers Pay Teachers (TPT) was a company based on teachers uploading classroom materials that they had developed for sale to other teachers. In turn, these other teachers would pay for the right to use those materials. Uploading teachers would receive the bulk of the payments, with TPT taking a percentage for providing the platform for the exchange. In many respects it was a superb win-win situation.

This is where content moderation was involved. By law TPT could not prevent material from being posted. However, by law it could *remove* material that it felt did not meet TPT community standards. That's where the advisory board came in.

The board's role was to help the TPT team conceptualize, design, and apply a set of community standards, particularly where diversity issues were involved. My media writing marked me as someone who could bring a special perspective to the process. It also gave me the opportunity to apply some of the analysis I had been doing for my project as a fellow of the UC National Center for Free Speech and Civic Engagement.

During 2022 and 2023 the task force met several times at the TPT headquarters in New York City. The sessions were rousing, revealing, and challenging, although I can't reveal details because of my non-disclosure agreement. For my National Center project I had written about content moderation. With TPT I reversed my role. I and the others were actually attempting to navigate the real-world complexities of content moderation. It was much like my 2000 switch from being a media critic to becoming a member of the "Dora the Explorer" team.

Then, in 2023, TPT was bought by another company. The task force was eliminated. My content adventure came to an abrupt end.

Intercultural Legacy Project

My next project lasted a bit longer. Remember that back in the early 1990's I had stumbled into the relatively obscure field of intercultural communication, leading to my multi-decade sojourn of teaching at the Summer Institute for Intercultural Communication. Now, thirty years later, a pair of editors

decided to launch an autobiographical project involving what they dubbed to be pioneers of the field. They tapped me as one of those pioneers.

I hardly consider myself to be an intercultural pioneer. More like a late comer. Maybe my two decades of teaching at SIIC had earned me that status. Whatever, I agreed to write an autobiographical essay describing my foray into the area of interculturalism.

It turned to be a fabulous project. Guided by interculturalist editors Sandy Fowler and Daniel Cantor Yalowitz, the "pioneers" (all except me in their 80's or late 70's) met regularly via zoom for some two years to discuss the project and get feedback on their essays. It amounted to a crash course on the history of interculturalism, as some of the other pioneers had etched accomplishments that were truly stunning. I was delighted that my essay -- "From Neo-Oedipus to Dora the Explorer: A Me-to-We Journey" -- ended up in such honorable company.

Bilingual Education Redux

My past keeps revisiting me, like something out of "A Christmas Carol." California Assembly Member José Medina had drawn me back into ethnic studies with his request for me to try to help him pass his California ethnic studies high school graduation requirement. Then Jan Gustafson-Corea, the recently-retired executive director of the California Association for Bilingual Education (CABE), yanked me back into bilingual education. This request would have three dimensions.

First Jan asked me to be interviewed for a short film she was making about the founding and history of CABE to help

commemorate fifty years of the organization. Back in 1975 I had helped organize the first California statewide bilingual education conference, which was held at UCR. It turns out that the UCR conference had served as the ground from which CABE had sprung. Would I be willing to be filmed talking about my role in putting on the conference? Fifty-year old events are not the easiest to recall, but I agreed to give it a try. The interview took place at the Riverside County Office of Education in the fall of 2024. A snippet from the interview became part of the film that was shown at the March, 2025, CABE statewide conference.

But Jan was also involved in another film, this one being conceived, filmed, and edited by a Dallas educational media company. The topic of this film was the development of the field of bilingual education. Would I be willing to talk about my role in writing the book, *Beyond Language: Social and Cultural Factors in the Education of Language Minority Students*? In particular, would I talk about how I came up with my Contextual Interaction Model that had become so influential in the field? This hour-long interview took place in Santa Monica. While the film is still a work in progress, selections were shown at the 2025 CABE conference, including parts of my interview.

Then came the 2025 CABE conference itself. Would I be willing to participate in the conference and, as it turned out, receive a CABE Legacy Award for my role in the 1975 founding conference? So in late March of 2025, just before I turned 91, I found myself going to CABE, receiving the award, and speaking in three different sessions: a revisiting of the 1975 conference; a showing of parts of the historical documentary on

bilingual education with a follow-up panel in which I participated; and a packed session on the implementation of the statewide ethnic studies requirement.

For a nonagenarian, it was a bit overwhelming to suddenly be recognized for contributions to fields in which I considered myself only a marginal player. Yet it was also a revelation about life. Sometimes you do little things that turn out to be big things, plant seeds that grow into major crops, and propose ideas that straddle time. In my nineties, am I still sending messages to the future?

Multicultural Education Redux

The answer to that question may be embedded in my response to a final request from a friend. This one involved multicultural education and my long-time friend H. Prentice Baptiste, who along with Jim Banks had been a multi-decade leader in the field. It also involved what may have been the most challenging of all my 2020s'requests.

Jim Banks had been scheduled to give a Saturday morning keynote address at the National Association for Multicultural Education conference in Anaheim. However, Jim had been in a serious automobile accident, which prevented him from flying. So Prentice called and asked if I would fill in for Jim, particularly since I was already scheduled to do a break-out session that day on the implementation of California's ethnic studies requirement.

Prentice's call came on Tuesday. The keynote would be on Saturday morning. That gave me three days to write a 45-minute keynote address, a much tighter window than Riverside's

Anti-Racism Vision Statement. At least I didn't have to get it approved by a committee.

I could have patched together old multicultural education truisms and personal reminiscences. However, something told me that this was an opportunity to do something more substantive. Whatever, I saw this as an opportunity to lay down my marker for the future.

Over the past decade in particular I had developed concerns about the directions that the diversity movement was taking, including multicultural education. My recent journeys into the areas of interculturalism, free speech, the California ethnic studies requirement, and column writing for American Diversity Report had complicated my thinking. So I decided to let it all hang out.

The result was my keynote address, "Renewing Multicultural Education: An Ancient Mariner's Manifesto," delivered on November 16, 2024, at the NAME conference. I complimented multicultural educators for their significant contributions and, in truth, there have been many. But I also pointed out what I labeled as bad habits that some multicultural educators had fallen into and suggested steps that they could take for renewal, the underlying theme of my Ameican Diversity Report columns.

It was not a speech intended to please everyone, and it didn't. Some people came up to me afterward with criticisms. Others, however, thanked me for saying things that needed to be said. Then there was more. Before the day had ended, Prentice and the editor of NAME's signature publication, *Multicultural Perspectives*, approached me with an idea. What if NAME published a special fall, 2025, issue of the journal featuring

my keynote address followed by responses by other multicultural educators? NAME was overdue for such a soul-searching renewal conversation. Maybe this was a way of generating that conversation. I agreed. At this moment, the article is in page-proof form and is due to be published before the end of 2025.

Let's Hear It from the Old Man

Rather than the closing down 2020's that I expected, the decade had become absurdly busy. It was as if turning 90 had profoundly altered my image. When I was in my 80's, speaking and writing invitations seemed to come with an asterisk: we'd like to hear what you have to say *even though* you're awfully old. As I approached and entered my 90's, it was more like we want to hear what you have to say *because* you're old. If you've made it this far and still have your senses, you must be doing something right. Let's hear about it.

Hear about what? That was one of my biggest surprises as I reviewed papers for delivery to the library. Over the years I seem to have spoken on just about everything related to diversity. Well, maybe not everything, but about so many topics that it makes my head spin. I found one complete file drawer jammed with old public lectures stretching back to the early 1970's. Those talks -- some in full text, others in outline form -- are part of my library collection. The titles alone blew my mind. Did I really agree to talk about that? I wonder what I had to say?

Many of those talks were rooted in the 1980's, the decade when I began to spread my multicultural wings and move beyond education. Ironically, some of that sense of lecturing

adventure has been resurrected in the 2020's, with one major change. During the last two decades of the 20th century I was so busy speaking that I seldom had the opportunity to write out the full text of my talks. I was comfortable speaking from dense outlines, so that most of my talks from that era are in outline form. With fewer talks today, I have turned to writing out full texts. This makes the process more relaxing and, moreover, I can quickly turn them into publishable form.

Some of the recent titles reflect my increasing iconoclasm combined with a desire to provide a few minor shocks. Take, for example, the fifteen-minute keynote address I was asked to give at the November 29, 2021, retreat of UCR's Division of Biomedical Sciences. My charge was to talk about anything you want, but please try to make it interesting. So I ended up with a talk entitled "No, Life Doesn't Have to Suck: Five Things You Can Do to Keep That from Happening." I came up with the title months in advance without thinking about content. As the talk date became closer, I had to come up with five things. I did.

And the Winner Is . . .

Continued invitations to write, speak, and collaborate reinforced the idea that I had done some things right in my career. Here I was in my 90's still being recognized. Each recognition served as further impetus to keep on keeping on. Not that I was a super-star in the world of awards.

Along the way I had picked up a few awards for books and articles. Also UCR campus recognition via the 1976 Distinguished Teaching Award, the 1992 Faculty Public Service Award, and the 2004 Emeritus Faculty Award. Add to that numerous invitations to give commencement addresses as well as

receiving two honorary doctorates, in 2007 from the College of Wooster (Ohio) and in 2010 from Depaul University (Chicago).

More eclectic were awards for my forays into multiculturalism and diversity. In 1980, the California Council for the Humanities selected me for its Distinguished California Humanist Award. In 1982, my home town, Kansas City, Missouri, awarded me the Keys to the City. In 1989, my high school chose me for its Distinguished Alumni Award and the American Society for Training and Development named me its Multicultural Trainer of the Year. In 1993-1994 the Smithsonian Institution appointed me a Public Lecturer. In 2001, the National Association of Student Personnel Administrators selected me for its Outstanding Contribution to Higher Education Award. However, four awards stand out in my memory, the last coming in the 2020's.

In 2009, I received an Image Award from the National Association for the Advancement of Colored People for my work on "Dora the Explorer" and "Go, Diego, Go!" Not quite an Oscar, but mightily appreciated. It sits prominently in my campus office and will be part of my collection.

In 2016, the City of Riverside established the Carlos E. Cortés Diversity and Inclusion Award. It is given to a local resident who has made outstanding contributions in that area. I became part of the annual presentation ceremony at the Riverside Convention Center as part of the Mayor's State of the City Address event.

Shortly after that, the University of California, Riverside, named me the Edward A Dickson Emeritus Professor. That honor came through a highly competitive process involving faculty retirees from across campus. It has become a permanent part of my digital signature.

Then came the big prize: the University of California's Constantine Panunzio Award. This is a major annual University of California systemwide competition. Each campus nominates a retired professor in the arts, humanities, or social sciences who has made major contributions after retirement. One or two professors are selected for the systemwide award.

In preparing my papers, I ran across correspondence nominating me twice as the UCR candidate. The first nomination came in 2003, with my friend and colleague Derickson Brinkerhoff (Music) writing a fine letter of support, backed by letters he collected from across the country. Let's make it short. I did not win. That was no surprise, since nobody from UCR had ever won the vigorously contested award.

A few years later Douglas Mitchell (Education) and Rusty Russell (Sociology), then the heads of the UCR Emeriti Association, approached me to be their candidate again. Doug and Rusty were friends of mine. I didn't want them to waste their valuable time, particularly since my first candidacy came up short, so at first I demurred. But Doug was insistent and persuasive. He felt I would be a strong candidate.

So I agreed to be a candidate, although I cautioned Doug when he asked me to provide him with a list of experts who best knew his career. I responded almost cavalierly that nobody (including me) had a full knowledge of my disparate and sometimes chaotic career. I had done so many things in so many varied areas. People I worked with knew only bits and pieces of my career. None had any real sense of my professional life writ large.

Doug was undeterred. He gathered letters from a list of people I furnished him. Then he and Rusty composed what must

have been a formidable letter, transforming the disparate evidence into a compelling argument that convinced the selection committee. The result was that in 2021 the University of California selected me as the recipient of the Constantine Panunzio Award. Hats off to Doug and Rusty. The selection made me the only UCR professor ever to make the Panunzio list.

There is one caveat. Although I am the only UCR-labeled professor on the Panunzio list, there are two other *former* UCR professors who made the list as representatives of other UC campuses. Ironically both were also connected with the UCR History department. First came Robert Hine, the History chair who hired me back in 1967. Bob later retired from UCR, moved to a seniors complex near UC Irvine, and obtained a retiree appointment with the UCI History department, which nominated him, so he is credited to UC Irvine on the Panunzio list. Then came Brian Copenhaver, who served for several years as UCR's Dean of Humanities, Arts, and Social Sciences and held an appointment in History. Copenhaver later moved to UCLA, so he joined the Panunzio list as a UCLA retiree.

Still Cranking

That brings me to my 2020's writing. This era has turned out to be a period of book-length writing, with my end-of-life efforts involving disparate formats. Let's take it from the top with four major examples.

Of course, there is the document that you are currently reading. Partly it is the professional memoir that I had never written or intended to write. It is also partly a context-setting guide to the papers I will be giving to UCR Special Collections. Finally it includes personal reflections

on a professional life that I am rediscovering and re-assessing even as I write this document and rummage through my materials.

I'm not certain how this one may end up. I may stop with this document, a sort of helping hand for the curator who organizes my papers, a context-setting guide for those using my papers, and a very personal excursion into the past half century for those who simply want a glimpse of diversityworld's trajectory as refracted by my career. Or I may decide to adapt it into a real book. At this point I'm not sure, partly because I've got so many other big projects. Let's take them in order of completion.

Turning 90 Isn't a Stroll in the Park

In April of 2023, over lunch on the patio of Riverside's Mission Inn, my daughter Alana asked me what I was going to do special for my 90th birthday the following April. "As little as possible," I responded with my best imitation Ebeneezer Scrooge voice. As I get older, the more I detest birthdays with duty-driven phone calls and off-key versions of "Happy Birthday." I have assiduously avoided birthday parties, which seem like opening acts for the Elephant Man with the incessant question, "How does it feel to be turning _____?"

But Alana was determined and proposed the next question: what will it take to get you to come to your 90th birthday party? I pondered that existential question, then came up with an impossible demand. I'll come if you make a movie about my life so that I can just kick back and enjoy it. A celebration of life while I've still got life.

Deal, Alana announced. Game on. One year later we celebrated my birthday (actually one year and one week later so

that we could hold it on the top floor of the nearby Pechanga Casino Hotel). It was a fabulous event, coordinated by Alana and our five granddaughters. Alana's movie, composed heavily of interviews with family members and professional colleagues, turned out to be a masterpiece.

But no good deed goes unpunished. I said yes to the celebration so that I could kick back and enjoy it. But granddaughter Kai Winters decided to make me work for it. She signed me up for a year of Storyworth, an online autobiographical service. Each week my grandkids would choose a question from Storyworth's list (or sometimes make up their own), Storyworth would send it to me, and I would write an answer. At the end of the year the questions and my mini-essay answers would be put together in a book format as a remembrance of turning 90.

At first I wrote relatively straightforward answers to straightforward questions. "What was life like in the 60's?" "What was your Mom like when you were a child?" "What was your first big trip?"

Then came a question that changed the nature of the project: "What advice would you give your 20 year old self?" Give advice to my younger self? To answer that question, I first had to revisit my twenty-year-old self to see where I stood in my life's journey.

It turns out that 1954 (I turned twenty on April 6 of that year) was probably the most traumatic year of my life. I was flitting from one major to another. I had my first truly serious female relationship (we broke up by the end of the year). My parents separated (they got back together before the year was out).

So the 89-year-old Carlos counseled the 20-year-old Carlos about how to deal with life. Nothing particularly profound. In fact, I concluded the essay by referring to what I wrote as "a cluster of trite pieces of advice." But I was off to the races. From that point forward, I seasoned weekly narratives with touches of cross-generational counsel.

Simple questions now set me off on contemplative excursions. "What are some of your favorite smells, and why?" Rather than listing odors, I took my grandkids on a Willy Wonka-like journey through my various senses. How the decline of one sense (my hearing) intersected with the regaining of another sense (cataract removal and the insertion of tri-optic lenses so that I now read, write, and drive without glasses). Focus on appreciating what you still have even as you lose some of what you previously had.

"What is the best job you've ever had?" prompted a discourse on how you should try to find value in every job as much as you may dislike it. I illustrated that idea by describing a number of my jobs, complete with what I gained from each one. This culminated with my post-university-retirement adventures as an independent public lecturer, where I learned the true meaning of liberation: "No bosses, no employees."

Some of the questions challenged my judgment. "If you could travel back in time to any country and any era, knowing you'd be completely safe and could come back, where and when would you go?" Reluctantly I eschewed exotic adventures into distant times and places. Instead I opted for the 1930's so that I could observe my parents as they met, courted, got married, and had their two sons. I would love to accompany them in order to view and reflect on their turbulent journey:

marrying across ethnic and religious boundaries back when this was rare; dealing with family opposition on both sides; and raising me in the midst of the Great Depression.

After I had finished all of the mini-essays, I reorganized them in a somewhat chronological, somewhat thematic format for more coherent reading. The result was both a collection of memory-driven stories and a kind of ethical will, sharing my unrequested advice across generations. The final version was published in June, 2025, with the title, *Carlos E. Cortés: Backing into the Future at 90*, *April 6, 2024,* even though I had actually turned 91 by the time it was completed and the final version was printed in July, 2025.

Scouts' Honor

The first two writing projects – the library guide and the Storyworth collection of essays – were based on documents and memory. The third writing project was fiction, my first novel, although it drew in part on my memories of growing up in Kansas City. It was entitled *Scouts' Honor.*

Unlike the exploratory library guide and the question-driven, birthday-based Storyworth collection, *Scouts' Honor* had a decades-long gestation period. It drew on my memories of being a Boy Scout, particularly my five years of attending scout camp, two-week sojourns in the rugged hills of southwestern Missouri from 1947 through 1951. For the most part the novel was invention, but it incorporated some actual events that I had experienced. Invention included the shocking death of a 14-year-old scout camper that propels the was-it-accidental-or-was-he-killed-and-if-so-by-whom plot. The book is a mystery surrounded by a maybe-cover-up and an

exploration of the distortions of perspective, the elusiveness of memory, and the complexities of truth.

Over a number of years I wrote multiple drafts but had not yet decided whether or not to try to publish the book. Then, as so often throughout my life, luck intervened. For some time I had regularly enjoyed Thai lunches with my friend and UCR French professor colleague Ben Stoltzfus. He asked me to write an endorsement for his forthcoming novel, *Dumpster*. He mentioned that it was being published by 39 West Press in Kansas City, Missouri.

The press's location was just too serendipitous. I asked Ben if he thought that 39 West might be interested in my "Scouts' Honor" manuscript, since it was set in western Missouri, including Kaioga City, my fictionalized adaptation of Kansas City. Ben said it was worth a try and gave me the name of the publisher, j.d. tullock.

In August, 2018, I wrote him and struck pay dirt. j.d. took an interest in the manuscript. We met for a lengthy coffee meetings during my next trip to visit family in Kansas City. From then on we corresponded and met during my Kansas City sojourns.

j.d. turned out to be a fabulous editor, both insightful and laudably merciless. Endowed with an encyclopedic knowledge of literature, he scrupulously pointed out weaknesses in my manuscript and provided superb advice for strengthening the book, necessitating more drafts. Unfortunately, before a final decision could be made on whether or not he would publish "Scouts' Honor," personal circumstances caused the press to halt the publication of any more books.

At that point I was deluged with projects, so I set the novel aside, figuring it might never be published. A few years later I noticed that Riverside's Inlandia Institute -- the one for which I was teaching Adventures in Chronologyland -- was open for blind submissions of creative works. Well, nothing ventured, nothing gained. I removed my name from the manuscript and submitted it. It was a joyous moment when I learned that the manuscript had been accepted.

Accepted but not yet completed. Cati Porter, the savvy Inlandia director, took charge of the project and gave me additional suggestions for improvement, which meant another rewrite. Then there was the book production, with a fabulous cover designed by my granddaughter Amaya Lawton (Alana's daughter), an accomplished artist who graduated in 2025 from California State University, Northridge, with a degree in anthropology.

Scouts' Honor was published in August, 2025. With that event I joined the small cohort of American nonagenarian first-time published novelists. So far I have had two delightful book launches, one in which my artist granddaughter Amaya participated.

Diversity and Speech

This brings me to my final book-length project of the 2020's: my magnum opus (maybe) on the historical relationship of diversity and speech. I had begun this exploration back in 2018 as an inaugural fellow of the University of California National Center for Free Speech and Civic Engagement. My hope was to complete a book within a few years. Yet here it is, seven years later, and I am still struggling with it.

Twice I have come close to completing it. Then along came events that transformed my concluding chapters into hanging chads. I had to rethink my conclusion, which also forced me to go through the entire manuscript to make certain that my diversity-speech historical narrative was not out of synch with the new conclusion.

My basic formulation was iconoclastic. I suggested that the imperatives of diversity and speech necessarily clashed. However, rather than this being an aberration from the supposed American free speech tradition, as I had hypothesized in my fellowship proposal, I concluded that anti-speech actions taken by diversity advocates fit quite comfortably into the long American tradition of restricting speech, a pattern that has metastasized under the second Trump administration.

In other words, freedom of speech was not the American historical norm, with asterisks for a few minor restrictions such as libel and slander. Rather the United States had established a long tradition of restricting speech, with civil libertarians struggling mightily against this tradition, particularly by drawing on the First Amendment. In other words, the American speech trajectory has been of robustness, but never actually freedom. Moreover, the extent and nature of that robustness has varied over time. Within that framework, the efforts of many diversity advocates to restrict speech has been as American as apple pie.

In my first conclusion, I projected the future relationship of diversity and speech as one in which the imperatives of diversity and speech would necessarily clash. Civil libertarians would continue to struggle for more robust speech with fewer restrictions. Diversity advocates would continue to

raise a values challenge and, in some cases, would actually advocate for more restrictions. As a civil libertarian and also champion of diversity values, I argued that many diversity advocates had gone way too far in a counter-productive effort to cleanse the linguistic environment. The future would involve an ongoing balancing of the two vital societal imperatives of inclusive diversity and robust speech.

However, about the time that I completed my first conclusion, the anti-woke movement was rearing its head, particularly in places like Florida and Texas. Moreover, the anti-woke movement was going for the daily double. Not only did anti-wokers oppose gains made by the diversity movement, they did so by brutally restricting speech, including speech emanating from the increasingly beleaguered defenders of academic freedom, an increasingly fragile concept.

With that in mind, I reframed my book. Moving away from the diversity-speech polarity, I posited a three-cornered battlefield with pro-diversity, pro-free speech, and anti-diversity, anti-speech (ADAS) forces in triangular combat. Moreover, in contrast to diversity advocates who relied mainly on soft restraints to restrict speech, ADAS warriors brought to bear the full power of government to quash both diversity and speech.

Finally came the 2024 election of President Donald Trump. Upon taking office, he launched a full-scale frontal attack on decades of diversity gains. In doing so, the restriction of speech and other forms of expression became a primary strategy. The Trump administration targeted both diversity and speech, two for the price of one. That new dimension of the story meant that I needed to further re-massage my conclusion (as well as

some of the earlier chapters) to address this dramatic change in the national terrain.

So where does that leave me? On the one hand, the completion of my book-length Storyworth sort of ethical will and the publication of *Scouts' Honor* gives me more time to organize my professional papers, revise this document, and complete my diversity-and-speech book. On the other hand, I'm older and tiring. Do I have the time, energy, and will to complete these goals, including the publication of my diversity-and-speech career capper? Or will I have to be content with leaving drafts of the book in my library collection? Personal longevity may make that decision.

Learning to Be Lucky

That's my journey. Lessons learned? Somewhere along the way in my more-than-ninety-years on earth, I came to the conclusion that success in life depends upon three factors of varying importance.

First, you need some natural ability: mental ability; physical ability; and/or emotional ability. Second, you need to be willing to work hard, very hard, work-your-butt-off hard. Third, and finally, part of success involves blind luck: being in the right place at the right time under the right conditions with the right people and with the right willingness to take risks.

Once I developed that three-part framework for success, I began using it in advising others. I used that aphorism in rearing my children and grandchildren. I drew on it when counseling students or mentoring young professionals. I even developed a workshop entitled "Learning to Be Lucky," in which I

provide ideas of how to draw on your natural ability and your hard work to create conditions in which luck is more likely to occur.

I've been lucky. Make that very lucky. My career narrative illustrates that. But I've also put in the effort to do something with my native ability. I hope that this narrative provides some insight into how that has all played out, as reflected in the papers that I am donating to the UCR Library Special Collections. I also hope that those papers help provide insight into the turbulent half-century plus that ensued after my arrival at UCR in December, 1967.

I started at UCR at a time of momentous social upheaval. I finish my career at a time of heightened social polarization. As I look back over the past nearly six decades, I ask myself the question: have my efforts in championing bridge-building multiculturalism actually made a difference? Have I been part of a process that has made America a more enlightened, equitable, and inclusive place? Has the diversity movement left an indelible societal mark so deeply ingrained that it will survive current and future assaults?

Being an optimistic skeptic (not a cynic), I still believer in an affirmative answer to these questions. Future history may provide other answers, while those who use my papers will need to assess my role in our nation's (and the world's) ongoing trajectory. I hope that this extended essay with its reflections on the past six decades contributes to your assessment. In any respect, I have very much enjoyed writing it.

Postscript: Collection List

January 19, 2026

Books and published articles (2 bookcases, including the 106 volumes of my three edited Arno Press collections and my three co-authored K-12 textbook series)
Book projects (2 file drawers, including "The Bent Cross"; "The Hollywood Feature Film Curriculum on Race and Ethnicity"; "Diversity and Speech"; and "Los Corteses: A California Saga")
Articles (1 file drawer)
Columns, blogs, and book reviews (1 file drawer)
Movies, videotapes, audiotapes, and awards (l bookcase -- public lectures, performances, and educational videotapes in which I have been involved)
Lectures and workshops (1 file drawer)
Theatre, performances, and media projects (1 file drawer)
Chronological envelopes of public lectures (l bookcase)
University of California and University of California, Riverside records and course lectures (1 file drawer)
Méjico através de los siglos (five-volume family heirloom)
Miscellaneous material (2 file drawers, 1 flash drive, and selected email)